Go Squad

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Book One

Review Copy

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Go Squad · Book 1

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Chapter 1

Caledonia at night.

"Good evening and welcome to Carl Tucker Tonight."

One of the largest metropolises in the country.

"Caledonia is the third biggest city in the United States. Millions of people live here."

Home to the feared and revered vigilantes, the only team to patrol a major city at night, protecting its citizens from misdeeds, transgressions, delinquency, and general . . . malfeasance? Felonies and villainy were more of a professional law enforcement type deal, especially considering what counted as felonies and villainy to the Caledonia Police.

Possession, no matter how much, felony. Loitering, no matter that curfews being unconstitutional, villainy. Probable cause, basically whatever they felt it was, grounds for search and seizure.

They were all about the neighborhood and making sure the denizens of Caledonia felt safe, often from the uniformed sentinels immune to true justice.

The Go Squad were hardly ever caught on camera, any phone footage usually being too dark or blurry to be definitively anything other than outlandish claims for viral attention . . . or conjecture of the viewer who wanted to believe in something more. Anytime they saw themselves in any uploads or mentioned as part of the criminal element in the mainstream news, that's what they were called.

The first such broadcast—an excited social media influencer posting shaky phone footage—called them heroes. Said they appeared from nowhere, stopped a mugging, vanished like ghosts. She'd coined a name for them: The Go Squad. "Because they GO when nobody else will," she'd explained to her growing follower count, hashtagging every post. #GoSquad. #CaledoniaHeroes. #WhereIsGoSquad.

Firas hated it. Hated giving what they did a name, a brand, a power he wasn't willing to acknowledge. They were supposed to be shadows, rumors, figments of overactive imaginations. To his chagrin, the rest of the team loved the moniker and adopted it for their unofficial outfit. Someone was posting their exploits for thousands to see, turning them into a movement.

He'd argued against it during team meetings. "We're supposed to be secret." But the others disagreed: people needed to see someone was fighting back. Hope mattered, even if it came with hashtags.

"For a hundred and fifty years, it has been the hub of American commerce. If any one place can say that they helped build this country, it's Caledonia. So we should care what happens here. Unfortunately, what's happening now in Caledonia is almost all bad. In fact, it's a disaster. Crime has been never higher. Arrest rates have skyrocketed. Our fine boys in blue are being pushed to the very ends of their abilities to enforce law and order in this, our city, no more than in the inner city. What's happened to our beautiful Caledonia when our mothers and children can't walk the streets

without some gangbanger threatening to bust a ca . . .”

Firas pushed the home button on his phone, pulled the ski mask over his face and smelled the night air. He always wished he had some enhanced sense so he could sniff out a lead or hear the cries for help a mile away and dole out justice. He had to make do with his normal nose but really mostly relied on his police scanner he bought at a pawn shop.

“This is Rogue leader. Radio check-check, cop-copy,” Firas said into a handheld ham radio as he squeezed the call button on its side.

“Reading you five-by-five, Rogue leader,” the voice crackled back. “What’s your twenty?”

Firas loved radio jargon. He demanded that they all learn the codes that were standard for all ham radio users. The Go Squad were originally miffed they had homework but eventually appreciated how frickin’ cool they felt when they expertly asked each other where or how they were using jargon instead of speaking as they would on a regular phone call.

“I’m on the rooftop on State and Telegraph. Any action on the waves tonight?”

“Affirmative,” the voice replied. “Radio band talk of an increase in burglary and muggings in the Little Poland neighborhood. Could be worth a patrol.”

Firas grinned, his pulse quickening with anticipation. “Loud copy,” he said, then secured the radio onto his belt.

Bolting in the direction leading to Little Poland, which was a good 30 blocks away from where he was, he knew there would be a few gaps between buildings that were tougher than others. He almost loved this part as much as taking on a mugger.

He reached a door vestibule and performed a wall run on its side, going into a kong vault, safety rolling over the industrial air conditioner, then fell down half a story to the landing below. He strode onto the next building over an alley, executed a lache from a scaffolding, diveroll over a stack of lumber from the construction being done on the roof and full sprinted to the building’s ledge before doing a safety landing onto the building across the alleyway that was a story lower.

He knew this terrain intimately, had come to familiarize himself for years during his freerunning training he began when he was a young boy. Doing this blindfolded would be something he knew he could do if he had to, knowing better of course than to actually try. That was strictly reserved for practicing with the others within the confines of the training facility, someone always watching unobstructed and spotting for safety.

His heart raced but he wasn’t winded. The excitement to find some action coursed through his veins. Within seven minutes’ time, Firas had reached the center of Little Poland, a neighborhood with a four block radius, and as the name would suggest, a place where you can find the best pierogies in the city. During the day, Firas often came here for lunch while working at the Parkour Instructional School that he owned, where he started patrol this night. He would even take this route across the rooftops to get here, for practice and for fun.

Breathing heavily, he unclipped his radio and crackled it to life. “This is Rogue leader,” he announced, “I’m in position.”

“Record time, Rogue leader,” the radio responded. “You in some kind of mood tonight?”

“Just feeling it tonight, I guess,” he replied.

“Hang tight,” the radio spoke. “Just throw a line in the pond and wait for the nibbles. I’m sure something will come along. A nearby benefit event is just ending.”

“What’s the event?” he asked.

“Some campaign stop for a politician. What do you care, Rogue leader?”

“Just wanted to know the type of crowd to expect.”

Firas slumped down on the edge of the building and peered out into the street. Just like Batman, he thought. Or Daredevil. Probably more Daredevil than Batman. No, he decided and thought, I’m my own identity. I have none. That’s what separates me from those comic book heroes. I’m real. I’m wearing nondescript tactical body armor, pants, utility belt, Lycra ski mask and gloves. All black. No cape. There’s no distinguishing marks on me. I’m a shadow. Hey, that could be a good superhero name. No, no name. I’m not ‘Shadow,’ that’s not my name either. I’m just me and nobody will know that. The people will either be saved by me or feel the pain of street justice, depending on which side of the line they are standing.

All the same, he liked to imagine this is what Batman or Daredevil experienced on patrol.

A woman screamed. He snapped to standing, listening for the direction.

“Leave me alone!” The cry came from the distance.

Hearing where it was generally coming from, Firas dove down below to the fire escape he was standing above and shimmied down the side of it as quickly as he could. When he landed on the street, he sprinted to where the crime was taking place. Running past an alleyway, he stopped and hid behind the corner of the building. Three men were surrounding a terrified woman.

Perfect, he thought. He unclipped his radio and reported, “This is Rogue leader, assault in progress. Alley of Renata’s Bakery on Grand. Engaging hostiles, over.”

“Copy. Be careful, leader,” the radio acknowledged.

Firas crouched and went around the corner to hide behind a dumpster. He could hear them taunting the woman.

“Come on,” a devious voice urged. “We won’t bite unless we have to. Just give us what you got.”

In moments like this, and this was his 64th such engagement since he started doing patrols if his counting was right, he remembered how bad his legs shook the first time. He nearly vibrated on the floor like an electronic tabletop football piece as he yelled timidly at the baddies. This time, it was only a mild shake that he used as a reminder that it was time to get down to business.

The three men were cornering the woman and her face was awash with fear.

“Okay,” the voice continued. “Have it your way.”

The lead goon shrugged, smiled and stepped towards her to put his hand on her shoulder. The woman, terrified, screamed until Firas appeared behind him.

“This ain’t Burger King,” he blurted.

The lead goon stopped in place like a record scratch and he and the other two turned to face Firas.

“What?” the goon asked.

Darn it, Firas thought. “You know. You said, ‘Have it your way,’” he badly imitated. “So I said, Burger King because . . . nevermind,” he entreated before following up with a devastating elbow shiver across his face that floored the goon standing in front of him. Left and right goon jumped back in surprise, left goon bailing and out of the alley, right goon swinging a hook that Firas ducked under before rising up with an uppercut to his chin, knocking the goon off his feet half a foot into the air before crashing down to the pavement.

Standing with his two open hands ready in front of his face, ready to parry another attack, Firas checked to see if anyone was getting up to try again. They were scrambling away and were out of sight in seconds. The woman that was being accosted, stunned, slowly regained composure.

“Th . . . thank you,” she said, gratefully.

“Don’t thank me,” Firas responded with his back turned to her so she could not see his eyes. “Just . . . do me a favor and don’t tell anyone I said ‘This ain’t Burger King,’ and we’re even.”

“Uh . . . okay?” the woman uttered.

“What’s that?” Firas gestured behind her. The moment she turned to face the direction, he dashed down the alleyway into the darkness and dove behind a nearby dumpster. She saw nothing, and when she looked back, Firas was nowhere either.

She checked in with herself to make certain whether that bizarre encounter actually occurred or if she was dreaming. It was unfortunate enough to be mugged. To be saved by a masked vigilante was implausible. She wondered if that was actually a thing that happened in real life as she walked back to the sidewalk to reenter reality.

Once she was out of sight, Firas peeked his head from behind the dumpster to make sure no one was around to see him reemerge from the shadows. He dusted off his hands and nodded in self-approval for another job well done. Citizen saved, mystique aura preserved, no credit taken. He’d sleep well this night.

He always wondered how the ninjas and Batman did it in the movies, just disappear after the hero act was done. He considered magician smoke bombs but even then, where does one go? This part of the job was always pretty awkward, so he found it best to avoid it whenever possible, perform an Irish exit with side of made-you-look.

“Come in, leader,” the radio crackled.

Firas popped the radio into his hand and brought it to his face. “Go for Rogue leader,” he chirped cheerfully.

“Status?” the radio requested.

“Justice has been meted,” he bragged.

“Say again?” the radio said. “Justice has been what, over?”

“Meted,” Firas repeated. “Justice’s been meted.”

“You mean ‘met’?”

“No, ‘meted.’ Look it up,” he flared, squeezing the radio in his hand.

The talking part of hero business was really the actual hard part.

“Okay, ‘meted,’ copy that, boss. I’ll just assume you mean you’re okay.”

“More than,” he assured.

“Great. Good job, leader. As for me, I just helped an old lady get her cat down from a really high telephone pole. I’m going to call it a night,” the radio informed.

“You’ve earned it, Nightingale,” Firas said.

“Nice work tonight, Firas,” the Nightingale said.

Firas rolled his eyes, saying, “No first names over comms.” So unprofessional.

“Don’t forget about our dinner plans tonight. No body armor,” she said.

“Aright, aright,” Firas said, getting embarrassed. “See you there.”

“Signing off,” the voice said. “No better place.”

“No better time,” Firas responded, letting go of the call button. A moment later, he squeezed it and added, “Thanks, Ruth.”

Chapter 2

They didn't often allow their children to accompany them on their excavations.

Normally, it would have been out of the question with the nature of their work. The various situations they would find themselves in, political sensitivities to maneuver, local customs that frowned upon the inclusion of children, and school schedules and a sense of normalcy to uphold all precluded bringing the whole family on work trips. This one, though, was in the States and during the weekend.

Mr. Faraz Bacchus and Mrs. Naima Bacchus, ancient art and antique specialists and collectors, were more likely to be gone for days, sometimes weeks at a time, usually in remote corners of the Earth after receiving a tip from researchers or their connections in the military about possible locations of rare treasures, "treasures" at least among the niche demographic of those enamored with these trinkets and chairs no one could sit in anymore.

Ahdia and Firas were ecstatic to have the opportunity to tag along because for the first eight and six years of their lives, respectively, they were always left behind with a nanny or dropped off at a childcare in a military complex of which apparently their parents had connections to be able to do so. Neither had any personal military background to speak of so it was of mild curiosity to them how their parents were involved but, as with all things that were since birth, it was the way things were. What was explained to them by their parents was that some of the travels they engaged in required more than the usual considerations of typical globetrotters. Sometimes, to enter nations with frosty or hostile relations with the United States, it required a heavier authorization than simply receiving the necessary vaccinations or permissions from the embassy located stateside.

They were heading for Glacial National Park in Montana. First they flew from their home in the Caledonian suburbs and then drove a rather large truck that the U.S. Army conveniently provided, very much presented, as though the military personnel were nothing more than a valet, to Faraz at the airport.

The drive was long and this may have been tedious and cause for boredom and agitation for children their age but Firas and especially Ahdia were enthralled with the chance to talk to their mom and dad, who always had amazing and interesting things to tell them. Sometimes it was about the artifacts and antiques they found, where they came from and who was recorded to own them and other times, it was, oddly enough, about space.

"So, when your mother and I found the battle axe in Cambodia," Faraz recounted to his children as he drove. They were seated between Naima and himself in the bench seating of the truck, "The constellations were aligned in exactly the same way that the King's prophets recorded them when they hid away the supposed chosen one in the cave, along with the royal weapons . . ."

". . . and tea sets!" Naima added.

"Yes, the royal weapons and the tea sets," Faraz confirmed. "Well, a chosen one must have Maghrebi, too, right?"

“What’s a chosen one, papa?” Ahdia asked.

“Ah, a beautiful question, my queen,” he replied. “Every thousand years, or longer, when the stars revealed the time and space continuum was reverberating across the cosmos . . .”

“Dear . . .” Naima chided.

“Oh, they’re precocious!” he replied. “They know what I’m talking about, right my king and queen?”

“Even astrophysicists with advanced degrees wouldn’t know what you were talking about. Most of it are your father’s own interpretations, my darlings,” she said.

Firas and Ahdia smiled but did not betray any recognition of what was being said. They loved listening to him, whether or not they fully understood what he was talking about. Naima chuckled and raised her eyebrows knowingly.

“Alright, alright,” Faraz relented. “Let me think on it.”

When they arrived at their destination, the sun had already set and so the only thing to do was to set up their tent, a campfire and prepare their dinner.

“Alright, my king and queen,” Faraz announced, clapping his hands together as he surveyed the clearing. “Your mother and I have a proposition for you both.”

Firas and Ahdia perked up, eyes bright with anticipation. It had been weeks since they’d spent real time with their parents.

“A challenge,” Naima said, her eyes twinkling. “Whoever can set up their sleeping area in the tent first gets to choose tomorrow’s breakfast. And you know what that means.”

“Pancakes!” Firas shouted.

“With chocolate chips!” Ahdia added.

“But,” Faraz held up a finger, “your mother and I will be timing you. And we’re very discerning judges. Quality matters as much as speed.”

The children nodded eagerly, already eyeing the equipment bags.

“On your marks,” Naima said. “Get set . . . go!”

Firas and Ahdia scrambled to the truck bed, each grabbing armfuls of gear. Firas, always faster, sprinted back to the clearing first, his sleeping bag bouncing against his shoulder. Ahdia followed, more measured, carrying her load with both arms.

Faraz watched from the corner of his eyes as his children unpacked their things and set up their tent. Firas was struggling with the tent poles, his small hands fumbling with the elastic cords that connected them. His face scrunched in concentration, frustration building as one section kept popping apart.

Ahdia had already laid out her sleeping bag inside the half-erected tent. She glanced over at her brother, saw his difficulty, then quietly moved to the other side of the tent to “adjust” her own area. As she did, her hand drifted to the problematic pole section near Firas, steadying it just enough that when he tried again, the pieces clicked together smoothly.

“I got it!” Firas exclaimed, not noticing his sister’s subtle assistance.

Naima caught Faraz's eye and nodded toward Ahdia, who had already retreated to fussing with her sleeping bag, face carefully neutral.

"Firas, my king," Naima called out. "Would you gather some kindling for the fire? Your father will help you find the right kind."

"Okay!" Firas bounded off into the darkening woods with Faraz.

Once they were out of earshot, Naima sat down beside Ahdia, who was meticulously arranging her belongings. "You helped him with the tent poles."

It wasn't a question. Ahdia froze for a moment, then shrugged. "He was getting frustrated."

"That was kind of you," Naima said gently. She reached out and tucked a strand of hair behind her daughter's ear. "But my sweet, sometimes the kindest thing we can do for people we love is let them struggle a little."

Ahdia looked up, confused. "But I didn't want him to feel bad."

"I know, my queen. And your heart is so big, wanting to protect your brother." Naima pulled Ahdia close. "But Firas needs to learn to solve problems on his own. If you always smooth the way for him, he won't grow into the person he's meant to become. Do you understand?"

Ahdia was quiet for a long moment, processing. "But what if he can't do it?"

"Then he learns something from failing. And that's okay too." Naima kissed the top of her head. "You don't always have to fix things for other people, Ahdia. Sometimes the best thing you can do is just . . . be there. Let them know they're not alone, even when things are hard."

"Even if I could help?"

"Even then." Naima smiled. "The world needs your gifts, my darling. But it also needs you to trust others to find their own strength. Can you try to remember that?"

Ahdia nodded slowly, leaning into her mother's embrace.

By the time Faraz and Firas returned with armfuls of kindling, the fire pit was ready and Naima had started preparing their dinner. Firas proudly displayed his haul, and Faraz made a great show of examining each stick for quality.

"Excellent work, my king! You have a natural eye for combustible materials."

Firas beamed.

With their bellies full after their meals and the darkness of the wood around them embracing the light of their fire, Faraz continued.

"Every few millennia or so, and not every millennium, if you look into the night sky, and you know what it is that you should be looking for, it will reveal to you that something in the deep nothingness of the universe is at work. And for some unknown reason, that work directly affects our little world, the Earth. And particularly, one of its inhabitants. Using today's modern sciences, it has been discovered nearly fifty years ago that it's not just an alignment of the stars that pave the way for this mysterious effect, but the manner in which they too are affected. Deeper into the cosmos than we as mere mortals can fathom, farther away than even God can see, a giant phenomenon that is blacker than the darkest night and bigger than we can possibly dream . . . stirs."

Ahdia and Firas were entranced at this. The vaguery of whatever their father was describing only allowed their own minds to fill in the gaps of their understanding with fantastic and wonderful, even frightening imaginings.

“What is it?” Ahdia asked in wonder.

“It’s called . . . a black hole,” Faraz revealed. He paused a moment to let that sink in with their thoughts.

“A hole?” Firas eventually blurted. “That’s it?”

“Not just any hole, my son,” Faraz said. “This is an astronomical mystery that could hold the answers to all the questions of the universe. But no one knows what’s inside because once anything gets caught within the massive vortex it creates, nothing escapes. Not the most powerful rockets, not even a ray of light.”

“Not even light?” Ahdia asked.

“That’s right, my queen,” Faraz replied. “It will bend a light that is shone too close to it into itself. That is how powerful it is. And for the most part, it just continues doing what a black hole does; that is, it spins and devours anything that gets caught in its reach, called its ‘event horizon’. But, every few thousand years here on Earth, something . . . escapes!”

The children gasped at Faraz’s dramatics and Naima smiled at how adorable her babies were.

“How? And what is it?” Ahdia asked.

She never ceased to amaze and impress Faraz with her curiosity and drive for knowledge, even at such a young age. Just when he thought he couldn’t be more proud of her, just like that, he was.

“No one knows for sure,” Faraz said. “Scientists call it Hawking’s radiation but they’ve never actually seen it themselves. They merely suppose it based on what they know and feel sure of. They don’t know much about it other than that: plain theory.”

“So how do you know, papa?” Ahdia asked.

“Oh, didn’t you know, my sweet?” Naima chimed in. “Your father knows everything! Or so he says.”

The children giggled as Faraz smiled and said, “Right you are, mother, father knows it all. No, your father is no world-renowned scientist. I am a humble art and antiquities collector. But like astronomers, I study things that are exceedingly old and contain many stories of our world. And from the studies your mother and I have done in our careers, we’ve learned many things that those eggheads in lab coats at MIT would never come to know even if it flew out of a cave and bopped them on their eggheads. Like the legends of the chosen one, the one that was hidden with the royal guard and the royal tea sets. In fact, your mother and I have unearthed many treasures that all have a connection to this legend, to this idea of a chosen person who, by records in scrolls by prophets and scholars, and in the art of the tea sets, the linens and of course paintings and sculptures and such, coincides with the stirrings of the night sky from a place beyond the stars. Some of the interpretations of these artifacts reveal that this chosen one is given immense powers, incomprehensible feats achieved like feeding entire nations who were facing famine or defeating

entire armies in moments. One story your mother and I discovered in the art and scrolls was a victory by the chosen one for the king by making the enemy armies freeze in place, unable to move and then made them all disappear!"

"Where did they disappear to?" Ahdia asked.

"No one knows but some believe that they were not actually made to disappear but were made to never arrive at the battlefield in the first place," Faraz described. "The chosen one of that time was revealed to jealous and covetous nations who wished to possess the chosen one for their own nations. This caused armies to invade the location of the chosen one. Then, in a blink, all who knew of the chosen one suddenly did not have any recollection of where they were and were all no longer within the borders of the chosen one's nation. What that means remains uncertain but the nearest that I can come to understanding in modern science is the theory of Schrödinger's cat."

"All possible things happening all at once," Ahdia blurted out.

Faraz leaned back and focused his sight on his child. He darted his eyes to Naima who was equally stunned.

Noticing their dumbfounded looks, Firas chimed in, "She heard you talking about it on the phone the other day to the person who sent us here. She thought we were getting a cat."

Naima giggled, "Not in this timeline!" and Faraz continued, "Still very remarkable, my queen! Yes! That is precisely what Schrödinger's cat theory means. These chosen ones, because of their powers, would burn out and die very quickly once they received these powers and so a guard was always there to protect them, usually a group from the royalty that was in power at the time. But during their times imbued with the power from the cosmos, they would have such an impact on the world that they were revered as gods themselves."

Firas yawned, his head nodding in sleep. It was evidently getting late. Naima gestured to Faraz their sleeping boy and Faraz nodded. "Time for bed, my king and queen."

"No, papa," Ahdia protested, yawning herself. "I want to know more about the black hole."

Naima picked up a sleeping Firas into her arms and carried him into the tent. Faraz did the same but Ahdia was fighting sleep. "How come we can't see a black hole?"

"It's too far away, it's too powerful to get close without getting trapped in its pull," Faraz said as he carried her into the tent.

"I want to see it one day," Ahdia said. "I want to know what's inside."

"What if you get sucked in?" Faraz asked as he tucked her into her sleeping bag.

"I won't," she said as sleep won her over.

"Oh? Well, you are already trapped in one event horizon, my queen," he said giving her a hug. Ahdia gently laughed before she closed her eyes and he watched her doze off.

The next day, while their parents were setting up their equipment on their campsite, Firas and Ahdia were playing their favorite games in the woods nearby. It felt good to Ahdia to breathe clean, clear, open air of the woods and exploring her surroundings.

"Red light, green light, one, two, three!" she said and turned from the tree trunk she was facing at Firas who was encroaching on her. He was standing still, suppressing a smile.

Earlier, they played hide-and-go-seek. Finding her brother was a vehicle to checking under rock formations and giant exposed roots of trees, digging through shrubs and looking around the canopy of trees, as though Firas was swinging through them on vines. She had to admit, though, he was very good at hiding well. And when she did find him, he would take off like a shot and leave her in his dust trail. After about fifteen minutes of exploring, she realized that when it would be her turn to hide, she wouldn't be doing herself any favors by comparing efforts.

Changing gears to playing stoplight, in which there was considerably less running involved, there he was, standing there, and in fact, looking as though he were in mid-movement.

"Red light, green light, one, two, three!" she shouted again and quickly turned around to see how much closer Firas was to her.

His arms were bent at the crooks, legs in stride but unmoving. What was strange was that he was no closer to her than the previous round. Making note of it, she did another round and again, Firas was unmoved, exactly in the same position. After one more time and Firas again having been completely still, she left the tree she was positioned by and approached him. When she was near him, she saw that his face was equally without life. His eyes were open but he wasn't breathing, evident when she put her hand by his nose and mouth to feel for breath.

"Firas?" she called, growing fearful.

Firas did not respond.

A hand jabbed her side from nowhere. Ahdia screamed.

And, as was customary between the two of them, Firas howled with laughter. Before Ahdia realized Firas was playing to her paranoia when he quickly unfroze and poked her, he was off like a bolt.

"You thought you were the chosen one, didn't you?" Firas teased. "You thought you could make me disappear?"

A flush of rage filled her and she took off running after him, even though she knew there was no way she would be catching him.

Firas was always doing that. Not just scaring the bejeezus out of her any chance he got but running, flat-out running at top speed whenever he could because he knew he was good at it. There were enough times that Firas escaped certain consequences, from school, around the neighborhood, on the army base, from their parents, by simply hitting the bricks faster than anyone he came across. Of course, parents would always be there when he eventually came home from any escapade he was on and consequences were as inescapable as the pull from a black hole, but anyone else who weren't his legal guardians were lucky if they caught a glimpse of the hand in the cookie jar rather than the cloud impression of himself he left in his wake.

Still, he had scared her. In the woods, no less. To her, it was like a fear multiplier. He would pay because, she reasoned, these were the woods, not the vast and winding roads of the subdivision they lived in and it was nearly lunch time. Unless Firas had nature survival skills that she wasn't aware of where he could catch his own food to clean and roast over a fire he makes himself, there was only one place he would eventually end up. So instead of chasing him, she ran straight back to

where her parents were setting up camp. Revenge would soon be hers.

When she arrived, she saw Firas, once again frozen. Seizing the chance, she pounced on him and wrapped her arm around his neck and shoulders.

“Get off me!” Firas said, roughly shoving her off.

Startled, Ahdia searched her brother for what was going on. “You started it!”

“No, Ahdia, stop,” Firas said. “Mom and dad. They aren’t here.”

Chapter 3

The alarm rang and she heaved her arm over her half asleep head to the nightstand to silence it. She purposefully picked the most annoying ringtone available on the phone because she admitted that waking up was one of the hardest things for her to accomplish throughout the course of a given day, most days. An annoying, obnoxious sound that was supposed to be the plan to anger her awake. In hindsight every day, it was a terrible idea to wake up pissed off all the time but she was committed now, years deep in a sleep experiment that was yielding interesting findings: waking up was just as hard but now she was cantankerous about it, too.

She didn't have a job to go to but sleeping in past a certain time of the morning, usually the hours in the double digits or the ones with "PM" after them, felt more decadent and overindulgent than the actual penthouse she lived in, courtesy of an inheritance from her late parents, along with the massive insurance payout that came with their estate. Work was something she'd heard about people doing out there, in the world, a good long distance away from the ivory tower she resided in midtown Caledonia.

Rarely did she find herself actually out in that world, where people had schedules to keep, and lives they seemingly cared about doing stuff with. One of those occasions was later tonight, drawn out of her hermit hole, albeit an inordinately well provisioned, luxuriously furnished and nostalgically designed hermit hole, by her brother and his girlfriend Ruth. They, or Ruth more accurately, got the two of them to finally agree to a night out together, one that had been perpetually pushed back for ages, with flimsy excuses from Ahdia of having been too busy with non-existent events being the usual cause for rescheduling.

Of course, everyone knew, Ahdia's plans consisted of smoking, drinking, video games, endless hours of TV and ordering in. That was Ahdia's world ever since their parents disappeared after a trip they took to Montana, over fifteen years ago. If they were around, it was possible that they would have pushed her and encouraged her toward a career in engineering, before they were proclaimed dead by the insurance company, who dropped a fat check on her and her younger brother as some kind of balm for the searing pain their absence left with them. She couldn't speak for Firas but for her, it was an inadequate remedy.

It seemed to Ahdia that Firas was much better at the whole "moving on" thing. Eventually, after a period of mourning and self-loathing not unlike her own time with the endeavor, he took his inheritance and did something with himself. He became a small business owner, operating a school that taught freerunning, or "parkour" as the kids like to call it. She didn't get it but it was great that he took his passion and ran with it, no pun intended. Even if what he loved seemed trivial to her, and it certainly did to her parents when they found out that Firas was running around rooftops with his spare time, at least he got off his butt and did something. Anything, unlike her.

When she arrived at the restaurant, Ruth was waiting but Firas was nowhere in sight. That was unexpected because in recent years, he had become this responsible, serious, disciplined dude that

would have made their father proud.

"Hi, Ahdia!" Ruth greeted her warmly with a hug.

"Hi," Ahdia said back, only meeting her energy by about half. Ahdia hated hugs but she was game to participate if people seemed like they were coming in hot with one. They were always so listless, wet noodle, floppy embraces, both parties always left feeling a little bit weird about it after. It was the customary thing to do between family and their partners so she played along.

Ahdia had known Ruth for years, the length of time she and Firas had been dating. Another accomplished go-getter, Ruth was an ER doctor, about as high-stakes and stressful as Ahdia could imagine. When she thought about it, it felt like being around a completely different species, different brains and observed behaviors. Their natural habitats were certainly on opposite sides of the world; Ruth of the brainy, persistent, stalwart side, Ahdia on the side where they hit the snooze button more times than they'd care to admit.

"Where's Firas?" Ahdia asked.

"Running late," Ruth answered.

"They won't seat us until we're all here," Ahdia remarked.

Ruth shrugged. "Tried his cell. Went to voicemail. Must be tied up?"

"That's really unlike him, no? He's usually very punctual and considerate? Like, annoyingly so," Ahdia reflected.

Ruth chuckled softly, widening her smile, saying, "I wouldn't say 'annoying,' but definitely those other things. I don't know. I'm sure he'll be around or call any minute now."

They sat in the bar and had a drink, closing the tab assuming Firas would be showing up, running as usual, sweating as it was habitual, apologizing with some totally plausible excuse. After an hour passed, Ruth's smile disappeared along with her drink, which didn't stop her from absentmindedly stirring the ice with vigor while staring at the front door.

"Maybe the subway shut down and he's stuck underground," Ahdia reassured even though she was nervous herself.

"Maybe," Ruth agreed, unconvinced.

Eventually they parted company and Ruth said she would check his apartment and let her know if she finds him there or not. Ahdia thanked her and headed back to her luxury perch brought to her by dead parents while thinking about her now missing brother.

It truly was weird that Firas was a no call, no show. She didn't want to worry about it because the last time she worried about missing family members, she was punished with unlimited funds and the lap of luxury. If I end up with a yacht, I swear to God . . . she thought as the elevator doors opened. She got in, swiped her keycard against the sensor and reached to push the button way up top above all those other lowly buttons.

There was blood on it.

Instinctively, she checked her own fingers, thinking she had cut herself unknowingly and left that mark but that made no sense when she gave it a second more of thought. She pushed the lobby button on her way out and she hadn't been out of her apartment to necessitate pushing her own

floor in days. She pushed it and anxiously awaited as the elevator began its ascent.

Only those with a keycard could effectively choose her floor and the only two people who had access were herself and . . . her brother. Firas. It had to be him. Halfway up and she realized that he must be in serious trouble, bleeding and if he came to her place, something he'd always been reluctant to do, it must have been for a good reason. Was he on the run? He's definitely injured, that much was certain.

The door was slightly ajar and she pushed her way through.

"Firas?!" she yelled. "Firas? Are you here? Where are you?"

She frantically ran through her unnecessarily large abode—great time to appreciate the square footage, Ahdia—looking into every room she passed, calling Firas's name. When she found him on the bathroom floor, gripping his midsection like he was literally holding his guts in, her brain did that thing where it cycled through every movie death scene she'd ever watched. This is fine. Totally fine. Just like that Grey's Anatomy episode. Except real. And my brother.

"Hey, sis," he weakly uttered. "Long time."

"Firas?" she exclaimed as she rushed to him, kneeling in front of him. "What . . ."

Under any other circumstance where she would find a mortally wounded family member in her bathroom, she would have grabbed the towel to put pressure on the wound, called 911, maybe even recall a first aid course she had taken years ago to be a camp counselor as a teen. What froze her instincts was seeing that Firas was dressed in black tactical gear, a ski mask apparently tossed off by him strewn on the floor. There were questions that superseded any inner prompting to help her baby brother.

"What are you wearing?" she finally managed to ask.

"Can we . . ." Firas let out as he breathed heavily, wincing. ". . . talk about that later? Can you please get Ruth?"

"Ruth? No, baby bro, we need to get you to the hospital," she protested.

"No!" he yelled, followed by a distressed groan. "No . . . Ruth. No hospital."

"Why not? You're seriously injured. What happened?" Ahdia cried, speaking hysterically.

"Ruth. Please . . . no hospital . . ." Firas expressed, faltering into unconsciousness.

His grip on his midsection loosened as he slumped in his already reclined position. That natural tendency towards an injured family member finally kicked in and Ahdia grabbed the towel off the rack, pressed it against her brother's stomach with one hand and with the other, tried to wake him up.

"Firas? Firas! Firas, wake up!" she urged. He did not respond. "Oh god, oh god, oh god!"

She reached into her pocket to pull out her phone to dial for an ambulance but hesitated. Okay, dying brother says no hospital. In literally every crime show on USA Network at 2 AM, this is when you find out your family member is in witness protection or running a meth empire. Was Firas a criminal now? Did he owe money to someone? Was this some Breaking Bad situation where her parents' legacy skipped her and went straight to pharmaceutical crime?

From what Ahdia knew of movies, and she knew a lot of movies, the only reason people who were injured and bleeding didn't want to go to the hospital was because they would have to report a gunshot wound and that would involve the authorities. But those characters were usually criminals and there was no way her little brother was that. He was a lot of things, a gym rat, a professional parkour athlete, a gentle soul, a strong-minded individual but definitely not a criminal.

It crossed her mind, though, that he was right about something. It had been a while since they last saw each other. She couldn't remember the last time. It would have been sooner if she hadn't dodged their invites on so many occasions. Months? Over a year? The days living with no responsibilities and scheduling concerns really blended the days into one another and she really couldn't be sure. In that case, she reasoned, it was possible that things have changed for Firas and he was dabbling in crime.

No, that makes no sense, she conceded again. If he needed money, that might be one thing but the amount they were endowed with was almost impossible to exhaust if they tried. Was this a gunshot wound she was putting pressure on? She had no clue. Feeling that she was wasting valuable time, she pursed her lips and closed her eyes before dialing Ruth.

After a few rings, Ruth answered, "Hey, Ahdia, I just got to Firas's place and he's not here . . ."

"Firas is here, at my place and he's hurt! Badly!" Ahdia interrupted. "Please hurry here, he asked for you! He's bleeding really bad!"

* * *

Ruth arrived in fifteen minutes with a medical bag that looked like it cost more than Ahdia's couch. Probably did. Doctor money was real money.

She moved fast. Professional fast. The kind of fast you see in TV medical dramas where everyone knows exactly what they're doing and nobody hesitates. Ahdia tried to help by staying out of the way, which was harder than it sounded in her own apartment.

They'd moved Firas to the guest bedroom. Less blood on expensive things, more space to work. Ruth had her gloves on, scissors cutting through his tactical gear like it was tissue paper, revealing the damage underneath.

Ahdia looked away. Tried to, anyway. Her eyes kept drifting back.

"Pressure here," Ruth instructed, guiding Ahdia's hands. "Don't let go."

Ahdia pressed. Felt warm blood seep between her fingers. This was nothing like Grey's Anatomy. Nobody was making quips or having relationship drama. It was just . . . quiet. Terrifying. Real.

Ruth worked methodically, removing fragments and dropping them into a bowl. Metal glinted in the tweezers, tiny and mean-looking. Four pieces. Maybe five. Ahdia had lost count around the time she started feeling lightheaded.

"That's all of them," Ruth said, not looking up. "But the damage . . ."

She trailed off. Ahdia recognized that tone from TV medical dramas. That was the "this patient isn't going to make it" voice, usually followed by a dramatic pause and someone yelling "don't you die on me."

Ruth reached for her bag. Not the fancy doctor bag, but a smaller case she'd brought separately. Metal, about the size of a jewelry box. Or a drug case. Ahdia's brain helpfully supplied: definitely drugs.

"What's that?"

"Something I've been working on." Ruth opened the case. Inside: vials of clear liquid, a syringe, some sort of small electronic thing that looked vaguely science-fictional. "Cellular regeneration therapy. CR-7."

Ahdia blinked. "You invented . . . what?"

"It accelerates cellular repair. For trauma patients." Ruth's hands moved fast, connecting the vial to the syringe, checking measurements. Very Breaking Bad, except less meth and more saving her brother's life. "Been developing it for three years. Published some early results, got laughed out of a conference. Dismissed as 'improvisation.'"

"Is it safe?"

Ruth's hands paused. Just for a second. "I've tested it on tissue cultures. Some animal models. Results were . . . promising."

"But not on people."

"Not on people."

They both looked at Firas. Pale. Barely breathing. Definitely dying if they didn't do something.

"He won't make it without this," Ruth said quietly. "Blood loss is too severe. Even with a transfusion, the damage is too extensive. His body's shutting down faster than it can repair."

Ahdia watched Ruth inject the clear liquid into Firas's IV line. When had she set up an IV line? Doctor things, apparently. It looked like water. Probably wasn't water.

"What does it do? Like, actually?"

"If it works?" Ruth monitored the IV drip, adjusting the flow. "His cells repair faster than they break down. Tissue regeneration accelerated. Not by much—maybe double normal healing speed with what I have on hand. But double might be enough."

"And if it doesn't work?"

Ruth met her eyes. Professional mask cracking slightly. "Then I just experimented on my boyfriend without his consent and it didn't help."

They sat in silence. Firas's breathing stayed shallow but steady. The TV would have dramatic music here, Ahdia thought. Maybe that beeping sound that flatlines. But real life was just . . . quiet. Waiting.

"How long until we know?"

"Few hours. If his vitals stabilize by morning, it worked. If they don't . . ." Ruth didn't finish.

Ahdia nodded. Nothing to do but wait.

And try not to think about how her brother might die on her ridiculously expensive sheets while his girlfriend performed illegal medical experiments in her guest bedroom.

Thursday nights used to be so much simpler.

* * *

Somewhere around 4 AM, Ruth said Firas needed blood. His type. Which, conveniently, Ahdia shared. Perks of being siblings, she guessed.

Ruth set up the transfusion, more TV medical drama stuff, except Ahdia was actively involved this time, needle in her arm, watching her blood flow through a tube into her brother. Very weird. Zero out of ten, would not recommend as a bonding experience.

“How’s he doing?” Ahdia asked after Ruth had taken what felt like all her blood but was probably a pint. Maybe two. She wasn’t great at estimating these things.

“Stable.” Ruth checked his pulse again. She’d been checking it every twenty minutes for hours. “The treatment’s working. Cellular repair is accelerated. Not as much as I’d hoped, but enough to keep him alive.”

“So he’s okay?”

“He’s alive,” Ruth said, eyes still on her watch, still counting. “Ask me the rest in the morning.”

Chapter 4

Ahdia had been watching him breathe for three hours.

Not creepy at all, she told herself. Perfectly normal to stare at your brother to make sure his chest keeps moving. Very regular sibling behavior.

Ruth had been in and out all night, checking his vitals every twenty minutes with the focus of someone who was either saving a life or documenting a failure. Possibly both. She'd brought that tablet at some point, typing notes between pulse checks, occasionally muttering medical terms that sounded very impressive and meant absolutely nothing to Ahdia.

When Firas's eyes finally opened—blurry at first, slowly coming to focus, then sharply seen—Firas almost wished he had died instead of facing his older sister, who was staring at him crossly, probably for bleeding on her bedsheets.

"Hey, Ahdia," he groggily croaked. "Good . . . morning? What time is it?"

"Try afternoon," she corrected. "How you feeling, Firas?"

He swallowed while closing his eyes, assessing his current physical state. He was in a great deal of pain, as it turned out. "Not bad. Been better, I suppose."

Ahdia scoffed, unamused. "I'll bet."

Ruth, hearing the banter and the tenor in Ahdia's terse counters, flew in, stopping for a brief second to see that Firas was awake and then glided to his side, taking his hand. "Firas . . ." she said as tears gathered in her eyes.

"Hey, Nightingale," Firas smiled, mostly with his eyes.

Ahdia was feeling touched at the display so she allowed the lovebirds to goo-goo eye each other for an additional few seconds before interjecting, "So, what's the prognosis, doc? Is he going to make it?"

Not breaking eye contact with Firas, Ruth replied, "It's a good sign he's awake. He lost a lot of blood but luckily, you were on hand to provide a transfusion."

Firas furrowed his eyebrows and squinted towards his sister, lifting his head to see she was sporting a bandage near the pit of her elbow. He couldn't tell if Ahdia looked uncomfortable or irritated. It was always hard to tell with her. He dropped his head on the pillow and said, "Thanks for the blood."

"I'd say, 'anytime,' although I don't want to suggest it's okay for this being some sort of regular occurrence. They have whole-ass buildings called hospitals where we don't have to jerry-rig a blood transfusion using what's on hand. Normal people go to them when they're bleeding like it's going out of style!" she yelled, realizing she had lost her temper.

"Yeah, well," he said after he was sure she had let it all out. "I knew I lost a lot of blood and you, sis, were always the emergency plan if I ever found myself in this situation."

Ruth checked his vitals again—pulse, temperature, that thing where she pressed two fingers to his wrist and stared at her watch. Very doctor-like.

“The treatment’s working,” she said, more to herself than them. “Cellular repair approximately 1.8 times normal rate. Tissue regeneration visible on basic scans.”

“That’s good, right?” Ahdia asked.

“It’s incredible.” Ruth’s voice had that weird mix of pride and terror. “It’s also not nearly enough. At this rate, he’ll be stable in a few days instead of dead in a few hours, but full recovery is going to take weeks. Maybe longer.”

Firas shifted, winced. “Weeks? I need to—”

“You need to stay in bed,” Ruth cut him off. Professional voice back. “The treatment kept you alive. It’s not a miracle cure. Your body’s still healing from massive trauma. You try to go out on patrol before you’re ready, you’ll undo everything.”

“But the team—”

“Will manage without you. Night Knight’s been leading the tactical side for years anyway.”

Firas’s jaw tightened. Ahdia recognized that look. That was the look he got when someone told him he couldn’t do something and he was absolutely going to prove them wrong or die trying.

Literally die, in this case.

“Firas,” Ahdia said quietly. “She saved your life with science fiction medicine. Maybe listen to her?”

He sighed. Heavily. The kind of sigh that meant “fine, but I hate it.”

Ruth’s fingers were flying across her tablet again. Taking notes. Documenting. That’s what researchers did, right? Document everything?

“What are you writing?” Ahdia asked.

Ruth looked up. “Proof of concept. If this works—if he recovers fully, even slowly—it changes everything I’ve been trying to prove for three years.”

“And if he doesn’t recover fully?”

“Then I just proved the treatment has limitations I can’t overcome with the equipment I have access to.”

Which, Ahdia thought, was a very science way of saying “I did my best with what I had and hoped it would be enough.”

Sounded familiar.

Ahdia lowered her brow and pressed her lips together firmly before slowly asking, “Why would you have to plan for this sort of thing?”

She saw Ruth open her eyes and mouth slightly wider before turning away. “Because . . .” Firas began. “. . . I do things sometimes that things like this might happen.”

Ahdia scrunched her forehead and braced herself. “What things?” she asked.

“Ahdia, we should let him rest . . .” Ruth defended.

“No,” Firas objected gently. “It’s okay. She helped save my life, she deserves to know.”

Ruth stood down as she slowly turned her gaze to Ahdia.

“What is going on?” Ahdia asked, suddenly worried.

Firas sighed heavily. “Ruth, can you please? I’m really exhausted.”

“Sure, sweetheart,” Ruth agreed and pondered where to start.

A few years ago, after Firas opened his freerunning school, he was still feeling an emptiness in his life and no matter what he did, he couldn’t fill that void he had inside him, a feeling that was consuming him slowly, more and more, until it got to a point where he felt like he would collapse into himself. Then, one night, he saw someone getting beat up in the park and he said he didn’t know what possessed him to get involved, but he did and helped the person who was being attacked. Saved him. But in the process, he hurt his hand because one of them broke a bottle over him, which he blocked. He ended up at the emergency room of the hospital I work in.

I patched him up, sent him on his way, and I didn’t think twice about it. But about a week later, he was back, his head gashed open, saying he fell. Another few weeks go by and he’s back, this time with cracked ribs.

I told him, “You must be the most accident prone man I’ve ever met.”

He said, “Or I’m just getting into accidents so I can come back and see you.”

So corny! But I like corny. And I liked him. I patched him again, sent him on his way and didn’t connect with him until the next time he came back, but not because of an injury. He came to ask me out on a date. I said yes.

When we were out together, he took me to the Overlook, where we could see the whole city as the sun was setting. He made a picnic, Subway sandwiches and a bottle of wine, but I didn’t hold it against him. It was really nice. It was like all of Caledonia was lighting up just for us.

But then, suddenly, we were surrounded by a group of men. They were part of the gang that’d been terrorizing Caledonia at the time and they were saying the park was theirs at night, that we had to pay a tax. I was really frightened because there were so many of them, honestly, like five or six guys and Firas stood up, went up to the leader of them, the one that was doing the talking and before I knew it, they were scrambling all around me, going after him.

I thought he was dead or at least badly injured for sure but what I saw was Firas moving much faster than any of them, using their weight against themselves and, I swear, it was like watching water move between rocks. I don’t know how else to explain it. It was like a flow, like a dance, and they were being made to look foolish by him for every attack they tried to land on him.

Eventually, I worked up the nerve to pick up the wine bottle and smash one of them on the head, so I helped! Firas says that was the moment he fell in love with me. I didn’t know it at the moment, but I was falling in love with him watching him take on a whole gang by himself and coming out on top in a matter of seconds.

We’ve been inseparable since. I’ve even made what I think were helpful suggestions by having him wear body armor when he went out on patrols. After a while, I took lessons at the Parkour Academy, but not just for freerunning, but also Krav Maga and judo that he taught after hours to the recruits, others he trained individually; only a handful of students who stood out to him during freerunning classes.

Eventually, I joined him on some night patrols. And I wasn’t the only one. Apparently, the Academy was a great recruiting station and there were plenty of people who felt the same way we

did about taking back the city from the criminal element that had been victimizing Caledonia for years.

When we had a small group of reliable traceurs, we organized and called ourselves the Go Squad. There are enough of us to take shifts so none of us have to go every night. And, as you can guess, some personalities are more colorful than others.

We all took codenames because we only met when Firas introduced us and maintaining our real identities was our best way to protect that life. He said it was the best way to protect ourselves and those we love so they don't get dragged into our messes. And for four years, we've done just that. Kept this secret life to ourselves, stayed in the shadows, watched each other's backs.

There's Night Knight, Gloom Girl, Crimson Sable and Battlea. My codename is Nightingale. We don't reveal anything about our real lives. We don't know each other's real names. In fact, we only recently started showing each other our faces.

Firas never took a codename. He thought the whole thing was making a joke of what he started but he didn't stop others as long as we only used it among ourselves and never made the news. That was our first and most important rule: stay secret, stay hidden, never take credit.

We, the Go Squad, have talked about why we do this and we all seem to have our different reasons. Night Knight is ex-military, he's revealed that much to us but it's obvious in the way he talks and acts. He says this has been a great outlet for him to put his Marine skills to use. He probably suffers from PTSD but he's a great teammate, especially when it comes down to a tussle. Gloom Girl says it helps her depression. Sable never shares his reasons and that's all we know about him. And Battlea says doing patrols helps her with her anger issues.

I do it for all the times gunshot victims hobble their way into the ER or get dropped in our drive and for all the ones we can't save because . . . well, they never should have been shot to begin with. Oh, that's another rule. No guns. Night Knight still argues for it but he never crosses the line. But really, I do it for him, for Firas. I fell in love with him but I also fell in love with what he does and I fell in love with what I now do.

We all have our roles. Obviously, as the trained medic, that's my duty. We have mechanics and engineers . . . I'm pretty sure Gloom Girl is an exotic dancer because of her footwear and also all the singles she pays with but I can't be sure. And I don't judge her if she is! Aside from Firas, she bankrolls us hardest for gear and supplies. But we all contribute in the ways we can to support each other. And we all throw down with the best of 'em, if need be.

Mostly, we're just helping people, though. We stay on rooftops and fire escapes and keep our eyes and ears open for anyone in trouble. Just last night, I helped an old lady find her cat, but before I did, I stashed my body armor, belt and mask, just looking like a regular citizen dressed in all black at that point, and got her cat down from a telephone pole. It's usually like that for the most part and, honestly, I am grateful for those nights we don't run into the gangs.

Because when we do . . . I feel really bad for them.

Chapter 5

“Okay, so now tell me what happened tonight,” Ahdia insisted after processing everything Ruth shared. “Is this normal? Is this why you wear Kevlar? Because you get shot at regularly?”

“No,” Ruth said. “Tactical body armor was my idea because broken ribs aren’t very treatable, so avoiding that is huge but in general, we don’t engage against armed enemy combatants.”

“Explain that,” Ahdia urged, pointing at Firas’s stomach. “That is engaging armed enemies. A gunshot.”

“Shotgun, actually,” Firas corrected, immediately regretting it, then sheepishly explained, “Close range . . . that’s why . . . it went through.”

“Oh, that’s much better,” Ahdia said, shaking her head in disbelief.

“Look, Ahdia,” Firas spoke gingerly. “After mama and papa . . .” Firas exhaled, unable to speak the words. “. . . I couldn’t eat, I couldn’t sleep. I thought starting a business would give me something to do but that didn’t work and I don’t know what else I could have done to avoid eventually putting a bullet in my brain or hanging in the closet.”

Ahdia pursed her lips and turned away from looking at her brother before she couldn’t contain her emotions any longer.

Firas continued. “I wasn’t planning on going out on patrol last night. I had the night before and I had plans with the two of you for dinner. I was looking forward to seeing you again, Ahdia. Sorry it was like this.”

Ahdia sniffled. “Yeah, dramatic much?”

Firas chuckled and groaned. “Don’t make me laugh. Anyway, I was on my way when I was passing the Natural History Museum on Grand Ave. It was past closing so the truck that was parked out front with hard looking men surrounding it caught my attention. I ducked into a cafe across the street to just watch. I’m sure they were just movers, right? But the next thing I see, the front door busts open and more guys are shoving a man out, like, definitely with force against his will. They threw him into the truck and drove off.”

Ruth’s eyebrows raised. She was just as curious as Ahdia was to hear what happened.

“You followed them?” Ruth cried, a swell of disappointment and shock flooding her.

“Yeah . . .” Firas admitted, resigned in shame. “Sorry.”

“They had guns, didn’t they,” Ruth admonished.

“Of course they did!” Ahdia shouted. “Look at him!”

Firas knew he was in the wrong and outgunned in the room. “Yes, I know. I should have done a lot of things differently.”

“You should have called!” Ruth lambasted.

“I know,” he agreed. “I didn’t want to worry you and I thought this would only be recon. In, out, scout and mark for a return.”

Ruth almost didn’t want to hear more. “So?”

“As the truck was pulling away, I hopped on the back and rode it all the way to the docks. I peeled off unnoticed and changed into the suit,” he continued.

“I said no body armor,” Ruth said through gritted teeth.

He shrugged. Ruth knew he could never help himself, ever. She rolled her eyes, indicating him to continue.

“I made it to the roof of the warehouse they pulled him into and peeked in from above. The guy they shanghai’d was being grilled by a suit with a haircut. From where I was, using my binocs, I could tell it was none other . . . than Harding Kain.”

“Harding Kain?” Ahdia chimed. “The presidential candidate?”

“The one and only,” he confirmed.

Ahdia almost laughed at the absurdity. She had seen countless Harding Kain ad spots on all the channels she surfed to pass the days while sipping Big Gulps. The guy was as polished as a turd could shine, with his fake hair, fake tan and obviously tailored suit to hide his gut. She wasn’t planning on voting but if she did, it was definitely not going to be for this guy.

“What’s Harding Kain doing in the docks of Caledonia Harbor?” Ruth wondered.

“Exactly. When I saw it was him staring down a trembling . . . I don’t know? Anthropologist? Museum docent? Either way, what’s he pulling this Godfather, Goodfellas nonsense for when he’s got a campaign to win? Must have been really important. Anyway, before I know it, Kain is snapping his fingers and some muscle heads wheel in a box and place it right in front of the museum guy. They open it and . . . I can’t describe what I saw. I don’t think anyone can. It’s . . . Ruth, I haven’t seen anything like this in my wildest dreams.”

“Try,” Ruth encouraged.

Firas stared blankly to search his memory and narrowed his eyebrows. “It was like . . . like I could see all sides of it, even though I was obviously only on one side of it.”

“It was a mirrored box?” Ahdia guessed.

“No,” he dismissed. “Like I said, it wasn’t anything that I can really explain. It . . . was like it wasn’t really there . . . like it was a projection or something but that wouldn’t make sense because how could a projection show me all sides of a solid object? Do you see how crazy that sounds? But I swear I did! It looked like a . . . a ball? No . . . egg, maybe? A lemon? Or a football? But it was going in and out of itself, constantly changing shape but at the same time remaining the same. That’s still not a good description. I was dumbfounded and completely outside my head that I wasn’t careful about leaning on the glass and broke through. Luckily, I landed on a scaffolding only a few feet below but obviously I was blown and I ran like hell before they started opening fire on me! Blam! Blam! Blam! I was booking it across this narrow catwalk as bullets were ricocheting right under my feet! I kash vaulted over some crates when I reached the end of the catwalk, rolled into a room and shut the door behind me. There was only one way out through the window so I did a wall run and climbed out and found myself back on the roof. By then, the muscle heads with the guns were also on the roof so I had to make it to the water. It was my only chance. I ran as fast as I could and I thought I was clear to make a dive when a dude out of nowhere appeared out of a

trapdoor right in front of me. Before I even could think, I pop vaulted over him and I was falling to the water. But when I was falling, he fired his shotgun and it hit me square in the armor."

"Most of it didn't make it through but enough did to cause internal damage," Ruth let him know. "I can't be sure your organs are intact . . . I got out all the bullet fragments but I do need to get you properly examined. I'll get what I need in the morning and bring it here. You can't move. You have to stay in bed."

Ruth was checking Firas again. He'd been talking for maybe ten minutes and she'd checked his pulse three times, adjusted his pillows twice, and kept glancing at her tablet like it might spontaneously reveal better news.

"What?" Firas asked, noticing.

"Your recovery rate is slowing," Ruth said. "It was accelerated for the first twelve hours, but now it's plateauing. Back to maybe 1.5 times normal healing, dropping toward baseline."

"That's . . . bad?"

"It's not good. The therapy needs consistent cellular support—specialized isotopes, synthesis equipment I don't have. What I gave you was field medicine. Improvisation." She set the tablet down, frustrated. "I kept you alive. But I can't get you back to fighting shape. Not with what I have access to."

"How long?" Firas asked.

"For full recovery? Weeks minimum. You won't be cleared for patrol for at least a month. Maybe longer."

Firas closed his eyes. "The team—"

"Will be fine. Night Knight can handle tactical. I'll coordinate medical. Gloom Girl's been itching to take point anyway." Ruth's voice softened. "You built a good team, Firas. Good enough to run without you while you heal."

Ahdia watched her brother struggle with that. The guy who couldn't sit still, forced to stay in bed for weeks. The leader who had to watch his team operate without him.

"There's nothing you can do?" he asked Ruth.

"Not without proper lab resources. Synthesis equipment, medical-grade materials, regulatory clearance I definitely don't have." Ruth shook her head. "What I gave you was prototype-level at best. To take it further, I'd need access to a research facility that wouldn't laugh me out the door. Or arrest me for unauthorized human trials."

She said it like a joke. Ahdia didn't think it was funny.

Ruth looked at her tablet again. At the data proving her research worked, just not well enough. "I saved your life," she said quietly. "But I can't give you back what you had."

Firas squeezed her hand. "You saved my life. That's enough."

Ruth nodded. Didn't look convinced.

Ahdia understood that feeling too.

He squeezed her hand. "I'm fine. I'm going to be okay."

Ruth felt reassured, seeing color in his face and speaking to him. They sat in silence, appreciating life and having it when it could easily have been taken if not for the armor.

“You stupid idiots,” Ahdia seethed.

Firas and Ruth turned their heads to Ahdia, standing by the window with the city at her back. “You’re out there playing cops and robbers and think this is a game?”

“Sis . . .” Firas started.

“Don’t ‘sis’ me!” Ahdia cut off. “What in the world is wrong with you two? You!” she yelled, pointing at Ruth. “You’re a doctor! You of all people should know better!”

Ruth turned to look at her, indignant. “Excuse me?”

“Allowing my brother, the man you claim to love and care for, to go out playing Batman and you go with him like you’re Batgirl or something! It’s a joke! It’s a sick joke that you guys either aren’t seeing or are deluded into thinking what you’re doing makes any kind of sense or making any kind of difference!” Ahdia rebuked combatively.

“And sitting in your penthouse all day every day is doing anybody any good?!” Firas volleyed in defense. “When was the last time before tonight that you saw the sidewalk except to hit up 7-Eleven for more Slurpees and Parliaments?”

“Nice,” Ahdia dismissed, turning away in anger.

“At least we’re out there doing something with our lives instead of counting down the days feeling bad for ourselves until we die. At least if we die, it’ll be fighting, not cowering in the safety of our tower.”

“You know what . . . !” Ahdia violently started.

“All you do is waste time feeling bad for yourself that our parents are gone,” he growled through the agony of his injury. “When are you going to let go and live your life?”

“And when are you going to grow up and see that running around doing karate against the putty patrol should have stopped in third grade?! Or is taking artillery to the sternum not a clear indication of that?” she said.

“Stop it! Both of you!” Ruth interrupted before Firas responded. “Just . . . ugh . . . stop. Please.”

Ahdia looked at Firas, struggling in pain and Ruth checking to make sure he didn’t bust his stitches.

“Forget this,” Ahdia muttered as she stormed out of the room.

“Where are you going?” Firas yelled.

“Out!” Ahdia replied.

This is insane, she thought when she reached the streets. She pounded the sidewalk with every step and lit a cigarette as she did. Her mind raced in a feverish velocity as she tried to recall everything she had learned in the past few hours.

Her brother and his girlfriend started a wannabe-superhero team with other wannabe-superheroes. This would never have happened if their parents were still with them. Life would have made sense. She would have been an engineer and her brother would have been

competing in parkour tournaments or something like that. Surfing in Bali, maybe, or really anything he wanted. This didn't compute. One didn't add up to the other.

Crimson Sable? What a joke. Gloom Girl? What the actual? This felt like a bad dream, like a nightmare that she couldn't slap herself hard enough to wake from. She kept waiting for that annoying ringtone she set to wake herself up whenever she felt this messed up while dreaming. It wouldn't come no matter how long she waited.

And before long, before she realized where she was walking, she found herself at the edge of the city, by the water. By the docks.

She scoffed. There's no way her brother was describing what she thought he was describing . . . an object in four dimensions. That was only theoretical from what she knew of all the YouTube videos she watched while eating her cereal. When he was describing his nightly escapades punching out evildoers, she was more likely to believe him. If he was describing seeing a spherical object from all sides at once, this was clearly an elaborate prank he was pulling to get back at her for bailing on all their plans; dye pack of blood and his doctor girlfriend Ruth in on it, Firas had the time and money to pull something like this off.

Ahdia wanted to see for herself and defiantly marched towards the warehouse.

"We'll see," she muttered.

Chapter 6

When Ahdia arrived at the warehouse, she approached the door to get in. Trying the handle, she found it was locked. She went to the bay doors to try it even though, if they were even open, she didn't have the muscles to hoist up the door on her own.

It started raining. She felt vindicated, not seeing any criminal activity and definitely not four-dimensional objects. Still, she needed to be certain.

Remembering what Firas supposedly recounted, she decided that she needed to get on the roof. If she couldn't get in the building, she would at least call it a night and be able to legitimately call shenanigans on Firas and Ruth if she at least got to peek in through the windows. The only windows on the building were lining the walls under the top tiered roof. She went to the left side of the warehouse, keeping her eyes open for any entrance or landing she could climb on to reach the top.

If her weird brother could do it, she figured how hard could it be? Not seeing anything on the right, she circled around to the back and then to the left side. It was sheer wall on both sides and she was miffed that she was starting to get impressed that Firas was actually able to somehow get on the roof with nothing apparent to climb on. She knew he thought he was a superhero but as far as she knew, his power was only that he jumped around on buildings. Since when could he fly to the tops of them in single bounds?

Maybe climbing to the top wasn't her best option. She looked around for something to bash in the front door with. Searching the premises, she found an old broken piece of wood, part of a shipping crate most likely, and struggled to carry it to the front door. When she got there, she placed one end of it on the ground, leaning the other against her body as she took a moment to catch her breath, move the wet strands of hair out of her face and then hoisted it using both hands over her shoulder.

"Careful," a voice from behind her startled. Ahdia's heart jumped into her throat before she turned to see Ruth standing there, wearing a North Face windbreaker with her hood up. "You might get a splinter. You should really wear gloves when you're out on patrol."

Ahdia, realizing it was just Ruth, turned her attention back to the door, saying, "I'm not on patrol. Don't be dumb. What are you doing here?"

"Really? Besides the dinner wear you're sporting, out on a closed dock in the middle of the night, breaking and entering into a suspicious warehouse really gives off the wrong impression," Ruth said glibly.

Trying to ignore her, Ahdia raised the plank in her hands a bit higher, getting ready to strike the door handle. "There it is. People making assumptions just because of the way I'm dressed," Ahdia sneered. "Typical."

"Before you do that . . ." Ruth quickly cut in before she struck the door. "You do that and the night's over before it begins. That loud noise is going to draw all the wrong kinds of attention and

if we're lucky, we'll be behind bars."

Ahdia hesitated. "And if we're not lucky?" she asked.

Ruth raised her eyebrows, pouted her lips and tilted her head down, her eyes looking to her right before she began walking away. Ahdia blinked the rain pouring down her head out of her eyes as she watched Ruth walk away. Shaking her head, she redetermined that breaking the door down really was the only way. She took a deep breath, gripped the plank and stretched her arms above her head as high as she could.

From somewhere above her, she heard a light banging against metal. She drew her attention to the direction and a moment later, saw Ruth leaping from the top of a stack of shipping containers onto the roof. Ahdia's jaw dropped watching the majestic arc Ruth created, a stride that reminded her of a gazelle hopping along the African plains she saw once on Animal Planet. She dropped the plank next to her and ran to where she could get a better angle of the roof to spot Ruth.

She cupped the tops of her eyes to shield from the rain to see Ruth, standing with her hands in the pockets of her windbreaker and, if she knew any better, smugly smiling at her.

"How'd you do that?" Ahdia called to her.

"Easy when you know how," Ruth called back.

Ahdia was pissed. She could plainly see how Ruth got to the top of the stack of shipping containers. Knowing how didn't make it easier for her to climb on top of the first landing, a single unstacked shipping container next to a stack of two, next to a stack of three, next to a stack of four from where Ruth made her leap. Being fair, struggling onto the crate was made more difficult by the rain, and she used an improvisation of a garbage bin she tipped upside down to stand on to climb up.

Ruth knelt down, keeping an eye on Ahdia, amused at her fumbling attempts at each level. The stack of two, without the help of her garbage bin, was uncomfortable to witness as Ahdia came close to losing her grip once she jumped high enough to grip the edge. At eight and a half feet, that was no easy trick and Ruth so admitted to herself that she was impressed, even though it took multiple attempts and Ahdia's above average height and reach played to her advantage.

When Ahdia made it to the top, as Ruth suspected would happen, Ahdia hesitated after looking at how high up she was. The top of the roof she needed to land onto was a few feet below the plane Ahdia was on but the gap felt inordinately long, too long for human traversal.

"That's impossible!" Ahdia protested.

"Clearly not!" Ruth said, standing, presenting herself where Ahdia proclaimed impossibility.

Ahdia swore under her breath. There was no way she was going to climb back down, something that she realized was probably almost as dangerous as falling from this height once she got onto the stack of three containers. She was pot-committed, like the time Phil Hellmuth was in the World Series of Poker she saw on ESPN. The commentator said that it was a fallacy, she remembered, that you can always back out no matter how much you commit and often, that's the best play, but in that moment, that felt like nonsense.

She moved as far back as she could on the ledge, about eight feet wide. Psyching herself by taking quick breaths, she darted forward before her nerves stopped her. Ruth's eyes widened on Ahdia's approach, taking her hands out of her pockets and bending her knees to prepare for however Ahdia was going to land; short or long. Ruth honestly didn't think Ahdia had the courage to go through with it.

After four momentum building strides, she timed her leap when she got to the very edge as though she were bowling, thinking about the Professional Bowlers Association broadcasts she watched on ESPN2 while drinking Pabst Blue Ribbons. To the surprise of all parties present and witnessing, Ahdia cleared the gap by a good foot and landed safely . . . before tumbling forward to the ground anyway because her legs gave way to the anxiety of the event.

Ruth rushed to her to help her onto her feet, excited and happy for Ahdia's success in not dying. "Nicely done!" she congratulated. "I'm really impressed! I didn't think you had it in you!"

Ahdia barely registered any of what Ruth was saying, swallowing the urge to vomit. When she had a moment to adequately gather herself, she peered over the edge to see how high up she was. The darkness and rain made it look like an endless abyss, even though it was actually about 35 feet high. She was glad she hadn't done this surveying of the gap beforehand because she also learned then that she experienced slight vertigo from such height, even though she lived on the highest rise in Caledonia.

While Ahdia was marveling her own accomplishments, Ruth scouted the rooftop and saw the indication she was looking for. "Over here," she said.

Ahdia broke away from her self-admiration and joined Ruth, who was pointing at a window frame with a clearly broken pane of glass.

"This must be where Firas broke through," Ruth commented.

The windows were on an incline so it was reasoned that he was leaning too much of his body weight against it when it broke. They cautiously climbed in, another not-so-safe activity that Ruth made look easy, jumping gracefully feet first through and landing on the catwalk below. Remaining crouched, she inspected the chipped paint from the ricocheted bullets.

Ahdia kicked off the remaining glass shards along the bottom of the frame and found a safe enough surface to grip her hands on as she slowly, clumsily lowered herself down and let go to drop a few feet above the catwalk. Luckily, no mobsters or gangbangers were in sight but Ahdia had to admit, so far, everything corroborated Firas's story. This was either something he really actually experienced or the elaboration of the prank was deeper than she could imagine. Until she saw the four-dimensional object for her own, she reminded herself to stay skeptical.

"That's the room he went into," Ruth deduced. "Let's go the other way, down the stairs, to see what we see," she said and headed in that direction.

Ahdia tried to ratchet up her awareness and wished she had spidey-senses, like Spider-Man does on Disney+, to detect danger before it occurred so she could avoid it. The only tingle she felt was the goosebumps on the back of her neck and on her arms.

They quietly made their way down the grated stairs, a slight “ting” with every step, and hid behind a set of crates near the stairwell.

“Let’s stay quiet and search the area,” Ruth suggested. “Stick together.”

They were half-crouched, stepping lightly and moving around towards the center, where they could see a box, possibly the one Firas described. It had an insignia ink-stamped on the wooden panels, a logo in the shape of a diamond and the word “TRIOMF” emblazoned below it. Ahdia’s anticipation was getting the better of her as she felt her heart beating in her eyes more and more with every step they took. When they reached the crate, Ruth looked nervously at Ahdia before she put her hands on the lid.

“Hold it!” they heard from the dark corner of the warehouse. They weren’t alone.

A man emerged, holding a handgun, trained on them, switching between the two of them repeatedly and closing in to where they were.

“Put your hands up!” he barked.

Chapter 7

They slowly raised their hands. Ahdia started having the feeling that her brother wasn't making things up after all but for some reason, she kept it in the back of her mind that this man could be one of their buddies, Ruth was leading her into the warehouse as part of the ploy and they weren't in any danger at all. Until she saw a mystical object in which she could see all the sides of from one perspective, all of this was subject to disbelief. The thought at least helped assuage the panic-scream her brain was doing internally.

"Who are you? What are you doing here?" the man demanded.

He was built stockily, had a black blazer over a gray turtleneck, sporting a crewcut barely hiding his scalp. Ahdia wondered if guys like these came out of some evil henchman catalog that villains subscribed to.

"Evening, sir," Ruth responded. "We were just out for a stroll and needed to get out of the rain, you know how it is."

"Yeah, right," he said, close enough to be able to smell his cologne, distinctively Fahrenheit by Christian Dior, definitely way too much.

He took out a hand radio from inside his coat and squawked, "I got two intruders here, in the warehouse."

Wiseguy & Sonoma.

Ruth subtly looked at Ahdia who could only calm herself to notice that Ruth was trying to get her attention by coming up with dumb names of fake stores.

Amazon Prime Suspect.

When Ruth saw that Ahdia was paying attention, she motioned with her eyes to the box.

Blood, Bath, and Beyond.

Not knowing what exactly she meant, Ahdia's panic intensified.

Sur la Tombstone.

Suddenly, while the man with the gun was slightly distracted by talking on his radio, Ruth moved quickly, slightly ducking out of the way of the line of fire the man was drawing, stepped in closer, turning her back against him with his arm above her right shoulder.

Crate and Shallow Burial.

Ahdia, hoping Ruth meant to duck and hide behind the crate, did so. She squeezed her knees against her chest and tightly shut her eyes.

Target.

In the very next moment, the man with the gun squeezed the trigger. Ruth immediately grabbed his arm and yanked it down over her right shoulder. A sickening crunch could be heard as the man's elbow bent in an unnatural manner. He roared in pain before Ruth climbed up the man's slightly bent knee by stepping on his thigh and wrapping her legs around his neck. She then landed two successive elbows down onto the top of his head, dazing him, followed by dropping her entire

body weight back and down as hard as she could. Still gripping his neck with her thighs, she used the momentum to flip her quarry forward, headfirst onto the ground. He was unconscious on his back while Ruth lay on top of him with her knees by his ears.

Ruth knew since he radioed for backup, they had precious few seconds remaining before they were outnumbered. She called out for Ahdia as she got up and did a catpass over the crate and over Ahdia, where she ducked behind.

“Ahdia . . .” Ruth said weakly, seeing the bullet the thug fired went through the crate and hit Ahdia’s chest.

Already in shock, Ahdia looked up from staring at the blood on her hands to Ruth, whose concerned and defeated eyes met her own. “I’m . . . shot,” she said.

Then, footsteps could be heard stampeding into the warehouse. Ruth peeked over the crate to see a group of men, dressed similarly filing in through the open front door.

“We gotta get out of here,” Ruth said hurriedly before looking at Ahdia, who was fading fast.

Ahdia looked up at the light that was shining on them, like a spotlight. It was somehow getting brighter as the edges of her vision were closing in darkness.

“Ahdia?!” Ruth echoed in Ahdia’s ears as she slumped over.

The last thing Ahdia saw before she passed out was Ruth being hit in the back of the head with the butt of a pistol.

“Ahdi,” her mother called.

“Mom?” Ahdia said, unsure where her mother’s voice was coming from.

They were back in their house in the suburbs of Caledonia, the one she was raised in from birth to when they disappeared. She was in the hallway from her bedroom to the kitchen.

“Ahdi, come wash up for dinner,” her mother’s voice said again.

She could smell the couscous dish, her mother’s own recipe with dried fruit, ready to be dipped into by the bagita that she baked earlier in the day. It had been so long since those aromas filled her nostrils.

Ahdia approached the kitchen to see her mother, as alive as she had remained in her memory, removing her apron as she saw Ahdia, giving her a warm smile.

Suddenly, Ahdia’s ears started ringing, louder and louder.

Her eyes fluttered open.

She heard footsteps and saw she was lying on a dusty floor in a vast and dimly lit room. Ruth was kneeling down, her arms tied behind her back. She was surrounded by men with guns, too many to count, some shrouded in the darkness where the light didn’t illuminate.

They had apparently left her on the ground, lying on her side, assuming she was dead.

“First we had a boy wonder bust through the roof and now we have two little birdies stuck in the rafters,” a man spoke.

He was pacing back and forth, unarmed and dressed differently than the others. He was not in shape like the men around them, evident by his rotund figure, with thickset rings adorning his stubby fists, a three-piece gray suit with a black dress shirt and the least convincing hair-hat she’d

ever seen.

Harding Kain, in the flesh.

“Heard this was where the party was,” Ruth replied, unwavering in her snark.

“From who?” he demanded as he stepped to her, grabbing her face by the chin.

Ruth remained quiet.

Kain released and took one step away, suddenly turning and slapping Ruth with the back of his hand, embellished with heavy rings. Ruth yelped and spit blood but returned to give Kain a teasing smirk.

“The voters are going to want to know your stance on women’s issues, Harding,” she taunted. “My face is going to be hard to explain away to that particular demographic.”

“Oh, little bird,” Kain mused, walking to the edge of the ring of light. “What makes you think you’ll get the chance to show your face anywhere to anyone again?”

With his back turned to her, he walked up to one of his men who handed him a lead pipe about a yard long. He gently tested the weight against his hand and smirked, handing it back to the hired bruiser to take his blazer off. Handing the blazer to his human coat rack, he unbuttoned and rolled up his sleeves.

Ruth didn’t betray any emotions on her face but her eyes were windows into her fright and terror. Whatever this man said, he had the clout and influence to do it and more, get away with it. Turning around with the pipe in his hand, he was walking jauntily, twirling the pipe like an unskilled drum major towards Ruth who squirmed and struggled against her constraints.

Watching her writhe drew out a guttural laugh from his belly. “What’s the matter?” he chaffed. “Don’t worry, little bird, I’ll get you to sing.” With that, as if he were winding up a golf swing, he measured his stroke to her face and slowly raised the pipe above his head. Ruth saw fire in his eyes, blinded by a lust for violence. She closed her eyes, not wanting that to be the last thing she saw.

“What the . . . !” she heard and opened her eyes. The whole room was suddenly pitch black.

“No better place than here!” a voice, one she recognized, cried from the shadows.

She jumped to her feet and silent-ran in a direction she remembered there was a gap between men.

“No better time than now!” a chorus of shouting voices responded.

Slowly, flashlights blasted on from the men, one by one. Apparently, smoke grenades had detonated and the flashlight beams cut through like light sabers. Ruth, running blind, ran into what felt like a fleshy brick wall.

“Nightingale!” the wall greeted, holding her by both shoulders.

“Night Knight!” Ruth realized, nearly crying in relief. “Thank God you all made it in time. I was about to get brained!”

Night Knight turned her around and used a combat knife to cut her bindings. Gloom Girl was standing by him, obscured by smoke and shade. She handed a set of infrared vision goggles to Ruth. Ruth put them on and activated them.

It made everything she saw coated in blue but she was able to see heat signatures of all the warm bodies who were stumbling blind in the smoke. She could see heat signatures moving faster around other signatures, and she recognized their motion to be the Go Squad, Battlea and Crimson Sable, surging through the bodies with flying kicks, baton strikes and body momentum takedowns.

Ruth wiped the blood from her mouth and snickered, running back in the direction she came from.

In the cloud of smoke, with their training, all the unsuspecting blind bodies struggling in the kill zone became an amorphous freerunning track. In coordination, the group ran, jumped and pushed the muscle heads around, into each other and into practiced, harmonized movements and coordinated attacks.

The house lights turned back on; one of the thugs reached the breakers to switch them back. The Go Squad removed their infrared goggles, by then having dispatched of most of the guards, and only three men were left standing, surrounded.

One of the guards made a break to attack the nearest traceur, Gloom Girl, and found himself being flipped onto his back when, in one fluid motion, she placed her hands on his wrist and shoulder, turned around while stepping under his arm, pulling him towards her. Throwing him off balance over her squatting lower center of gravity, she used his momentum to lift him, a man with a hundred pounds on her, over herself. The ground knocked the wind out of him but she kicked his lights out for good measure.

The other two, watching a clearly smaller girl do that to their burly companion, were stunned long enough for Battlea to step behind them to smash their heads together.

The smoke cleared and the Go Squad were left standing amid a sea of incapacitation. Ruth, seeing that they had taken every one out, relaxed her tensed muscles, but noticed something.

“Where’s Kain?” she called out.

“Here!” he yelled from the catwalk above them, holding a rocket launcher.

Ruth was the first to see him and yelled, “Scatter!”

The Go Squad all turned to face him but he had already pulled the trigger.

Chapter 8

Ruth and the Go Squad dove, each in a direction towards the respective wall they were nearest to, fanning out like a bursting firecracker of human bodies. They covered their heads as they landed, thought of their loved ones.

The explosion roared.

But it was distant. Wrong. Like hearing thunder from the next county over.

Ruth's ears should be ringing. Her body should be shredded. She should be dead.

She peeked up from her defensive position.

Concrete under her palms. Rough. Wet from rain.

She was outside.

Ruth sat up slowly, every movement careful, like her body might fall apart if she moved too fast. The warehouse was fifty feet away. On fire. Burning so hot she could feel the heat from here.

They'd been inside that.

She looked down at her hands. No burns. No blood. Her tactical gear wasn't even singed.

Around her, the Go Squad was getting to their feet, moving like sleepwalkers. Crimson Sable touched his own face like he was checking if it was still there. Night Knight stood frozen, staring at the flames. Gloom Girl was on her hands and knees, hyperventilating.

The unconscious goons were scattered across the dock. All of them outside. All of them breathing.

And Harding Kain. Kain and his security detail were all tied up. Roped, zip-tied, chained. Professional work. The kind that takes time.

None of them had been restrained when the rocket fired.

"Wha . . ." Battlea muttered, just as bewildered as the rest of her team, staring at the warehouse that was on fire.

Ruth's mind tried to process it. They'd been inside when the RPG fired, and they should be dead. Instead they were outside, unharmed, and their targets were somehow bound, which wasn't possible.

Ruth forced herself to move, checking each team member. Aside from shock, they were all uninjured.

"What's going on, Nightingale?" Crimson Sable asked, taking his ski mask off and shaking his head.

"Keep your mask on, Crimson," Night Knight ordered. "We're still on duty!"

Crimson was too flustered to listen.

"Gale?" Gloom Girl called weakly, scared. "What's happening? How did we get here?"

Ruth opened her mouth to speak, but no sound would come out. She scanned her surroundings and counted heads, and her heart dropped.

"Where's Ahdia?" Ruth called out, panic rising in her voice.

The team looked around, checking behind crates and near the bound thugs, and found nothing.

"She was right next to the crate," Battlea said, voice shaking. "When the rocket—"

"We have to go back in!" Ruth started toward the burning warehouse.

Night Knight grabbed her arm. "Ruth, no one could have survived that blast if they were still inside—"

"She saved us somehow! We have to—" Ruth's voice cracked.

The warehouse groaned, part of the roof collapsing inward. Flames roared higher.

"Nightingale . . ." Gloom Girl whispered.

Ruth stared at the inferno. Ahdia had been at the center of it all, the crate and the bullet wound that should have killed her, and now she was gone.

"We need to move," Night Knight said quietly. "Before cops show up."

Ruth didn't respond and couldn't tear her eyes from the fire.

"Gale," Battlea said firmly. "We have to go. Now."

Ruth nodded numbly, letting herself be guided away. She looked back over her shoulder at the warehouse.

At Ahdia's pyre.

Chapter 9

Two nights after the warehouse.

Caledonia.

A city nestled in between twin rivers and a latitudinal location that hits the sweet spot of all the seasons. Goldilocks would have chosen Caledonia after tasting Canada and Mexico.

“Well, good evening and welcome to Carl Tucker Tonight. Presumptive presidential nominee, Harding Kain, as you may have heard, fired back at the media today in Caledonia.”

Like most cities, it is stricken with a severe case of multiple personality syndrome. During the day, a bustling and busy economy keeps the ants marching to their jobs, hobbies and other interests. It has decent theater and even a few well regarded restaurants. Tourists come for the mild climate, the friendly atmosphere and the famed hospitality.

“Mr. Kain has been forthright about the burglary and subsequent explosion in his own personal warehouse business in Caledonia Harbor, praising the police for their response and shunning any accusation that he was involved in any criminal behavior. ‘Don’t believe the liberal press,’ he said in his press conference earlier today.”

At night, a near police state emerges as local law enforcement, led by Police Chief John Whitford, cracks down on the criminal element harder than any other city in the country. The denizens shutter their windows and doors to protect against, not just the supposed rising crime rates in the city, but also from drawing the ire of the gestapo tactics of the police.

“The only crime I see Mr. Kain committing is being a hard working American, burning the midnight oil at one of his businesses that he keeps a personal and close eye on, something, I believe, we can expect when . . . I mean, if he should win the election come November.”

Firas had seen it for himself long before he took to the rooftops: police looting pharmacies to flood the neighborhood with drugs, shooting first and claiming fear for their lives after, ignoring calls for help that came from the wrong people—the ones who hadn’t paid for “protection”. From the criminals, of course.

“He asks the big questions that matter, like questions of whether statues are next? George Washington? Thomas Jefferson? It’s not a joke. Suddenly, our founding fathers are considered evil slave-owners by the fanatics on the left. It means that Jefferson must be purged from public praise forever. Let me be frank, up until a hundred and fifty years ago, slavery was the norm, it had been for thousands of years before that. Sadly.”

Whitford had outlasted many a sitting mayor and had each of them in his corner, promising “law and order,” which meant over-policing the poor neighborhoods and a blind eye for the white-collar kind.

“This does seem like a turning point, not just on the right but on the left. These events of the last two days, where even a potential sitting President of the United States can’t safely operate in this city without thugs with Uzis and drive by shooters terrorizing their business . . .”

Ruth closed the app on her phone and tucked it in her utility belt. Nightly, especially during their patrols, Ruth ruminated on this, the bigotry, the intolerance, knowing that even though it felt like she ultimately wanted to help the police do their job in protecting and serving the citizens, they found themselves at odds with what they've seen the police doing in the course of their duties. The Go Squad had always resisted tangling with the police but if they weren't wearing a badge, much of what they'd seen them do wouldn't give them pause to act.

Tonight was different, and Ruth's mind was elsewhere, to the night of the warehouse, of when they mysteriously survived what was all but certain doom. She tried to measure it against all the training that Firas put the Go Squad through, the group sessions in the dark where they learned to move as one and without any second thoughts, but the training had no answer in it.

None of these things, these grueling, intensive and dangerous things, prepped her for what she was grappling with since the impossible occurred a couple nights ago against Harding Kain.

Two snaps of a finger close to her face caught her attention.

"Gale?" Battlea asked, waving a hand in her face after Ruth turned to her. Her black Lycra ski mask was folded up on her forehead and her annoyed expression was clear. "Can you hear me? Are you with us?"

"Yeah," Ruth replied, sighing. "Sorry. What were you saying?"

Battlea rolled her eyes and repeated, "I said, I don't think we're going to catch any fish here. Night Knight just radioed in and said he's heard there's police band chatter about activity at the Junctions."

Ruth nodded her head in understanding and looked at Gloom Girl, standing by the ledge of the roof they were on, peering through a set of binoculars at the streets.

"Gloomy?" Ruth called. Gloom Girl lowered her binocs and turned to Ruth. "What do you think? Should we make the trip and displace out of here?"

"Couldn't hurt," Gloom Girl replied. "It's been real quiet for a while now."

Ruth shrugged. "Let's do it, then," she agreed.

They didn't fly high over buildings and get mistaken for birds or planes. After all, they were normal people dressed in light black tactical gear. They jumped, bounced, rolled and dove. But when a person in a high enough building who happened to be looking out their window at night saw their movement, they would swear they weren't running; they were gliding across the rooftops.

This was their training, the work Firas spent his whole life honing for this purpose. If the Go Squad members were mistaken to have any kind of powers, it was near perfect topographic knowledge and recall of the Caledonia cityscape; every landing, fire escape, awning, trellis, even missing bricks in walls that gave enough of a usable hold to bound from. If the Go Squad were dropped in any other city, they'd be seriously hampered in their traversing abilities for at least a few weeks until they learned the area well enough to jump off a building's edge with full confidence of what they needed to do to not roll an ankle or fall to their deaths.

Battlea won the unspoken race that the Go Squad always engaged in whenever they did paired or grouped patrols. Gloom Girl finished second and Nightingale struggled in at third. Battlea and Gloom Girl exchanged looks with one another as this wasn't typical. Nightingale was the best of them, even more graceful than Firas who taught her. She was the standard they all strove for.

"You alright, Gale?" Battlea asked, watching Ruth catching her breath.

"Yeah," Ruth said, gulping down a 0.5 liter hydration pack she produced from her utility belt. "Why?"

"You know you don't have to do this right?" Battlea offered.

"Do what?" Ruth asked, wiping the water from her chin.

"We know you're worried about Firas," Gloom Girl said.

"Of course I am," Ruth replied, matter-of-factly. "We all are."

"Yeah, obviously," Battlea said, raising her mask. "But it's clearly affecting you."

"How?" Ruth defended.

"You've been in la-la land all night and were sloppy in a lot of the passes on the way over here," Battlea pointed out, placing a finger against her palm with each point.

Ruth took a deep breath and raised her own mask. "You're right. I am distracted," she admitted. "And, yeah, Firas's injury is weighing on me but I've really been more messed up about what happened at the warehouse."

Battlea and Gloom Girl avoided any and all eye contact. Instead, Battlea grimaced and Gloom Girl squashed an imaginary bug under her shoe as she held her hands behind her.

"Right," Battlea said. "That."

"I mean," Ruth continued. "What part of that makes sense to any of us? You? Gloom Girl?"

Gloom Girl raised her hands in innocence, saying, "I've just upped my medication. I can't think about it or I get panic attacks."

A pang of sadness over that admission struck Ruth. "I'm sorry, Gloomy."

Battlea put her hand on Gloom Girl's shoulder. "Yeah, kid. We're here for you. We're all messed up about it."

"I feel like we all just wanted to accept it so we don't have to think about it," Ruth noted and Gloom Girl slowly nodded her head. "And I think it's because it's easier to do that than try to figure out what the heck happened. I mean . . . Kain had us dead to rights. We were clustered and he fired that RPG at us. I'm not making that up right?" They silently agreed. "So . . . thoughts? Any explanations? I actually considered the smoke bombs were maybe defective and had some kind of hallucinatory side effects? Seems far-fetched but it's the best I can come up with."

The three of them stood around each other silently.

"I'm going street-level. I need space," Gloom Girl said, breaking away and pulling her mask off when she turned away from them so they couldn't see her face, stuffing it into a pocket of her utility belt.

"Gloomy . . ." Battlea called fruitlessly as Gloom Girl hopped over the roof edge onto the fire escape below and out of sight. "Great," Battlea uttered, turning to face Ruth as she gathered her

mask on her forehead. “Did you have to do that with her around? You just heard her say she upped her meds. You know she’s sensitive.”

Ruth was angry with herself, knowing Battlea was right. “Lea,” Ruth exhaled as she dropped her head back and closed her eyes. “I’m going nuts. I could use whatever meds she’s on myself.”

“Yeah, but what good is that going to do you? You know Glooms just avoids dealing with stuff head-on. We’re different,” Battlea assessed. “At least you’re not alone. If you didn’t think to call us for backup before you went in that night and then tried to explain everything that happened to us, we’d probably clip your wings and keep you grounded for a while. Maybe keep you cozy with a straitjacket.”

Ruth walked over to the ledge to look at the street level, watching Gloom Girl lightly jog to a spot in an alleyway in the dark. “I wish I can just let it go. But honestly, the weirdest part is Ahdia.”

Battlea narrowed her eyebrows and came to stand next to Ruth. “Firas’s sister?”

“Yeah. I saw her get shot. There was blood on her clothes. Then I got knocked out and when I came to . . .” Ruth shook her head. “She was just gone. In the fire.”

“You did say the round went through the crate. Maybe it slowed the bullet enough that she could move.”

Ruth shook her head. “I thought of that. But the blood . . . and then how did we all get out? I know I got my head knocked pretty hard but . . .” Ruth groaned. “None of it makes any sense.”

Battlea didn’t have a response. The truth was that she felt just as bewildered as Ruth.

“Nightingale,” the radio crackled, Gloom Girl’s voice coming through. “Police activity, eastbound heading our way.”

They peered in the direction Gloom Girl reported and saw the siren lights of a squad car. It was apparently pulling over a minivan.

“You think the soccer moms are at it again?” Battlea joked.

Ruth squeezed the call button on her hand radio. “Put eyes on, Gloomy,” Ruth ordered.

“Acknowledged,” Gloom Girl said. She pulled out a GoPro camera that was on a headband, activated it and placed it on her head.

Ruth knew these supposedly routine stops were twice as likely to go wrong at night in Caledonia than if it were during the middle of the day. She scanned the area for all the ways she could make it to street level in the fastest ways possible if she needed and then watched the two police officers approach the minivan from both sides, as was normal police procedure.

“They both unclipped their holsters,” Battlea noted.

She was right; the cops both rested their hands on their pistols. The driver side officer knocked on the window and the driver opened it. The officer shined his flashlight into the person’s face, blinding them.

Ruth squeezed her radio and said, “Gloomy, you got audio?”

“Standby,” she replied and reached into her utility to pull out a collapsed audio device. She opened the fan and connected the sound amplifier into the hand radio with an AUX cable in

another pouch on her belt. She squeezed the radio and announced, “Go for audio.”

Ruth and Battlea listened to the tinny audio broadcast through.

“Where you heading?”

“Home.”

“Where from?”

“Out for dinner. It’s my daughter’s birthday.”

“Yeah, right. Step out of the vehicle.”

“Why?”

“I said, step out of the car.”

The officer on the passenger side door attempted to slide open the minivan door.

“I want to know why! I have the right to know what crime I’ve committed.”

“Right now, it’s obstruction if you don’t do what I say.”

“No! I didn’t do nothing wrong! I don’t have to get out of the car.”

The officer then drew his weapon and pointed it at the driver. The frightened cry of a child could be heard, both from the radio and on the street.

Chapter 10

That same night.

“Get out of the car! Now!” the officer demanded loudly.

His partner also drew his weapon and pointed it into the back of the minivan where the child was.

“You seeing this?!” Gloom Girl radioed.

“Confirmed, Gloom Girl,” Ruth replied. “Do not engage. Maintain visual surveillance and monitor the situation.”

The driver slowly opened the door.

“Hands! Show me your hands!” the officer demanded.

“Mommy!” the child screamed.

“Please, officer, that’s my six-year-old, please don’t hurt us,” the driver pleaded, raising her hands.

“Step out of the vehicle!” the officer shouted. “Slowly!”

When she had her feet on the road, the officer grabbed her arm and forcefully pulled her toward the ground, laying her out on her stomach.

“What the hell?!” Gloom Girl was heard.

“Stand down, Gloomy,” Ruth repeated as calmly as she could.

The officer on the passenger side suddenly used his flashlight to bust open the passenger side door. The child screamed even louder as the mother on the ground, who had a police officer kneeling on her back, begged through tears to not hurt her child. The passenger side officer slid open the door and had his gun trained on the child. He reached with his free hand to unbuckle the car seat and then pulled the child out violently.

“What did we do? What is this about?!” the mother yelled. “Why are you doing this?”

The passenger side officer put the child on the floor and kicked the child’s knee pit to make them drop. He then applied a set of handcuffs.

“That’s it,” Gloom Girl said before the audio cut.

“Gloom Girl!” Ruth barked into the radio. “Stand down! Come in!”

“Damn it. I’m going in,” Battlea announced, pulling down her mask as she stepped up onto the ledge and dropped down the face of the building onto an elevated platform that the window cleaners left two stories down. She landed with a thud and a loud clang that drew the attention of the officers. She immediately did a safety roll off the edge, grasping the platform to hang down to soften a drop onto a ledge on the wall and then turned to land on the street.

Gloom Girl ripped off the GoPro and clipped it to her chest. As she sprinted up from behind the officer handcuffing the child, she pulled out her mask and yanked it down over her head. When she reached him, he was distracted by Battlea’s diversion, so Gloom Girl roundhouse kicked the handgun out of his hand with her right, followed the motion to plant that foot on the ground and

spun to follow with a sidekick with her left leg to the officer's knees, the way he did to the child but with much more force.

The officer on the mother couldn't see what was occurring on the other side of the minivan but turned to see what the commotion was, allowing enough time for Battlea to close the ground she needed to land a flying double sidekick, sending the cop brutally into the open driver side all the way through to the passenger seat.

A thud could be heard on the passenger side from the officer's impact as the van rocked on its sides, making the child flinch while Gloom Girl bent to elbow strike the ribs, crumpling him down, then reached up to hold onto his wrist. She raised her leg above his head and locked the back of his neck under her knee, then jumped with her other leg to wrap under and around his arm. Like a pendulum, she used her body weight to swing him to the ground. Landing on her back with the cop, face down, locked in an arm bar, he yelped in pain as she applied firm pressure with the leverage she created.

Ruth breathed a sigh of relief as she saw with her binoculars that the two takedowns were fast and before backup was requested. Battlea helped the mother up to her feet and then swung around to the sidewalk as Gloom Girl attached the handcuffs the cop was holding onto his wrist. Battlea helped strap the other cuff behind his back and then opened the passenger door, causing the unconscious cop to tumble out from the passenger seat.

In the distance, Ruth heard the whop-whop of a helicopter getting louder and louder. Looking up towards the sound, she saw a police helicopter in the distance heading their way. It couldn't have been for them, she assumed but kept her eyes on it as it distinctly looked like it was heading straight for them. She didn't want to risk being wrong.

"Bail, bail, bail," she repeated on the radio for the two on the street to hear. "Helo inbound, could be for us. Scatter!"

Gloom Girl smiled and waved at the little girl after she helped her back into her car seat. The minivan started off down the road. Battlea nudged Gloom Girl, urging her to run and they sprinted down the alleyway.

A spotlight from the helicopter shattered the dark of the alley they were in, revealing them as clear as day. "This is the police!" a voice through a megaphone demanded. "Stop where you are!"

As they reached the end of the alleyway, Battlea called out, "Divide and conquer?"

"Yeah!" Gloom Girl agreed and split into opposite directions, Battlea going east.

Meanwhile, Ruth flitted from rooftop to rooftop to try to keep up and not get spotted by the helicopter. She looked up and saw that the helicopter turned westbound.

Her radio blared Battlea's voice, "Nightingale, Nightingale! The helo turned west and is on Gloom Girl's six. Do you copy?"

"Copy, Battlea," Ruth responded. "I'm in pursuit. Hang tight, Gloomy!"

Her performance was affected before, they were right and she knew it immediately when they called her out. Now, she was laser-focused in. Her best freerunning always came to her when she wasn't thinking and was reacting to the topography, when she trusted her memory and instincts. At

times, she even surprised herself after a particularly daring maneuver but only well after she was home, usually while showering off the night's patrol. It was also whenever a teammate needed help when she found that extra gear for her motor.

Gloom Girl was almost balletic in her movements but speed wasn't her strongest attribute. If she had any chance of losing a helicopter, it was by finding cover and maneuvering tight spaces. Ruth knew if she followed the helicopter, it would lead her to Gloom Girl but too late, after they reached her. She needed to anticipate where Gloom Girl would go.

"I've got bogeys! They've sicced dogs on me!" Battlea reported through the comms.

Ruth stopped in her tracks. She suddenly had a choice to make. She could double back and try to draw off Battlea's tail onto her and hope Gloom Girl finds somewhere to hide as she suspected she would be able to, or leave Battlea on her own, hope for the best and continue to find Gloom Girl.

"Nightingale to Night Knight, come in Night Knight," she barked into her handheld.

"Go for Night Knight!" he cried through the radio.

"Are you okay?"

"Ask me in a few minutes! I got ambushed by the fuzz. I'm high tailin' it right now!" he replied. It sounded like he was running.

"Where's Crimson?" she asked.

"On my way to Battlea," Crimson cut into the frequency, sounding relaxed.

"What, are you taking a taxi? You don't sound like you're in a rush," Ruth commented.

"Something like that," Crimson Sable said as he prepared to leap off the train he was riding on top of.

"Everyone on comms," Ruth said. "Elvis has left the building, I repeat, Elvis has left the building!" she said before clipping her radio and continuing to where she thought Gloom Girl would be.

"Elvis has left the building," was their code phrase to separate, lay low, and wait for an all clear transmission. They never had to use it before because this level of police attention was brand new. They weren't even aware anyone, let alone the police, knew of their existence.

The helicopter spotlight locked onto Gloom Girl and it seemed like no matter what she did, they knew where she was. She knew of a construction site that she could duck into and find cover but it was across one of the rivers and she was almost certain the bridge would be a bottleneck for them to cut her off. She was running out of breath, her legs were beginning to feel like jelly, and her hand grip strength fatigued. She decided to risk it figuring that if she didn't try for it, she was done for anyway.

The bridge was in sight but she knew it meant a dead sprint, something she didn't have in her body at the moment. Seeing scaffolding on a building face, she turned a quick corner and disappeared under the awning, holding on to the bars to stay off the sidewalk. She breathed hard as she grabbed a hydration pack from her utility, draining it down her throat and then dropping it to the ground. The helicopter rotors echoed in the awning she was hiding, hovering like a hawk

waiting for the mouse to make its move.

It was only appropriate that the helicopter chose her, she considered as she slowed her heart rate. She was, after all, the one that disobeyed the order from Nightingale to stand down. But how could she stand down? Every time they had seen something like this in the past while on patrol, their general rule was to record it with their cameras and not intervene. Let YouTube do the rest in exposing the police. But a child was being arrested. Was that cop even going to be able to apply adult sized cuffs onto a six-year-old?

After a few more breaths trying to psych herself up, she descended to the sidewalk and bolted with everything she had left. The helicopter was caught off guard but quickly found her running on the bridge. Controlling her breathing as much as she could, she pushed herself up the incline and reached the top, stopping when she saw the line of police cars cutting her off at the pass. She turned around to see another set of police cars coming to a stop behind her.

“It’s over!” a loud voice said through a police megaphone. “Get down on your knees and put your hands on your head.”

She felt her heart pounding twice for every second and her lungs burning as she gasped for air. She laced her hands on her head but to expand her lungs for air and wandered to the edge of the bridge.

“Get down! Right where you are!” the voice demanded.

She looked over the edge and saw the water below, wondering if she could survive the fall. Even if she did, swimming was almost harder than sprinting for miles as she had just done and they’d be waiting for her on the shore. As her breathing and heart rate slowed, Gloom Girl climbed up the railing and balanced on the ledge.

“Don’t do it! Get down now!” the megaphone blared.

She looked to her left at the police and held up a rude gesture. She did a swan dive off the bridge. Ruth was watching from a building near the bridge through a pair of binoculars.

“No!” she screamed when she saw Gloom Girl jump.

Chapter 11

That same night.

The helicopter decided to go after Gloom Girl in the shell game. A selfish part of her was relieved but the team-first mentality Battlea harbored knew she was faster than Gloom Girl. Gloom Girl was agile, downright bendy, but it would take pure speed to try and lose a helicopter on foot. Speed and creativity.

She was sprinting on street-level. The goal in her mind was to run to a spot where she knew she had a stash . . . a small duffel bag hidden in various points throughout the city that contained a baseball cap, overalls and a bomber coat. Firas's idea and one that Battlea always thought was a bit on the paranoid side; when would they ever need to do a quick change? Well, here was a golden opportunity and she was glad that when she needed it, it was available . . . as long as she could get there without being seen.

She turned a corner and stopped dead in her tracks. A police blockade. For little old me, she thought. She turned 180 degrees and took a few steps before an identical impediment blocked the next block. In moments like these, as far as her training in Firas's school went, there was always an out. A foothold or handhold that normal people don't see. All it takes is one to get over.

She turned to her left and right, scanning for an escape—a hole in a wooden fence leading into a construction yard. That was it. She did a dead dash and leapt, jamming her foot in the hole the size of a can of Coke and used the forward momentum she had and pushed herself up and over. She landed on an unexpected dirt hill.

Tumbling down, she didn't panic and performed one safety roll after the other until she reached the bottom. Recovering smoothly from the last roll onto her feet, she continued sprinting into the darkness of underneath the concrete floor that was being suspended by girder support beams. Battlea felt the urge to chuckle, thinking about all the trouble the cops put themselves through to trap her, until she had to stop due to a sheer wall about twenty feet high. She was trapped.

Voices of excited men floated in from behind her, flashlights beaming from the entrance of the construction site. Battlea turned away from the direction but stayed near the wall in the cover of darkness.

As she was afraid of, the site dead-ended and she was literally cornered in the foundations built for what was intended to be a new skyscraper. She knew her only option was to fight her way out and that wasn't going to last very long.

Seeing a group bustling their way into the underway she was in, she ducked behind a workbench and held her breath. She wondered what it would be like, getting arrested. She wondered if she should ditch her utility belt so when she was apprehended, she could claim she was some crazy woman in the eyes of a judge and not a street vigilante. It would be a flimsy defense but plausible and that might be all the cards she had left to play in her hand.

A wave of cops canvassed the dark, gradually illuminating the whole area, like the tide flowing onto the coast. A police officer slowly advanced onto the workbench she was hiding under. Battlea reached over her head and grabbed a wrench that was lying on top. She heaved it as far as she could in the dark air over the line of cops and it clanged against a far support beam.

Everyone turned and faced their flashlights to the beam that rang out an unexpected sound. Seeing her chance, she bounded from her hiding spot to the nearest officer and swung around him using his body like a pole, finishing with a double kick to the officer next to him, sending that one flying back, while dragging the unsuspecting officer she was using as a sling to the ground. Landing next to him, she delivered an elbow to his face, connecting with a Plexiglas face mask that was attached to the helmet he had on. Still, a strong enough blow dazed him, giving her time to stand up to face whoever else might be next for her to attack.

The next nearest officer shouted, “Found her! She’s here! Open fire!”

Open fire? Seemed a bit excessive. That was her cue to dive towards the officer on the ground that she first kicked. She did a safety roll on top of his laid out body, turning him over on top of her. A few trigger-happy cops fired and hit their fellow officer in the bulletproof vest he was wearing that Battlea used as cover. She heard her human shield cry out in pain.

“Cease fire! Cease fire!” someone quickly yelled.

“Fire in the hole!” someone else yelled before popping a canister in his hand and rolling it towards her.

Recognizing it to be either tear gas or a stun grenade, she knew the timing from when the pin was pulled was up to six seconds and she hoped it wasn’t too late before she quickly rolled over onto her stomach, did a modified stationary catpass from prone and kicked back the rolling detonating device.

The second she did so, the officer who sent it dove out of the way. It flashed after a loud pop. A flashbang, she noted, judging by the sudden ringing in her ears. At least she wasn’t blinded she figured and hoped that maybe some of them were.

She lay back and did a kip-up to get on her feet. Scanning the environment, she registered about ten flashlights still blocking her way. These cops were intent on using lethal force. She’d go down fighting, she accepted. Getting arrested wasn’t an option.

A shot fired and buried itself into her body armor under the right clavicle bone. She fell down onto her back, sucking air after she felt it all knocked out of her. The pain was tremendous but her adrenaline allowed her to roll over and army crawl back towards the workbench. It was over, she knew.

A commotion could be heard and Battlea was surprised she made it all the way to the workbench, sitting and leaning on it to catch her breath. When she peeked around, she saw a cloud of smoke and a flurry of movement from what seemed to be a bo staff.

Crimson! she recognized. She reached into her utility belt to put on her infrared goggles and saw her teammate, Crimson Sable, fluidly disabling anyone he could get to, one by one, with elegant lines of successive strikes.

The smoke would clear soon and he'd be exposed, she knew. She pushed aside the choking pain in her chest and scrambled towards him.

"Sable!" she called, so that he wouldn't mistakenly strike her. "Behind you!"

She landed a vicious left overhand, hopping to build momentum as though she were throwing a baseball to home from the outfield, on the soft part between the body armor and helmet on the neck of an officer wandering obliviously in the smoke directly behind Crimson.

"Thanks, chica," he said, proceeding to plant what turned out to be a rebar staff on the ground to block an attempt by a cop to hit him with a swinging rifle butt to the midsection. Crimson executed a turning kick to the cop's helmet and used the rebar to balance himself, reversing the kick for two immediately successive kicks, enough to take down his target.

"We gotta make waves!" Battlea yelled.

"Agreed," Crimson replied dropping the rebar in a loud heavy clang as he knelt down, grabbed a flashbang from the cop he just felled, pulled the pin and threw it towards the remaining cops.

As the smoke cleared, only a few cops were left unharmed but confused as to what had happened, dazed from the stun grenade. The two of them were out of sight.

When they reached a rooftop of a nearby building, Battlea collapsed on a brick roof door vestibule. Crimson knelt in front of her, taking off his goggles and examined her to make sure she wasn't badly wounded. No blood, which was good, but he knew from experience how much it still hurt to be shot in the armor.

"That's going to be a nice bruise tomorrow," he commented.

"Maybe if you're nice to me, I'll show it to you later," she managed to crack.

"That a promise? Because if so, you have a deal, señorita," he smiled. "I thought you said there were dogs."

"Freeze!" a voice from the ledge of the building shouted. They were coming up from the fire escape.

"These guys won't quit!" Crimson shouted, standing up between her and the cops.

One by one, the remaining group of cops in the SWAT team filed onto the roof, their semi-automatic weapons drawn on them with flashlights. Crimson held his hands up.

"Get on your knees!" he ordered.

Crimson didn't move. He looked back and down at Battlea. They shared an understanding look; they'd go down fighting.

"I said get on your knees!" the cop ordered again, coming close enough to put the muzzle inches from Sable's face.

Crimson Sable quickly pushed the muzzle with his right hand, moving it slightly to the left of his head as the officer reacted and fired. The loudness was expected even if it still rang in Crimson's ears. Ignoring it the best he could, he threw an open hand quick jab at the officer's throat, causing him to choke. From the ground, Battlea kicked the cop's knee in a sickening crunch, crumpling him to the floor.

Crimson knew he needed to act fast to get to the others, but the other officers began pulling their triggers at him.

To the surprise of everyone, none of their weapons fired, allowing him the window to land a form perfect sidekick on the sternum of the nearest officer to him.

And again, to the surprise of everyone, including Crimson, the officer was kicked like a rag doll clear off the roof to the next building, apparently kicked so hard, he left behind his weapon and helmet.

Everyone froze, staring at the officer writhing in pain a block away, then turned their attention to Crimson to see if he was some sort of three-headed beast. Nope, just a normal looking dude in black tactical gear in a fighting stance, looking just as shocked as they did.

Someone finally snapped out of it and yelled, “Open fire! Open fire!”

That shook everyone awake. Sable jumped, rotating his hips to be horizontal in the air, landing a downward kick on the shoulder of an officer, leveling him into the ground in an impact crater. They kept pulling their triggers but none of their weapons fired.

Battlea shoulder charged an officer into another officer and they both violently crashed through the ledge, about ten yards away, falling onto the fire escape. Dumbfounded, she looked over at Crimson after he uppercut another SWAT cop ten feet straight up into the air. They looked at each other and both shrugged while in fighting stances and then looked at the remainder of the SWAT team left standing. They made a quick calculation and retreated down the fire escape, picking up their downed teammates to drag back with them.

“Crimson . . .” Battlea said, relaxing her stance and looking around at the damage they inflicted. “What the hell is going on?”

Crimson Sable followed the retreating police to the ledge and watched them urgently descend the stairs. He turned around with his hands up like Rocky and yelled, “I’m a freakin’ superhero!”

Chapter 12

Night Knight jumped where he stood. Gravity handed him back the usual couple of feet. The team watched him expectantly anyway. He shook his head and reset into an athletic crouch. He focused on some point above the rafters and jumped again, straining for it. He came down on the same mat, the same man, disappointed.

“I swear, it was like . . .” He carved a long flat arc through the air with one hand. “Fffffwwwweeeuuuuhhhh!”

Firas watched from a plyo box by the office door. He had picked the box because sitting on it looked voluntary, and because standing for a whole meeting was past him, since Ruth had ordered bed and he had bargained her down to this, seated, one morning only.

“I thought I was going to get arrested,” Night Knight said, dropping his arms. “I was on the rooftops when on one particular jump, I just frickin’ flew. Well, it was more like a super-jump if I’m being honest, not like Superman flying. But it was like a quarter-mile, based on how many blocks I covered in a single bound!”

Ruth stood against the doorframe with her arms folded. “Firas, I know it sounds crazy. I was there and I’m still struggling to believe it.” She had walked him through the bridge part twice already, slowly, in the cadence she saved for bad labs: Gloom Girl mid-air over the river, then gone between one blink and the next. Then a body dropping out of an empty sky four blocks inland, unhurt, and a third telling that had not made any of it smaller.

“Look, look, look!” Sable had found the remote and was aiming it at the wall TV, urgently thumbing the volume up.

“. . . reports of a burglar and alleged assault perpetrator jumping then . . .” The helicopter footage was grainy and wide, a small figure balanced on the bridge rail. “. . . vanishing into thin air. The police are withholding speculation but experts think this is the work of a master illusionist.”

The anchor handed off to an ad break, and Harding Kain filled the screen in a three-piece suit, heavy rings catching the studio light, promising a country that worked again. Ruth crossed the mat and put the screen dark with her thumb.

“It probably has something to do with what happened that night at the warehouse. We all teleported out of there, out of range of the RPG. We were all dead if not for that.”

Gloom Girl’s hand shot up. “Maybe I did it!” She sat cross-legged on a crash mat with her hood up. “I mean . . . I don’t remember doing it, but I don’t remember doing it last night, either. Maybe my powers are panic-based?”

“None of us can do it again,” Battlea put in, rotating her left shoulder, testing where last night had left its mark. “We’ve been trying.”

Firas leaned forward on the box. “Let’s . . . table that for now. What was with the police presence last night?”

“Yeah, that was extra as hell,” Gloom Girl agreed, tugging the hood lower over her eyes.

“If what you all are telling me is true . . .” He heard himself dole the rest of it out in pieces, each piece heavier to lift than the last. “. . . and you all can’t control your . . . ‘powers’ . . . we may have to discuss . . . disbanding.”

“Disbanding?” Night Knight echoed.

“It’s for everyone’s safety,” Firas told them, and even he could hear how little that weighed.

“No offense, jefe,” Sable offered. “If any one of us cared that much about our personal safety, we wouldn’t be going out every night dressed like urban ninjas looking for trouble.”

“We’re not quitting,” Battlea said.

“Look,” Firas said. He pushed himself upright off the box, one hand flat on it for the launch, because some sentences could not be delivered sitting down. “What do you think? I started this. I trained you all. And guess what? That makes me responsible for you all. And last night, it could have ended in the worst ways,” he went on, his eyes on Gloom Girl. “We have to consider ending it before it comes to that.”

“Even if we disband,” Gloom Girl pointed out. “You know we’re still going out on our own. We’re safer together.”

He ran that one four different ways, hunting for the counter, and there wasn’t one, so he sat back down.

“My question is,” Night Knight said. “How did the cops know where we were all going to be? It seems like all of us faced down a whole precinct each. They kettled us in three different areas of the city at the same time. What are the odds?”

“What are you saying, Night Knight?” Firas asked.

“I’m saying . . . who among us . . . leaked?” He let each pause sit there and do its work.

Every eye in the room found Gloom Girl. And settled there.

“What?”

“Gloomy,” Ruth said. “We know.”

“That’s not fair. I don’t know a thing about any of you.”

“No one should,” Firas answered. “That’s how I recruited you all. Individually. But you’re the most public figure in the room.”

“I don’t even talk to my dad anymore. Do you guys know that?” She looked from face to face, demanding a flicker of surprise, and got none.

“We do,” Ruth told her. “Of course. But that doesn’t mean your father, the Caledonia Police Chief, doesn’t have the means to track you anyway.”

“I . . . I don’t know,” Gloom Girl managed, crossing her arms and turning her face toward the climbing wall.

The silence stretched thin, and Sable was the one who paid to break it.

“I’m a director at a non-profit,” he said. “My day job. We do community organizing for things like food drives and consumer advocacy. My name is Victor. Victor Hernandez.”

Four years of masks, handed over in one plain sentence, and Battlea straightened up beside him before it could cool.

“I’m Leah Turner. I’m a barista at the Bean Post. I’m also the jammer on the Caledonia Roller Derby team.”

“Ben. Bukowski. I’m a . . .” Night Knight hunted for a dignified way into it.

“Personal trainer,” the whole room answered at once.

“That obvious, huh?” He grinned sheepishly at the floor.

“I’m Ruth Carter. I’m a doctor,” Ruth said, crossing to the crash mat and crouching to Gloom Girl’s level. “We trust you, Tess. That’s not what Night Knight . . . Ben was saying.”

“It’s about time you all did this,” Firas allowed. “It was starting to get weird.”

That bought the first laugh of the morning, a small one. Tess did not join it; she unfolded her arms and got to her feet.

“There’s something else I need to say.” She took a breath. “I’ve been . . . posting about us. On social media. The Go Squad stuff, the videos, the hashtags—that’s me. I started it.” She pressed on before anyone in the room could load a reply. “I know you said stay secret, Firas, but people needed to see. Someone was fighting back. Caledonia needed that hope.”

“Tess—” Firas lifted a hand.

She rode straight over him. “I’m sorry I didn’t tell you earlier. But it’s working. People believe in us. They actually have hope that things can change.” Her chin came up. “And now with these . . . powers? We could actually be what I’ve been telling them we are. Real heroes.”

Battlea reached over and squeezed her shoulder. “People did need to see. You weren’t wrong about that.”

“Though it does mean we’re kind of . . . public now. That’s more exposure than we planned.” Night Knight shifted his weight uncomfortably.

“Exposure that’s giving people hope,” Ruth countered. “That matters.”

Firas looked around the room and understood the vote had ended before it opened. “Just . . . be careful what you post,” he said at last. “If we have powers now, we’re in a different category. Bigger risks.”

“I know,” Tess promised. “I will be.”

The room loosened by a degree, but Ruth did not.

“Firas,” Ruth said. “What about Ahdia?”

The dagger sat on the filing cabinet just inside his office door, where he had set it that morning, squarely in his line of sight, so that he would stop waiting for the phone to ring. He looked at it instead of at her.

“She didn’t make it out,” Firas said. “The warehouse. She was . . . she didn’t make it.”

“I’m sorry, man,” Night Knight offered.

Something rose in Firas then, fast and wordless, like water coming under a door, and he did the only thing he ever did with a thing that rose. He outran it.

“Honestly? Maybe it’s for the best.” The crack in the middle of the sentence surprised him, and he kept going over it. “My sister was already dead inside anyway. All she did was sit in that penthouse watching TV eight hours a day and eight hours a night, living on raspberry freezes and gummy bears. She gave up on life years ago.” He dragged the heel of his hand across his eyes and one tear got loose and headed down his cheek. “At least this way it was quick.”

The tear stopped halfway down.

So did everything else. The dust in the window light hung like stars, Ruth was fixed mid-breath, and Sable’s hand had stopped short of his own jaw. Nothing in the room needed to move, so nothing did.

Behind the big blue foam vault at the far end of the activity area, Ahdia Bacchus got to her feet.

She had heard every word. Eight hours a day and eight hours a night. He had the numbers right, and the rest she was not going to sort now, or possibly ever.

She crossed the floor between the mats. Her sneakers made no sound, none, not even to her. She kept her hands in close and touched nothing, because the room had the exact look of a paused frame, and the one rule everybody knows about a paused frame is that you don’t smudge the screen.

She stopped in front of her brother. The tear hung on his cheek, mid-fall, lit from the side. He had called her dead inside with wet eyes, and both of those were his, and neither one canceled the other. She shook her head at him. Then she stuck her tongue out, the full childhood version, all the way.

“Very mature, Ms. Bacchus.”

“What the—” She spun around.

It hovered at eye level, small and sleek and metallic, not quite committed to being real, its edges a shade too clean for the room around it. She knew it. It had hung in the warehouse smoke, and waited beyond her penthouse window at three in the morning, and found her twice in the hours she spent teaching herself what she could do now. A light on its face swept her from head to foot.

“Wait—”

The light climbed past white, and space folded inward.

* * *

The tear finished its fall. Nobody had spoken since he said it, and the silence in the room had a current running through it now.

“Wait, what?” Ruth cut through it. “What did you just say?”

For half a second Firas would have sworn somebody had been standing in front of him, near enough to touch. He looked past Ruth. The blue vault at the far end, the empty mats, nobody at all. Grief, he decided, inventing company for him, and he put it down and left it down.

“Did you seriously just say ‘maybe it’s for the best’ about your sister dying?” The quiet in the question was worse than any volume Ruth owned.

“I didn’t—” He got two words out.

“She was shot protecting people she didn’t even know!” Ruth took a step toward him. “She died in that warehouse trying to help us, and you just—”

“Ruth—”

“‘Already dead inside’?” Gloom Girl had gone small on her mat, hood forward, knees up. “That’s what you think about people who are depressed?”

“No, I didn’t mean—” The edges of the room went white on him.

“Then what did you mean?” Battlea’s arms were crossed again. “Because it sounded like you meant exactly that.”

“I was grieving, I didn’t—” He reached in every direction and found no handholds anywhere.

“Grieving doesn’t make you cruel,” Night Knight said, with no heat in it at all, which made it land harder. “That was cruel, man.”

He had meant every word, and he had not meant one of them, and both things stayed. On the filing cabinet the dagger lay where he had put it, meaning what he had put it there to mean.

“I don’t—” The crack went all the way through this time. “I don’t know how to do this. I don’t know how to—”

His legs gave out the rest of it, and he went down onto the plyo box hard enough to feel it in the wound, elbows on knees, face in his hands.

“You process it,” Ruth told him, sitting down beside him on the box, close, not touching. “You feel it. You don’t make it about whether she was good enough to deserve being alive.”

Nobody else moved for a while and the window light had gone back to ordinary, the dust all settled out of it. In the corner by the blue vault, the air stayed still, and stayed empty.

Chapter 13

Star Trek had prepared her for a shimmer and a polite chime. Star Trek had lied. Every atom she owned screamed at once that “here” had been a lie all along, and the lie was being edited out from under her, cell by cell, each one getting the memo at a different moment. No travel happened. It was more like being recast mid-episode. Reality changed its mind about her address, and the only calm thing anywhere in her was the Hyper Seed, sitting where her heart should be, reading the correction as she used to read subtitles.

She reassembled in the dark, on cold concrete, on her hands and knees, and threw up. She did it again. Then she stayed down until her arms agreed to hold her.

The dark turned out to be the shadow of something large and humming. Ahdia spat, wiped her mouth on her sleeve, and made herself look up.

Gravel under her palms. A low parapet. A sky the exact color of dishwater. The humming thing was an air-conditioning unit she knew, because Firas had once spent an entire dinner mourning the three grand it cost to replace after Night Knight tried a wall run on it. The Academy roof, then: she was sitting above the room she had just left, close enough that her own funeral was probably still in session under her sneakers.

Two strangers stood near the roof edge, unbothered by the drop behind them. The woman was silver-gray and somewhere past fifty-five, dressed for a conference room that billed by the hour, and she studied Ahdia slowly and from above. The man beside her had a military posture his civilian clothes could not talk him out of. He carried two paper coffee cups.

“Apologies for the disorientation,” the woman said, in the practiced tone of an airline announcing a delay it had caused. “Translocation affects everyone that way. It doesn’t improve with repetition.”

Something to look forward to, then.

“Ms. Bacchus,” the woman went on. “I’m Director Harriet Bourn. CADENS. This is Colonel Bentley Mack.” She let a pause open up, one you could have parked a car in. “We need to talk.”

“You’ve been watching me.” The words came out scraped raw, as if she had spent the trip between there and here screaming.

“Yes.”

“The whole time.”

“Yes.”

“Since the warehouse.”

“Before that, actually. We were monitoring Kain. You became relevant when you bonded with the Hyper Seed.”

Relevant. She filed the word away for some colder hour with the TV on. “Where’s my brother?”

“Downstairs. With his team. Time resumed normally after we extracted you.” Nothing in Bourn’s face moved while she delivered any of this. “They’re processing what he said about you.”

Processing. A generous word for a room where “already dead inside” was still circling the mats with “maybe for the best” flying wing behind it. Her stomach rolled again. She decided, officially, that it was still the translocation.

“You should sit,” Bourn told her.

A folding chair stood open on the gravel. Ahdia was fairly sure it had not existed four seconds ago. Naturally, these people owned footage of her with her “tongue out” at her frozen brother. Somewhere a log entry read “throwing up on gravel,” timestamped and cross-referenced. They had known she would need a chair before she did. She sat, mostly because her legs voted early.

Mack crossed the roof and held out one of the cups. “It’s terrible,” he said. “But it’s caffeinated.”

The cup was warm and real and stupidly ordinary. Her hands closed around it like disaster-movie survivors close around blankets.

“What do you know about CADENS?” Bourn asked.

“Literally nothing. Except you have creepy drones and you kidnapped me with physics.”

“We didn’t kidnap you. We relocated you for a conversation.”

“That’s just kidnapping with better PR.”

Mack’s mouth moved a quarter of an inch. On him that apparently counted as applause.

“CADENS,” Bourn said, “is the Cataclysm Activity Detection and Engagement Network Sentry. We monitor and respond to cosmic-level threats. Events that fall outside normal understanding. Dimensional incursions. Reality fractures. Artifacts like the Hyper Seed.”

“So you’re like . . . government X-Files.”

“Something like that.”

“And you want something from me.”

“We want to show you what we know. Then we’ll discuss what happens next.”

The air above Bourn’s shoulder rippled, and the drone was there, as a fish is there once the water settles. It was the same one, and its surface slid like oil on water, colors moving across it without ever choosing one. Ahdia’s grip tightened on the cup.

“What is that thing?”

“Field-Adaptive Entanglement Reconnaissance and Infiltration System,” Bourn answered, each syllable worn smooth from years of use. “FAERIS for short. Advanced surveillance and translocation technology. This particular unit has been tracking you since the warehouse.”

“Tracking me.”

“Among other things.” That was Mack, into his coffee.

Bourn’s eyes stayed level, and somehow that was worse than any amount of volume. “You’ve been operating under the assumption that you were hidden. Training in secret. Helping your brother’s team without them knowing. We need you to understand: you were never hidden. We’ve been watching since the beginning.”

All that sneaking around she had been so proud of. Invisibility was the one thing she had been certain she owned, and it had been a set the whole time, and she had been the show without ever once getting to read the script.

"FAERIS," Bourn said. "Warehouse incident. Night of August 14th. Begin playback."

The drone brightened. Light with shape in it rose off its shell. The warehouse assembled itself above the gravel in translucent gray-blue, rafters and catwalks and crates, correct down to the smell her memory supplied for free. And there, easing along a catwalk with a wooden plank held like a sword nobody had issued her, went a small determined idiot in pajamas.

"Wait," Ahdia blurted. "Is that . . . what I was wearing?"

"Business casual pajamas," Mack supplied. "And a wooden plank."

"We had three drones positioned around the warehouse," Bourn continued. "Monitoring Kain's activity. You and Dr. Carter were . . . unexpected variables."

The footage ran on. Ruth arrived in the little gray world, fluid as water finding a drain. Then the gunman. Then the muzzle flash, her own past knees buckling, a dark stain opening across a tiny pajama shirt. Ahdia's hand went flat against her own chest, against unscarred skin, checking. Nothing there now. It didn't help as much as advertised.

"FAERIS," Bourn prompted. "Her vitals at impact."

"Heart rate dropping. Blood pressure 60 over 40. Survival probability: 3.7%."

"You should have died," Mack told her, with the flat courtesy of a man reporting weather. "We thought you did."

So she had now watched her own death scene in dailies, with the crew, and the coffee trembled slightly in her hands, and she let it.

The rescue ran compressed: smoke, goggles, small gray figures moving in choreography she recognized from underneath. Kain shouldered the launcher. The rocket left the tube.

"Then this happened," Bourn said, and the little world stopped. The rocket hung mid-air, exhaust sculpted behind it. On the warehouse floor, the dying girl stood up.

Ahdia came halfway out of the chair. "What the hell?"

"FAERIS," Bourn said. "Time dilation parameters."

"Gravitational anomalies detected across 47-meter radius," the drone reported. "Subject vital signs: heart rate zero, respiration zero, body temperature dropping. Subject remains ambulatory."

Heart rate zero. She had walked around clinically dead and improvised. She added it to the list of words that would need a colder hour.

The display slid to the crate. Her past self reached in. The thing that refused to be three-dimensional folded into a point of light, and the light ran up the tiny arm and sank into the tiny chest, and the figure convulsed and dropped. On the roof, one full second late, Ahdia's whole body flinched in sympathy.

"What happened there?" she asked, though part of her had voted against knowing.

"We're not sure," Bourn admitted, and seemed to dislike the taste of it. "Our sensors detected massive energy discharge. Visual distortion. Something that might have been communication, but

we couldn’t capture it. You were unconscious for 2.3 seconds. What did you experience?”

Ahdia looked into her coffee for a long moment. “I saw . . . things. Images. It was like having a whole encyclopedia downloaded into my brain in two seconds except I couldn’t read any of it. Just flashes. Something massive—I can’t even describe it, like trying to describe a color that doesn’t exist. A moon forming. Earth, but wrong, like from space billions of years ago. And . . .”

The end of that sentence went somewhere she couldn’t follow. She let it go. “This sounds insane.”

“Ms. Bacchus, you bonded with an interdimensional artifact while dying. ‘Insane’ is baseline.”

“I felt like I was being watched. By something huge. And then it was just . . . over.” Gooseflesh climbed her arms, and the terrible coffee did nothing against it. “When I came to, the bullet wound was healed. I knew I could freeze time. I didn’t know how I knew. I just did.”

“That’s when we knew,” Bourn went on. “Previous Temporalists took decades to achieve initial bonding. You did it while dying. In less time than it takes to blink.”

“How many?” Ahdia asked, and Bourn tilted her head a single degree. “Previous Temporalists. How many were there?”

“Records suggest seven over the past three millennia. None in the last four hundred years. We thought the lineage was extinct.”

Seven people in three thousand years, and the universe had cast a woman who once cried at a yogurt commercial. Somebody upstairs needed to fire their casting director.

“You saved him,” Mack put in. “Kain. You could’ve left him in the blast. No one would’ve known.”

On the display, her past self hauled Kain’s bulk clear of the frozen fireball, bound him methodically with rope and zip-ties, then went back for the thugs, one dragged armful at a time.

“I thought about it,” Ahdia said. “But that would make me a murderer. I already had enough therapy topics without adding that one.”

Mack’s almost-smile made a second appearance.

“We thought you’d be trapped,” Bourn added. “Ancient texts suggest Temporalists aged decades during their first freeze. They’d enter ‘The Unmoving’ and couldn’t release it. By the time they figured out how, they’d lived years in frozen time. Aged that amount in a single instant when they released.”

The tiny her sat down on the dock edge, hunched, lips moving around something no sensor had caught. Then fire jumped, smoke tore sideways, and the figure ran.

“How long was I in there?”

“FAERIS?”

“Duration: 47 minutes, 18 seconds subjective time. Real-time passage: 0.00 seconds.”

“You can measure that? To the second?”

“FAERIS tracks temporal variance to the millisecond,” Mack said. “The fastest learning curve we’ve ever recorded.”

“That’s when we made our decision,” Bourn said. “You bonded with the most dangerous artifact on the planet. Demonstrated unprecedented learning speed. And chose to save lives over tactical advantage.” She let the list settle. “We needed to know if you were an asset or a threat.”

“So you kept watching.”

“Yes.”

* * *

“Your training period was . . . informative,” Bourn resumed, as though there had been no break at all.

The display had rebuilt itself into her own building, thirty-four translucent floors of it, a tiny figure grinding up the stairwell with the enthusiasm of a condemned prisoner.

“You could’ve frozen time and walked up without effort,” Mack observed.

“I didn’t want to use it,” Ahdia said. “I had this feeling—instinct, maybe—that using it was costing me something. I thought maybe I could . . . not do that.”

“That lasted about six hours,” Bourn noted.

“Emotional trigger,” Ahdia agreed. “I had to get angry.”

“And then calm down to release it,” Bourn said. “We watched you practice. FAERIS, how many successful freeze-release cycles in the first training session?”

“Seventeen successful cycles,” the drone answered. “Subject endurance increasing. Duration extended from 6.4 seconds to six hours continuous freeze within 48-hour period.”

Ahdia lowered the cup. “Six hours?” On the display a mug hung over a frozen kitchen counter while a tiny her circled it, hands on hips, learning her own physics like a toddler god. “I thought it was like . . . a few minutes.”

“Time gets weird when you’re the one freezing it,” Mack allowed.

“Then you got ambitious,” Mack went on.

“Oh no,” she muttered.

“You were gathering intelligence on your brother’s team,” Bourn said. “Learning their capabilities. Weaknesses. Resources.”

Apartments scrolled past in gray miniature, rooms she had drifted through while their owners stood frozen elsewhere, learning who these people were from bookshelves and medicine cabinets and unwashed dishes.

“I was trying to understand them,” she protested. “I wanted to help but I didn’t know how—”

“We know.” Bourn let the interruption finish dying. “You were training yourself for tactical support operations.”

The display settled on a punching bag folding itself gently around nothing, then leaping off its chain into a wall. She pointed at the display before the pride underneath could embarrass her. “How hard did I hit that?”

Bourn glanced at the drone. “FAERIS?”

“Force amplification ratio: 1:47,” the drone reported. “Subject’s gentle contact translated to 47 times normal impact force upon temporal release.”

“Forty-seven times,” she repeated. “I barely touched it.”

“By the end of two days,” Bourn said, “you could hold a freeze for thirty minutes. Move through secured locations without leaving traces. Amplify force with precision control. You went from ‘can barely unfreeze’ to ‘tactical asset’ in forty-eight hours.” She paused. “Then the police ambush happened.”

The display went dark. The coffee had gone cold against her palms. Ahdia registered that she was angry four seconds after the anger arrived, which was about her average.

“You’ve been watching me break into people’s apartments,” she said flatly. “Training. Experimenting. And you just . . . took notes?”

“We needed to understand what you were capable of,” Bourn answered. “And what you would choose to do with those capabilities.”

“So this was a test.”

“Everything is a test, Ms. Bacchus. You just didn’t know you were taking it.”

Every private fumble, every pep talk delivered to an empty penthouse, every practice run that ended with her on the floor—all of it existed somewhere now, timestamped and threat-assessed. She kept her face still and drank the cold coffee anyway, slowly, because the alternative was letting them log the reaction too.

“The force amplification,” Mack said. “Did you figure that out intentionally or was it an accident?”

“Accident,” Ahdia admitted. “I dropped a book while everything was frozen. When I unfroze, it shot across the room like I’d thrown it. So I tested it. Pushed things gently in frozen time, watched them fly when time resumed.”

“Forty-seven times amplification,” Bourn repeated. “That’s significant. A gentle push becomes a knockout blow. A tap becomes a battering ram.”

“I was trying not to kill anyone,” Ahdia insisted. “I thought if I could help them without them knowing, maybe—”

Maybe what. The sentence ran out of road and left her standing at the end of it, and she honestly did not know what had been waiting there. Maybe they would be proud of her at the second funeral, which sounded worse laid out flat.

“You wanted to help,” Mack offered.

“I wanted to not be useless,” Ahdia said. “For once.”

The roof went quiet except for the AC unit and its three-thousand-dollar hum. The confession hung there like a boom mic dropped into the frame.

“Your psychological profile,” Bourn said, “suggests significant depression, social isolation, lack of direction. Multiple therapists over the past decade. No employment history longer than three months. Estrangement from family members.”

“Wow. You really did your homework.”

“We needed to know if you’d be reliable.”

“And?”

“You climbed thirty-four flights of stairs because you didn’t want to waste life force helping yourself,” Bourn said. “Then you spent that life force helping people who didn’t know you existed. Broke into their homes not to steal, but to understand them. To prepare to protect them.” Her cadence never changed. “Your profile says you’re unmotivated. Unreliable. Can’t commit to anything. But in forty-eight hours, you taught yourself capabilities that took previous Temporalists decades. And you used them to save lives.”

Ahdia looked at the gravel between her sneakers while the kind words floated there with nowhere to land. Insults she could have returned fire on all day; she had a whole arsenal racked and oiled. “So what does that make me?” She made herself finish it. “Asset or threat?”

“That,” Bourn said, “depends on what you do next.”

The drone’s shell brightened again, and light gathered itself over the gravel.

“The police ambush,” Bourn said, as the light sharpened into a street she recognized. “That’s when we knew for certain.”

Chapter 14

“Knew what for certain?”

Bourn stood. She rose like an executive ending a meeting, as if the chair had been her idea.

“I’d rather show you the rest at our facility. The rooftop drone projection has limitations. And we should get you off this roof before your brother’s team finishes their discussion downstairs.”

“Your facility.”

“CADENS operations center. Secure. Climate controlled. Better coffee.”

Mack’s face registered a brief professional dissent on the coffee point.

“Do I have a choice?”

“You always have a choice, Ms. Bacchus.” Bourn paused long enough for that to finish being technically true. “But if you want answers about what we know, what’s happening with Kain and the police, and what your parents were actually doing in Montana—you’ll come with us.”

Montana. Nineteen years of no rangers, no wreckage, no theory that survived daylight, and this woman had dropped the word into a sentence as casually as a room number. CADENS knew something about her parents. Bourn had turned that something into bait and she knew it and Ahdia knew she knew it. She hated that it worked. It worked completely.

“Fine,” Ahdia said, standing before her legs could be consulted. “But if I throw up on your fancy facility floor—”

“We have protocols,” Mack said.

Somehow that was scarier than anything else on the roof. The drone drifted closer and its light climbed all three of them head to foot, brightening toward business.

“Oh no,” Ahdia managed. “Not again—”

“Deep breath,” Bourn advised. “It doesn’t help, but people feel better if they try.”

She tried. Space inverted anyway.

* * *

The second trip was worse, second-bee-sting worse: this time she knew what the universe planned to do with her and dread made a lousy anesthetic. Reality pulled her file, crossed out “rooftop” and penciled in “somewhere else” instead and every cell she owned received the correction at a slightly different moment. Star Trek still owed her an apology.

She reassembled on her hands and knees on concrete polished to such a corporate shine that she got to watch her own reflection throw up. They both did a thorough job.

“Protocol Sigma,” Mack told his radio. “Command center, level three. Standard cleanup.”

A janitor appeared unbothered inside the minute, steering a mop cart around her with the serenity of a man doing a familiar chore. Her vomit had a protocol. This happened here often enough to need a name and she was too busy shaking to decide how she felt about being a

recurring event.

Once she could lift her head the room was every underground command center she had ever watched from her couch, except real and humming. Holographic displays hung in the air with nothing holding them up. People in tactical gear crossed paths with people in lab coats, and nobody saluted anybody. One whole wall ran live feeds: a storm rotating off some coastline, a sinkhole collecting a crowd, something burning under a headline in a language she couldn't read.

"Welcome to CADENS," Bourn said. "This is where we actually work."

"You said better coffee."

"I said we had coffee. Better is relative." Bourn was already moving. "Conference room this way. The footage is already queued."

The conference room offered a long table, a wall-sized display, and chairs with opinions about posture. The drone floated in after them and settled at head height like a housecat claiming a shelf.

"Water?" Mack held one out and she drained half the bottle in one pull, and sitting stopped being optional.

"The police ambush. Three simultaneous engagements across the city. Every member of the Go Squad kettled by coordinated police response. We were monitoring their communications. They knew exactly where your brother's team would be."

"How?"

"That's what we wanted to know." Bourn tipped her head toward the drone. "Show her." She looked back at Ahdia. "Before the ambush makes sense, you need to see what you were doing that night."

* * *

Gray light rose off the drone's shell and a street she knew assembled itself over the table, and then the conference room stopped existing, because memory has better production values than any hologram.

The night of the warehouse. Hours after the crate, after the light, after the ice moved into her chest and unpacked. She ran for home, ten blocks uphill at a dead sprint, because the alternative was waiting at the docks to explain the artifact-shaped hole in somebody's inventory. Home meant the couch. The couch was where she intended to have her breakdown, in comfort, with the TV on.

The weirdness arrived on an installment plan.

First a dog hung mid-bark, silent, all four paws off the ground and staying there. She filed it under adrenaline. A man stood checking a very expensive watch whose numbers never moved, and she filed that under broken watch and rich guy and not her problem. On the next corner a couple had their argument on pause, the woman's finger parked an inch from the man's sternum, neither of them blinking. A taxi idled at a green light with its driver slumped over the wheel and she nearly stopped for him, and some deep animal instinct voted no and she kept running.

And always behind her, strictly peripheral, the world kept twitching back on. The dog landed. Horns resumed. People snapped their heads down at their phones, hunting for the thirty seconds

they could swear they'd just lost. She was carrying a bubble of stopped time the size of a modest living room and didn't know it, and everyone she passed got their evening docked half a minute for standing too close.

Her working theory was hallucination. Her backup theory was that she was the Flash now, which genuinely troubled her for half a block on jurisdictional grounds, because the Flash was DC and the X-Men were Marvel, and whichever universe had drafted her hadn't sent any paperwork.

"Wait, I was freezing time while running? I didn't even know I was doing that."

The conference room reassembled around her question. Bourn glanced at the drone.

"FAERIS," she prompted. "Duration of unconscious freeze during subject's return trajectory."

"23 minutes continuous," the drone reported. "Radius: approximately 6.1 meters. Subject maintaining temporal field unconsciously while in motion."

"Twenty-three minutes," Bourn repeated. "Maintaining a time freeze while running at full speed. Without even realizing it." From her, flat delivery was what awe looked like.

The gray light swelled again, and Ahdia let it pull her back under.

Her building. The doorman stood frozen mid-wave and she waved back out of reflex, a courtesy she could feel guilty about at her leisure. Inside she jabbed the elevator call button and got nothing, jabbed it again in the special rhythm people reserve for elevators and the button stayed dark while the truth put itself together in pieces she did not want. Electricity was a thing that happened over time. Time, at present, was her fault. She lived on the thirty-fourth floor.

"You've got to be kidding me."

The stairwell door accepted her without comment and shut behind her onto perfect dark—the emergency lights were electricity too, and electricity was hers now. The first eight floors went fine anyway, hand over hand on the railing, which she would later understand was the cardio equivalent of the first eight seconds of a fall. By ten her thighs had opened negotiations. By twelve she was hauling herself up the railing hand over hand, past the door she took for fifteen, where a sign she couldn't see went on advertising the residents' gym she had never once visited, information her body received as pure sarcasm regardless. By fifteen she was dying, not decoratively but actually dying: a heart attack at twenty-seven built from years of gas-station food and twelve-hour television days. Her heart had given up on rhythm. A hummingbird in a jar.

On the landing of twenty-two, folded over the railing, she had the idea that saved her life and complicated everything after it. The bubble had an edge; she had felt it dragging behind her all night like a bridal train made of stopped clocks. A thing with an edge had a size. A thing with a size could shrink. Just her, maybe. Just her heart. She pressed a hand over the cold spot where the Seed sat and asked her own heart, silently and sincerely, to slow down. Please. Just a little.

The cold answered. Her pulse stuttered, then settled into a calm she had done nothing to deserve.

"Oh," she said as the stairwell swam gently sideways. "Oh that's—"

She hadn't fixed anything, was the thing. Heart calm, legs suffocating: she had redistributed the crisis and called it a fix. Silver linings. Floors twenty-three through thirty-four happened on

willpower and railing and her own voice out loud in the dark. At the top she released her heart like a held breath, and her pulse came slamming back with interest, every postponed beat delivered at once, worse for the delay. She sat on the top step until her legs re-enlisted.

Her key found the lock on the third try. The penthouse was dark and the TV was off, and the TV was never off; the wrongness of that reached her before the shape on the couch did. Firas lay on his side, one arm trailing to the floor, still in yesterday's clothes.

He wasn't breathing.

"Firas?"

It came out at a pitch she didn't recognize as hers. She crossed the room with no memory of crossing it.

"Firas!"

Nothing moved. Her brain, helpful to the end, laid out the math. She had run home inside a bubble of stopped time. She had carried it through her own front door. She had parked it on her brother, and her stupid cosmic time powers had done to Firas what a shotgun couldn't and she had killed the only—

The clock. The wall clock above the TV, the one that ran six minutes fast on purpose, held its second hand still.

"Oh you've got to be kidding me."

Apparently panic pulled the same trigger as everything else. Her fear for him had frozen him, frozen the room and the clock and the air, and kneeling over her maybe-dead brother she could not work out how to let go. She tried the mental equivalent of Ctrl-Z. She tried unfreeze, undo, cancel, whatever the opposite of a scream was. She ordered the clock to move and the clock declined, and the ice in her chest sat there, patient and bright, waiting for something she didn't know how to hand over.

"Please," she whispered, and the word carried none of the command she'd been attempting, which turned out to be the trick. "Please please please I can't—I can't do this again, I can't lose—"

The clock ticked.

Firas pulled in a breath, long and rude, and let it go. Asleep. He was asleep on her couch, dead to the world in the ordinary reversible way, and she knelt there with her hands hovering over him, relearning how to exist.

So that was the lesson, delivered at the maximum available cost because that was the only tuition she ever paid: emotion pulls the trigger. Calm releases it. A device keyed to panic and unlocked by serenity, issued to a nervous system already running hot. What could possibly go wrong.

Firas mumbled something with no consonants in it and rolled over into the cushions.

She stood up on legs with strong opinions and went to the kitchen, and there on the counter sat that morning's coffee mug, an inch of cold coffee poured by a woman who had never frozen a city block or a heart or a brother. She had to learn to control this thing. Because next time he startled her, dropped a glass or banged a cabinet or laughed too suddenly behind her, the freeze might not

ask permission and might not let go, and she could freeze him to death for the crime of saying good morning. She stood in the dark kitchen a long while, staring at the mug.

* * *

The mug had survived the night, and the next afternoon Ahdia came back for it, rested and reasonably caffeinated and ready to negotiate.

“Freeze,” she whispered at it.

The mug declined.

She squared her shoulders and worked down the full menu. “Stop. Pause. Time out. Za Warudo!”

The last one honestly felt the most promising, since her only working reference for stopped time was an anime villain, and the universe had already shown a taste for her references. The mug sat there. She tried the Force-choke hand next, fingers clawed at empty air, elbow cocked, and held the pose long enough to catch her reflection in the microwave door and feel as stupid as she looked.

Under the old bullet wound the Seed hummed along, a cold ember, awake and interested and useless. Beneath the hum ran the instinct that had ridden with her since the docks: this costs you. She didn’t know what it took from her; she only knew the feel of something running somewhere out of sight.

She dumped yesterday’s coffee and brewed a fresh cup, reasoning that if she meant to spend the afternoon threatening a beverage, the beverage should be worth drinking. Then she threatened it for another hour. Commands. Gestures. Meaningful eye contact. Nothing worked, and the not-working stacked up in her until it hit the floor of her patience and went through.

“Come ON!” Her palm cracked down on the counter—

—and the world stopped.

The steam over the fresh cup hung mid-curl, a white ribbon parked in the air. The stove clock said 2:47 PM and went on saying it. The refrigerator hum was gone, and the silence where it had lived had a texture, thick and total. Dust hung in the window light and did not fall.

“Oh,” she said.

Nothing on Earth moved except her.

“Oh shit.”

She tried to un-slam the counter. She tried the commands again in reverse order, then in a calm indoor voice, then in the wheedling tone she saved for dying electronics. The freeze ignored all of it as the mug had ignored her. Panic arrived punctually, because the first freeze, at the docks, had ended on its own timetable, like weather, and she’d had no vote. This one might never end at all: the steam might never land, and the clock might read 2:47 PM for the rest of a very long life, hers, alone in a world-sized diorama.

The panic crested, broke, and rolled back out, and it dragged the anger with it, and for one hollow second she was empty of everything but tired.

Time snapped back, the steam finished its curl, and the refrigerator resumed its low argument with itself. The clock still said 2:47 PM. The entire terror had cost the world nothing.

She stood very still and did the math, because math was a thing you could hold. Mad pulled the trigger. Calm released it, or whatever hollowed-out cousin of calm she had fallen into.

She practiced until midnight. Getting angry on purpose turned out to be the easy half, since she owned years of material; letting go on purpose was the work. The holds ran five to ten seconds, seventeen freezes by the end of it, each release slightly less of an accident, and when she quit she felt scraped hollow, and the cold spot under the old wound ached like a pulled tooth.

* * *

The theory arrived with the next morning's coffee, fully formed: buy time by spending time. If frozen seconds cost the world nothing, then frozen time was free practice space, a private gym the size of the universe, and she was apparently the only member.

By midmorning she could hold past a minute, and shortly after that she got scientific about it. She froze the kitchen and lobbed a pillow across it, and inside the stillness the pillow flew and flopped as pillows do, obeying her private physics without complaint. When she released, nothing dramatic happened at all; the pillow was somewhere new, with no history of having traveled.

Then the variation. She threw the next one hard and let the freeze go while it was still mid-flight.

The pillow crossed the living room like it had been fired out of something military, cracked into the wall, and brought the framed photo down with it in a burst of glass.

"Oh shit!" She was already moving toward the wreckage. "Yes!"

Both reactions were true, and neither one canceled the other. She swept up the glass and logged the finding underneath it: whatever went in gentle came out enormous. A fingertip push inside the freeze arrived, in real time, as a shove from something far bigger than her. She spent the afternoon calibrating on furniture that couldn't sue, cushions and cereal boxes and one long-suffering ottoman, until she could dose it, tap to thump to launch.

She worked it out by the clocks: an hour inside ran to three minutes outside, which she wrote down and declined to understand. By day's end she had banked something near six frozen hours, she could drop into the stillness at will and hold it for minutes at a stretch, and the cold under the old wound had crossed the border from temperature into pain. Her sleeve cuffs had gone soft and pale too, the fibers furred like rope just before it parts, and she could not name a thing she had done to them. She filed it under later and kept going. The meter she couldn't see ran on.

* * *

What she did with the stillness next was go visiting.

She told herself it was reconnaissance, which was true, and that it was for their sake, which was also true, and that it had nothing to do with wanting to stand inside other people's lives for a

while, which made her two for three.

Ruth first, obviously, because Ruth was the only one of them she actually knew. The lobby guard was frozen mid-yawn when she walked in, a yawn wide enough to count fillings by, and she went past it at her leisure. Upstairs, the apartment door was unlocked. The woman fought crime on a volunteer basis and did not lock her front door, and Ahdia stood in the hallway a moment feeling offended on her behalf. Inside: The New England Journal of Medicine on the nightstand, bristling with sticky notes, a trauma surgery text underneath it. Tactical gear hung behind the winter coats, squared away with terrible neatness. The fridge wore photographs of Ruth and Firas, years of them, and Ahdia lifted one free, held it, and set it back precisely where it had been, corner to corner, and did that until her hands were steady and nobody living could have said she'd come through.

The tiny studio across town had its fire-escape window cracked two inches, so she went in that way. Its tenant was asleep on the futon in her work clothes. The pharmacy bottle on the bathroom sink read WHITFORD, TESS, and under the name, Sertraline 100mg. Ahdia knew that one; it hadn't done much for her either. Another depressed girl making rent, sleeping where she landed. Recognition, not pity. She eased the window back to its two inches on her way out.

The community center said "nonprofit" from every surface, in the dialect that translates to "we're one grant away from closing." She came in past a rubber doorstop wedged for the evening crowd, past a janitor frozen mid-mop, past flyers for a food drive and ESL classes taped up at heights suggesting the ladder had been optional. The donation jar by the front desk held six dollars, all of it coins. In the back office a framed wedding photo stood on the desk, and the woman's face in it had been scratched out, gouged deep enough to mark the glass. Ahdia didn't touch that one; she left it where it lived and went back out through the propped door.

The last apartment belonged to a barista, per the name tag on the dresser: the Bean Post, then LEAH, then a smiley face added in Sharpie. The helmet on the wall hook was stickered over every inch and carried a star for jammer, a fact Ahdia possessed for one reason: that roller derby movie, 3 AM, a box of Thin Mints, no witnesses. A punching bag hung in the corner, held together with duct tape and spite. On the shelf sat anger-management books, and under them workbooks with actual handwriting in the margins, page after page of somebody doing the assignment anyway.

She froze the room, set two fingers against the bag, pushed like you'd test a door, and released from across the apartment. The bag went off. It swung like it had taken a full baseball swing, the chain snapped taut, and a ceiling bolt bent out of true.

"Oops," she told the empty apartment.

By the end of the second day she could hold a freeze for thirty minutes, come and go without leaving a fingerprint of herself anywhere, and dose force from a nudge to a wrecking ball. She carried out one other finding, the kind she hadn't gone looking for. Sticky notes, six dollars in coins, duct tape, handwriting in a workbook: none of these people were special because of what their bodies could suddenly do. They were special because they kept showing up.

* * *

Two nights after the warehouse, she learned what the practice had been for.

The Frederick Douglass Bridge, from her side of it: floodlights, a helicopter hammering the air white, and Gloom Girl up on the rail with the whole department closing in. Then she was off the rail, one middle finger raised on the way down.

Ahdia froze the night with her still in the air above the river.

She was most of the bridge away when it happened, so she sprinted the deck flat out in the stillness, hooked one arm through the cables, and hauled a frozen, folded woman in out of the dark, which mostly took nerve. The carry was the education: four blocks inland with a grown adult over her shoulders, then up a fire stair toward a roof where Ruth stood fixed at the parapet, binoculars up. Halfway up the climb her lungs went from burning to bargaining, and her body remembered the stairwell, the trick with the heart, how narrowly that trick had missed being her last idea. Wrong dial. She didn't need the whole engine slowed, only the burn. So she put her attention into her own screaming legs as she'd put two fingers on a punching bag, and asked time to run cold there, and only there.

"Oh," she said.

The burn in her legs folded up obediently and went quiet mid-stride.

"Oh that's way better."

She topped the climb sweating through everything she wore, because apparently effort still had to go somewhere no matter what the muscles agreed to.

"For such cosmic power," she said, "it sure is a sweaty one."

She left Gloom Girl hanging a foot above the rooftop, feet down, arms arranged, close enough that Ruth's binoculars would be beside the point. Then she crossed three rooftops and let the night go. Somewhere behind her a girl dropped out of an empty sky, unhurt, and the story would assemble itself without help from anyone. Teleportation. The vanishing girl. Let them have it.

A low whistle brought the conference room back, and the whistle was Mack's.

"She figured out selective time dilation. Her own muscles. Mid-climb."

Ahdia's hands had found the water bottle without consulting her. "Is that . . . hard to do?"

"FAERIS," Bourn said. "Previous Temporalist development timeline for selective biological manipulation."

"Average development time: 12 to 47 years post-bonding," the drone reported.

"You did it in under an hour," Bourn told her. She let the number finish landing before she went on. "That's what made us decide you were worth recruiting. You problem-solve with cosmic abilities the way most people problem-solve with everyday tools."

It was a compliment shaped like a lab result, and Ahdia filed it away to have feelings about later.

The display split into three feeds, three gray miniatures of one long night.

"We had eyes on all three ambush sites," Bourn said. She nodded at the feeds in turn. "Ruth on the Frederick Douglass Bridge. Battlea and Sable at the construction site in Little Poland. Gloom Girl and Night Knight near the waterfront."

In one feed a police dog hung mid-lunge and then was elsewhere, aimed at nothing, while a small gray Ahdia leaned her weight into other people's punches half a second before they landed. In the second she watched herself gather Gloom Girl out of the air like fruit off a high branch. In the third, Night Knight left a rooftop at a doomed angle, and a hand closed around his ankle in the stillness and moved him two degrees.

"Coordinated perfectly," Mack said, and he wasn't praising anyone. "Someone fed Chief Whitford their locations. All three teams kettled at the same time."

"Then you showed up," Bourn resumed.

"Three simultaneous interventions within twenty minutes," she added. On the middle feed the river hung in gray pleats below the bridge. "Ensuring no one died—police included."

Mack turned to the drone. "FAERIS," he said. "Total power usage duration for police ambush intervention."

"Six hours continuous temporal manipulation across multiple sites," the drone answered. It paused, for effect or for math. "Force amplification applied 47 times. Life force expenditure: 23% of total reserves."

The blood left her face and took its time coming back.

"Twenty-three percent? In one night?"

Nobody in the room softened it for her, and she sat back slowly until the chair took her weight.

"I wanted them to be okay. I wanted them to think they could do this without me."

"You gave them confidence," Mack offered. "Made them believe in themselves."

"While exhausting yourself," Bourn said.

The display had moved on to an alley, where a small gray figure slid down a wall between dumpsters, folded up, and cried into her sleeve while the timestamp in the corner kept counting anyway.

"Ten minutes before you could stand," Mack murmured. "You limped home. Took eight ibuprofen. Passed out on the couch."

"And woke up the next day to do it again," Bourn finished.

The feed changed again and gave her the Academy, the day after: the whole floor stopped at midmorning, Firas caught mid-sentence beside a mat, Victor frozen nodding along. A small gray Ahdia leaned in and stuck her tongue out at her brother, the full childhood version. Then the figure stumbled. A hand went flat against her chest, and even in grayscale the color went out of her.

In the conference room the gray light lay across her hands, and Ahdia leaned forward into it.

"I could feel it. Like something was burning through me. Every time I used the powers, it got colder."

"Colder?" Bourn asked.

"The Seed. In my chest. When I freeze time, it's cold. Really cold. But after—when I let go—it feels like it's taking something from me. Like I'm emptying out."

"That's when you realized," Mack prompted.

“That the power wasn’t free,” Ahdia said. Her eyes stayed on the small gray figure. “That it was costing me. I didn’t know how much or what exactly, but I could feel it. Like . . . like running on a battery that doesn’t recharge.”

Bourn turned to the drone. “FAERIS, bio-sign analysis from that session.”

“Cumulative degradation detected across all power usage instances. Pattern consistent with permanent cellular depletion, not temporary fatigue.”

“Permanent,” Ahdia repeated.

On the display, the gray Ahdia sat down on the Academy floor and stayed there a while. Then she stood, looked for a long moment at her brother, still frozen in the middle of whatever he was telling Victor, unfroze the room, and walked away before he could turn around.

* * *

The display went dark. For the first time since the roof, nothing was playing anywhere, and the quiet had intentions.

“That was two days ago,” Bourn said. It didn’t sound like an accusation. That made it worse. “You figured out your powers were draining you. That you couldn’t keep using them without consequence. And then you hid behind a foam obstacle to stick your tongue out at your brother.”

“I was processing,” Ahdia managed.

“You were regressing,” Bourn corrected. There was no cruelty anywhere in it. “After everything you’d accomplished—saving your brother’s team twice, mastering abilities that should’ve taken decades, preventing multiple deaths—you heard what he really thought of you.”

Her hands, she noticed from a slight distance, were still shaking. She flattened them on the table and reached for the one question that outranked the rest.

“My parents,” she said. The words needed a running start. “You’ve been monitoring this thing—the Hyper Seed. Did they . . . was their work in Montana connected to this?”

“Your parents,” Bourn said, and for the first time she seemed to weigh each word before spending it, “were working with CADENS when they disappeared in Montana. Or rather, working adjacent to us. They were tracking reports of a Hyper Seed manifestation. We were monitoring from a distance.”

“They died looking for this thing? For the thing that’s inside me now?”

“They died protecting it,” Mack answered. “From people who wanted to use it. People like Kain.”

“The Montana excavation wasn’t an accident,” Bourn told her. “Your parents discovered the Seed’s location. Someone else did too. There was a confrontation. An explosion. By the time our team arrived, your parents were gone. The Seed was gone. We thought it was destroyed.”

“Until Kain had it,” Ahdia finished.

“Until Kain had it,” Bourn agreed.

The echo sat on the table between them, and Bourn collected it before it could cool. “We don’t know how he acquired it. But we’d been tracking him for months before the warehouse. When you

bonded with it—when you became it—you inherited your parents' legacy."

"Lucky me."

Bourn rose and crossed to the long interior window, the one that looked down into the well of the facility: levels of it descending, screens tracking storms and sinkholes and every other way a planet can go wrong, people moving between them with somewhere to be.

"Our analysis suggests you're running on a finite energy source," she said to the glass.

Then she turned around, and whatever was coming had enough mass that the room felt it before she spoke. Mack went still. The drone's light held where it was, and the only sound left was the building keeping itself alive.

"The Hyper Seed bonding replaced approximately half your life force with . . . something else. Every time you use your powers, you're draining what remains. At a survivable rate of expenditure—short freezes, small corrections, nothing heroic—you have maybe eighteen months. The ambush was not a survivable rate. That one night cost you a quarter of everything you had left. Four more like it and we are not having this conversation."

"Eighteen months," Ahdia said. The number came out flat, from somewhere far away.

"Unless we can find another way," Mack put in. "CADENS has been studying Temporalists for decades. We have resources, research, ancient texts. Maybe there's a way to slow the drain, or restore what's been lost."

Bourn sat. "But we need your cooperation. We need you to work with us, not hide from us. We need you to trust us."

"Trust the shadow government that's been spying on me?"

"Trust the organization that knew you were at critical energy expenditure and intervened before you killed yourself helping people who don't even know you exist," Bourn shot back. Then the edge went out of her, all at once. "We extracted you from that academy because if we'd waited any longer, you would've spent the rest of your life—however short—watching your brother mourn you while you hid in the shadows."

The drone hummed at its shelf height while Ahdia looked at her hands until she could ask it.

"So what do you want from me?"

"First, we want you to stop killing yourself. Second, we want you to let us help you figure out how to survive this. Third—" Bourn let the third one stand in line. "Kain is still out there. Chief Whitford is still hunting your brother's team. And you're the only one who can help them without exposing what they really are."

"No pressure," Ahdia muttered.

"Exactly the right amount of pressure," Bourn returned. "The question is: are you going to keep hiding and burning through your life force alone? Or are you going to work with us?"

"Work with you how?"

"Training. Research. Mission support." Bourn stood. "Kain is escalating. Chief Whitford is escalating. We need eyes on both of them, and you're the only asset who can operate in ways they can't detect or counter. In exchange, we give you every resource we have to extend your life

expectancy beyond eighteen months."

"You want me to spy for you."

"We want you to stop Kain from acquiring more artifacts. Stop Whitford from weaponizing the police against enhanced individuals. And let us study your capabilities so we can understand what's coming." Bourn opened one hand. "Your personal life—your brother, his team, whatever family drama you're processing—that's yours to handle or not handle. We don't care. We care about preventing the next cataclysm."

Mack leaned forward. "But we do need an answer. Are you in or not?"

"What happens if I say no?"

"We keep monitoring," Bourn said, unhurried. "We intervene when you're about to do something that gets you killed. We track Kain and Whitford without your help. And when whatever cosmic threat is coming finally arrives, we hope we're prepared enough without a Temporalist on our side." She let that settle before she spent the rest. "But you keep burning through your energy alone. And you die in eighteen months, give or take. Alone."

There it was. Alone was not a threat you could aim at her; alone was the apartment she had lived in for years. She thought of the alley and the sleeve. She thought of the thirty-four flights she had climbed on ruined legs rather than spend one minute of herself on her own behalf, and of every person she had saved who would never know she existed, who would never get the chance to show up for her as they kept showing up for each other.

"I'm in," she said.

Nobody moved. The drone's light held on her, recording, presumably for some future footage session she would also get to sit through.

"But I have conditions."

Chapter 15

“What conditions?” Bourn asked.

Ahdia set the empty water bottle down and squared it to the table’s edge. That bought her two seconds, and two seconds was all the rehearsal she was going to get.

“You’ve been watching Caledonia. You know what it’s like down there. Police state. Whitford’s thugs beating people for existing while Black. Kain in bed with all of it. People are terrified.”

“We’re aware of the sociopolitical climate,” Bourn said, in the tone of a form letter.

“The Go Squad is the only thing giving them hope,” Ahdia continued. “Real people standing up to corruption. Not some government agency. Not some shadowy organization with acronyms. Just . . . people. Who decided they’d had enough.”

“They’ve become symbols.”

“Exactly. And if Caledonia finds out it was all me—that my brother’s team doesn’t actually have powers—that hope dies. They become frauds. The city goes back to accepting that nothing can change.”

Bourn considered that for a long moment, without any visible change of expression. “You want us to help you maintain a deception so a handful of parkour vigilantes can continue street-level operations against corrupt municipal authorities.”

“Yes.”

“And you believe this matters.”

“It matters to them. That’s enough.”

The pause ran long enough that Ahdia braced for the no.

“The sociopolitical stability of authoritarian regimes,” Bourn said, “has strategic implications. Populations under systematic oppression become . . . vulnerable to external influences. Maintaining indigenous resistance movements can prevent larger destabilization events.”

Ahdia waited for the rest of it. There was no rest of it. She had asked this woman to protect her brother’s hope, and the woman had agreed because hope was a stabilizing asset, and the agreement was somehow colder than a refusal would have been. “So . . . yes?”

“We’ll provide support,” Bourn said, and the terms came out in a list she had already drafted. “FAERIS surveillance of Go Squad operations. Real-time threat assessment. Translocation to intervention points. Extraction afterward. You provide tactical assistance during frozen time. They maintain belief in their capabilities. Caledonia maintains hope. We gather operational data on your power usage and limitations.”

“Everyone wins,” Mack added.

“Except I’m still dying in eighteen months.”

Mack looked into his coffee instead of at her. Nobody in the room offered a correction.

“Which brings us to our research division,” Bourn said, already up and moving for the door. “Follow me.”

* * *

The route ran along a railed walkway above the command floor, past the wall of live feeds with its storms and sinkholes and burning things in patient rotation. Side corridors branched off at intervals, every one of them labeled and every label an acronym. Ahdia watched the feeds slide by underneath her sneakers. “How many of these places are being watched?” Ahdia asked, keeping her eyes on the slow parade of disasters below.

“Currently? 247 active monitoring sites,” Bourn said, without slowing down or consulting anything. “Down from 890 during the Cold War. Cataclysm activity has decreased since the 1960s.”

“Why?”

“Unknown. Working theory: dimensional barriers strengthened after atmospheric nuclear testing stopped. Or testing weakened barriers and they’re slowly recovering. Or complete coincidence. We don’t have enough data.”

She offered all three theories with identical investment, and Ahdia was beginning to understand that Bourn kept her beliefs like other people kept spare batteries, interchangeable and in a drawer.

The walkway ended at a heavy door stenciled in yellow:

RESEARCH DIVISION - AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL ONLY

Beyond it the facility changed dialect: whiteboards instead of status boards, cables duct-taped across the floor in bundles, equipment she couldn’t name crowded against equipment she couldn’t guess at. In the middle of it all, a man in a wrinkled button-down was wheeling his chair between two monitors, loudly arguing both sides. “—can’t be right, the temporal variance should be inverse not proportional unless the field radius affects decay rate which would mean—”

He looked up, saw Bourn, and rode the chair into a filing cabinet. “Director! I didn’t—sorry, I was just—the readings from the warehouse event were—”

“Dr. Ryu,” Bourn said. “This is Ahdia Bacchus. Our Temporalist.”

He came upright fast enough to knock his glasses crooked. Japanese and somewhere in his late twenties, her height, wearing the look of a man thirty hours past his last sleep and running on enthusiasm instead.

“Yes! I know! I mean, I’ve been studying your—not YOU, obviously, that would be—I mean the data from your power usage, which is fascinating, not that you’re just data, you’re a person, obviously a person, a very—” He ran out of runway and pushed the glasses back up his nose. “Sorry. I talk too much when I’m excited. Also when I’m nervous. Also in general.”

“Relax. I understood maybe forty percent of that, which is my baseline for most conversations.”

“Forty percent? That’s actually above average! Most people stop me at ten. My last roommate used to throw pillows at me when I—” Bourn’s attention shifted onto him by a single degree, which was apparently enough. “Sorry. Doing it again.”

“Dr. Ryu will be your handler,” Bourn said. “He manages FAERIS operations and will serve as your tactical support during missions.”

“I’m your guy in the chair,” Ryu said. “That’s a Spider-Man reference. You probably don’t—”

“I know,” Ahdia said. “I’ve seen Homecoming like six times.”

“Seven for me. Well, eight if you count the time I fell asleep and had to rewatch—” He caught the Director’s stillness at the edge of his vision. “Right. Professional. I can be professional.”

“Dr. Ryu has been monitoring your power usage since the warehouse incident. He’ll brief you on what we know, what we don’t know, and begin baseline testing to understand your capabilities and limitations.”

“I’ve prepared a presentation,” Ryu said, rallying. “It’s only forty-seven slides. I cut it down from ninety.”

“We’ll skip the presentation,” Bourn said, already turning to go. “Run the physical assessments first. I want baseline biometrics before she uses powers again.”

“Right. Yes. Testing. I can do testing.”

Bourn was gone with a nod to Ryu, and Mack followed her out, giving Ahdia a look on the way that might have been sympathy or might have been a warning about the slides. The lab door sealed behind them, and just that fast the entire federal apparatus shrank down to one over-caffeinated scientist bouncing slightly on his heels. “Medical bay is this way.”

* * *

The medical bay was white and quiet, and the machine in the middle of it looked like a dentist’s chair and a tanning bed had pooled their ambitions. Screens ringed it on articulated arms. Ryu moved between them, waking each one with a tap.

“Okay,” Ryu said, cracking his knuckles at the console. “So. Baseline biometrics. We need to understand what the Hyper Seed bonding did to your physiology before we can figure out how to slow the degradation. Or stop it. Ideally stop it.” He patted the chair hopefully. “If you could just—”

“What exactly are you looking for?”

“Everything?” He spread his hands to indicate the size of everything. “Heart rate, blood pressure, cellular composition, temporal field resonance, dimensional signature, neurological patterns—basically if it can be measured, I’m measuring it.”

“That sounds deeply invasive.”

“It’s non-invasive! Completely! The scanners are passive. You just sit there. Well, lie there. It works better if you lie flat.”

A changing room hid behind a curtain in the corner, gray scrubs folded on its shelf in a stack of guessed sizes that included hers. She changed and came back and lay down on the not-quite-dentist-chair, which reclined beneath her with a hum.

“There we go. Comfortable?”

“Not remotely.”

“Great! That’s—I mean, sorry. Do you need a pillow or—”

“I’m fine. Let’s just get this over with.”

The scanner arm made its first slow pass, and data climbed the screens while Ryu leaned into them, fingers drumming the edge of the console as he read. “Okay,” Ryu muttered, half to the screens. “Heart rate elevated but that’s probably stress from translocation. Blood pressure . . . hmm. Cellular degradation markers are . . . oh.” The drumming stopped.

“‘Oh’ what?”

“Sorry. Just—the Seed integration is more thorough than I expected. It’s not just sitting in your chest like a foreign object. It’s connected to your cardiovascular system, your nervous system, your skeletal structure. It’s . . .” He turned one of the screens so she could see it. Her body rendered in gray sections with fine bright threads running through the gray. They followed her ribs and wrapped the long bones of her arms. They gathered at the center of her chest, thick around a point of light.

“It’s replacing parts of you. Slowly.”

She looked at the threads.

“Replacing me with what?”

“With itself.” He kept his eyes on the screen. “Every time you use your powers, it spreads a little more. Converts your biological tissue into something else. Something that can channel temporal energy.”

“So I’m turning into a Hyper Seed.”

“Essentially. The process is slow—eighteen months at current usage rates before you’re more Seed than human. But . . .” He stopped. His hands lay flat on the console now, holding still on purpose. “The tissue it converts isn’t dead. It’s still you. It still functions. It’s just . . . different.”

“Can you stop it?”

“I don’t know. Maybe? CADENS has been studying Temporalists for decades, but most of them died before we could collect meaningful data. You’re the first one we’ve had access to this early in the bonding process.”

She watched the threads. He watched her.

“But I’m going to try. That’s what all this is for—understanding the mechanism so we can intervene.”

“And if you can’t?”

“Then we make the eighteen months count.”

The scanner arm made its second pass. She lay flat and let it read her.

* * *

The full battery took another hour. She was back in her own clothes, sitting on the edge of the chair, by the time he had finished making the screens agree with each other.

"Okay," he said, wheeling his stool around to face her. "Good news and bad news. Good news: your baseline physiology is adapting remarkably well to the Seed integration. Your body isn't rejecting it, which is—well, you're alive, so obviously it's not rejecting it, but I mean at the cellular level there's no immune response, no inflammation, no—sorry. Rambling."

"And the bad news?"

"The temporal field generation is inefficient. You're burning way more energy than you need to for the same effect. It's like—" He looked around the medical bay for an analogy and located one somewhere behind her. "Like running a car engine at maximum RPM to go thirty miles per hour. You're getting where you need to go, but you're destroying the engine in the process."

"Can you fix it?"

"Maybe. If we can teach you to control the field more precisely. Right now you're doing everything by instinct—which is impressive, don't get me wrong—but instinct isn't efficient. It's like the difference between flailing in water and actually swimming. Both keep you afloat, but one uses way less energy."

Ahdia thought about the fire stair and the trick with her own burning legs, and kept the thought where it was.

"I want to run some controlled tests. See if we can refine your technique. But first—" He was already moving, waving her up and out into the corridor, talking happily the whole way about interface design and video game HUDs while she let it wash over her like weather. Two doors down he badged them into a long room lined with racks. "We need to get you equipped."

* * *

The armory ran deep, racks down both sides and a firing range opening off the far end. Front and center, on a mannequin, stood a suit: matte black from collar to boot, armor plates laid over flexible fabric in overlapping segments. It had very clearly been waiting for her. "CADENS is really going all-in on the superhero aesthetic, huh?" Ahdia said.

"It's designed specifically for you. Well, for Temporalists. The fabric is—" He stopped, upgraded his plan, and crossed to a rack drawer. "Here, let me show you something. Cover your ears."

"What?"

He came back holding a handgun. "Trust me. Cover your ears."

She got her hands up just before he shot the mannequin in the sternum. The report slammed around the racks, a spark jumped off the plate, and the round went whining away into the range. The mannequin rocked on its stand and settled, and the suit carried no mark that mattered. Her ears rang anyway.

"Bulletproof," Ryu said, setting the gun down gingerly with both hands, a man returning a borrowed thing. "The armor plates, anyway. The fabric itself is impact-resistant but not

bullet-stopping. It will, however, handle the temporal shear when you freeze time. Normal clothes deteriorate—fibers can't handle the stress. This can." He peeled the suit off the mannequin and held it out. "Temperature regulation, sensor-transparent for our monitoring equipment, and surprisingly light. Try it on."

"Changing room?"

"Same one as before."

The suit fit her. Every measurement was right, down to the length of her arms and the width of her shoulders, and nobody at CADENS had ever taken a tape to her, which meant they had extrapolated her dimensions from surveillance footage. She filed that under efficient and creepy in that order, and walked back out to the armory.

"Okay," he said. He said it to a point slightly to the left of her, then found something urgent to check at a console. When he came back he was carrying a visor, holding it out with both hands. "This is your HUD. Augmented reality display. Put it on."

She put it on. The armory grew a second layer: range markers and air temperature, a compass ribbon, small patient readouts attaching themselves to everything she looked at. "Whoa."

"Right?" He bounced once on his heels. "I designed the interface. Video game HUDs, like I said. You can track FAERIS-monitored individuals, see threat assessments, magnify your vision up to 20x, access tactical data during operations. It's all gesture and eye-tracking controlled. Very intuitive." He tapped his own temple. "It's also field-hardened like the suit—ordinary electronics stop dead inside your bubble, which is how I ended up watching you climb thirty-four floors instead of taking the elevator."

She looked at him. The display obligingly tagged him:

[DR. RYU MATSUDA - CADENS PERSONNEL - CLEARANCE LEVEL 7 - HEART RATE: 82 BPM]

When she had first put the visor on, the last line had read 78. "I can see your heart rate went up."

"Yeah, well, I get excited about tech."

"I'm also detecting," Ahdia said, "elevated levels of awkwardness. It's over 9,000."

"Did you just—did you make a Dragon Ball Z reference?"

"I contain multitudes."

He looked like a man whose birthday had arrived early.

"Also I watched a lot of anime at 4 AM when sleep wouldn't come."

"Okay, I'm raising your clearance level."

She raised an eyebrow at him.

"Just kidding, I don't have that authority. But we need to test the gear with your powers. The display should stay functional even in frozen time. I'm also going to test something experimental—the HUD's AR communication protocol. Step into the testing circle."

The testing circle turned out to be a ring of yellow paint on the floor near the range, and she stepped into it.

“Now freeze time,” Ryu said, backing up two steps and straightening his glasses. “And don’t freak out when you see me.”

She froze it. The room’s hum cut out, and Ryu stopped mid-fidget with one hand still at his glasses. Then light gathered itself beside the console, and a second Ryu stood there, edges faintly luminous, grinning at her through the stillness.

“If you can see this, wave your hand,” AR-Ryu said.

She waved.

“Excellent! Okay, this is going to sound weird, but I’m not actually me right now. I’m a cybernetic mapping of my brain running through the HUD’s processors. The system operates on picosecond framerates, so it can function even in your temporal field. I can talk to you, answer questions, provide tactical support—and when you unfreeze, everything we discuss gets uploaded to real-me’s brain instantly. He’ll—I’ll—remember this conversation like it just happened. Which, from my perspective, it did. Or will. Time travel grammar is confusing.”

“This is deeply weird.”

“Oh absolutely. But functional! Try asking me something only I would know.”

She glanced at the real Ryu fixed mid-adjustment, then back at the glowing one. “What show did I reference earlier?”

“Dragon Ball Z. Over 9,000 joke. See? I have all of real-Ryu’s memories up to the moment you froze time.”

She looked at it a moment longer. It stood there glowing, pleased with itself. “Okay, you can unfreeze now. Watch what happens.”

She let the stillness go. The hum returned, and the real Ryu finished adjusting his glasses and then caught up with himself all at once. “Did the AR work? Did it—oh, you asked about Dragon Ball Z. Yeah, I remember that now. It’s like I was there, but also I wasn’t? This tech is so cool.”

“That,” Ahdia said, “is the weirdest thing that’s happened to me. And I have a cosmic artifact in my chest.”

“Fair. But it means you’ll never be alone during operations. I’ll always be there. Sort of.” He checked the console readouts, nodding at each in turn. “Everything else maintained integrity too—suit, HUD, communication. You could hold a freeze for hours and we could have full conversations.”

He looked up from the console, straight on. “How does it feel?”

“I feel like I’m either cosplaying,” she said, “or I look like I’m about to brood on a rooftop.”

“You’re equipped,” Ryu corrected. “There’s a difference.”

“Does it have to be black?”

“Just for dinner,” he replied, without looking up from the console, and it sat there being a joke or possibly not, and she decided not to ask.

He strapped a heavy watch onto her wrist next, cinching the band with tech-support briskness. “This is your panic button. If something goes wrong—if you’re injured, if you’re stuck, if you just need immediate extraction—you press this and the nearest FAERIS unit will paint you for

translocation. Emergency protocol. Bourn authorized it specifically for you."

"Anything else?"

"One more thing. It's—you don't have to take it if you don't want to. But . . ." He took a flat case from the end of the rack and held it a moment before he offered it. "For anonymity. I know you're invisible during operations, but in case someone sees you before you freeze time, or after you unfreeze—"

She opened it. "A mask."

"A mask," he confirmed. "I know it's very comic book, but—"

"I'll take it."

It was a black domino, light as paper and shaped for the top half of a face. She put it on and turned to the mirror at the end of the racks. "I look ridiculous," she said.

"You look dangerous," Ryu corrected. "In a good way. In a 'don't mess with me because I can stop time and you'll never see it coming' way."

The woman in the mirror stood straight, armored and masked and built for a job. She looked capable. She looked above all like someone who wasn't Ahdia, and Ahdia had no complaints about the casting. "What now?" she asked.

"Now," Ryu said, "we test your temporal control. See if we can make you more efficient. Buy you more than eighteen months."

* * *

The training room was mostly empty space under a high ceiling: padded floor, a pendulum hanging on a long cable from a gantry, and a ball suspended from a rig beside a wall display. Ryu set the pendulum swinging and set the wall timer running, red digits climbing. "Okay," Ryu said, walking backward toward the console. "I want you to freeze time, but this time, try to feel what you're doing. Where the energy is coming from, where it's going. The more aware you are of the mechanism, the more control you'll have."

She reached for the cold. The pendulum halted mid-arc. The ball hung dead on its cable. The timer held at 00:03.87 and declined to move again, and for once she stood inside the stillness and paid attention to it instead of spending it: the cold flowing outward from the center of her, the far edge of the field somewhere beyond the walls and wastefully wide. She let go.

"Good," he said, eyes on his tablet. "Now try to shrink the field. Make it smaller. Just the room instead of the whole facility."

She froze it again. This time she went hunting for the edge. It was there, as the burn in her legs had been on the fire stair, a thing she could set her attention against and move. She hauled it inward until it sat just outside the walls and released.

"Perfect!" The tablet came up like a trophy. "You just reduced energy expenditure by thirty percent. Try it again, even smaller."

She did it again. The edge drew in closer, snug against the room, and now she could feel the whole shape of the thing, a bubble she wore instead of a weather system she dragged. "I felt it," she

said. “I could feel the shape of the field. Like it was part of me.”

“You just cut your energy usage in half. If you can maintain that level of control during field operations, you’ve bought yourself another year. Maybe more.”

Her legs were shaking, and she sat down on the padded floor before they could decide the matter for her. Another year. She turned the number over, looking for the catch. “Really?”

“Really.” He crouched to her level, tablet against his knees. “You’re a remarkably fast learner. Most Temporalists took years to achieve this level of control. You did it in an hour.”

“I watch a lot of training montages.”

“Well, it’s working.” He stood. She got herself up in stages. “You should rest. Tomorrow we’ll start coordinating with FAERIS, practicing translocation protocols, running through intervention scenarios. But for now—you’ve earned a break.”

“Where am I supposed to sleep?”

“Right. Quarters.” He led her out into a corridor where the lights had gone over to a dimmer cycle, evening by facility decree. “Basic but functional. Probably better than the penthouse you’ve been hiding in for months.”

“Hey. My penthouse has excellent TV.”

“Our quarters have TV too. Also running water, a bed that’s not a couch, and food that didn’t come from a gas station.”

“Sold.”

They walked. Somewhere below them the command floor went on tracking every wrong thing on the planet, while up here it was quiet enough to hear the air system breathe.

“Oh, almost forgot.” He stopped and dug in a pocket and came out with a small flat case.

“What’s this?”

She opened it. Inside was a silver crest—a shield with a crack down its center—CADENS embossed across the top, and below it a single word: AUERBACH

“Your codename. If you choose to accept it.” She looked at the word. “Everyone operational gets one—Howitzer, Greyhound, Mercury. Director Bourn picked yours herself. But if you want something else—”

“Auerbach,” she said. The word meant nothing she could trace. It was not an acronym she could unpack, or a joke she could catch. Bourn had chosen it, and Bourn explained nothing, and somehow that made it easier to hold. It was a name with no history attached. She could be the history herself.

“You don’t have to use it,” Ryu said. “We can come up with something else. Chronos, Tempus, um . . . Freeze Frame? That one’s terrible, sorry—”

“No.” She closed the case and kept it in her hand. “Auerbach is fine. It’s . . . it’s good.”

“Yeah?”

“Yeah.”

The corridor ended at a door stenciled TEMPORARY QUARTERS 7.

“This is you,” he said, opening the door with a tap of his badge. “Door locks from inside, bathroom has toiletries, there’s a tablet on the desk with facility maps and protocols. If you need anything, the comm system is—” He caught himself. “Actually, you probably just want to sleep.”

“Desperately.”

“Right. Sleep. Good. I’ll—I’ll let you do that.” He got three steps down the corridor and turned around. “Hey. For what it’s worth? You’re doing really well. I know this is all overwhelming—new powers, new organization, dying slowly—but you’re handling it better than I would.”

“You don’t know how I’m handling it.”

“I’ve been watching the surveillance footage,” he said. “I know how you were handling it before. This is better.”

Then he was gone around the corner before she could build an answer. She stood in the doorway a moment, holding the case and not building one.

The room was small and clean and belonged to no one, and it held a bed, a desk, a chair, and a lock she controlled. She sat down on the bed, and the bed was softer than her couch, a finding she was uniquely qualified to certify. She set the case on the nightstand where she would see it first.

The day had held one deal, one handler, one suit, one mask, one panic button, one codename, thirty percent and then half, another year and maybe more. She had spent the whole day doing something, and the something was slowly turning her into a cosmic artifact, but it was doing, and doing was new.

Small victories. She was asleep before the lights finished dimming.

Chapter 16

The movies had promised her a “high-tech command center”, and the movies had lied again. Real surveillance had no soundtrack and no quick cuts, and nobody helpfully leaned in to say enhance. It had an elevator ride down that lasted long enough to pop her ears twice, twelve-hour shifts, and chairs built by somebody who actively hated the human back. On paper, the whole facility was a “government office building that happened to have alien technology in the basement.” The paper seriously undersold the basement.

Days blurred down there until she quit tracking which was which. The Academy feeds ran in night-vision green from four angles, and she watched her brother’s team for entire shifts, as she used to watch television. Except that now she was also the network.

The Seed kept its cold under the old wound, the Hyper Seed, Power Extempore, whichever name the files were using that day. It never warmed. She had stopped waiting for it to.

Ryu held down the next chair, fingers drumming between commands. His badge hung crookedly from his shirt pocket: “Dr. Ryu Matsuda - FAERIS Operations.” He was the only person in the building who could interface with FAERIS without the drones going haywire, neurodivergent pattern recognition shaking hands with fourth-dimensional tech, which the rest of the staff treated as a miracle and Ryu treated as a Tuesday. She got that. Her brain didn’t work like brains were supposed to either.

The week came with a deadline. CCPD paperwork sat open on the far screen: a raid on a community center in the Old Caledonia district, filed under “probable cause”, which in Caledonia translated to “we don’t like the people who gather here.” The squad already patrolled three blocks from it most nights, on Ruth’s idea that the smart place to walk was wherever the police were hunting. So the bunker had two jobs. Teach the squad its triggers, and be ready when the paperwork grew boots.

* * *

Tess went first, and Tess failed.

The bridge story had hardened into squad canon by then: she had “teleported”. Off the rail, into thin air, out of an empty sky four blocks inland. On the feeds she spent two nights trying to do it again. She jumped off the vault with her eyes shut and held her breath until she wobbled. She clicked her heels three times, the full Dorothy method, no ruby, no Toto, and landed squarely in Kansas. The heels worked strictly as shoes.

Nothing worked, because nothing could work while her trigger sat unchosen in a bunker under a government office building, between two people with a checklist, and the flashiest power was getting the most care. Ahdia watched her drop off the climbing wall and stalk away, done with the universe, and felt the full Oz of it. She was the wizard. She was also the man behind the curtain.

She was also, per the biometrics, paying for every ticket in the house.

* * *

Ben was easier. Ben already had a habit.

On the feed he reset into his athletic crouch, fixed on a point above the rafters, and jumped for a ceiling he had no business reaching. He had been doing it for days, and Ryu pulled the clip and let the crouch loop endlessly.

“That one?”

She nodded; it was simple, repeatable, already his.

On Ben’s next attempt she reached for the cold and put a bubble around him. A dilation, not a freeze: time ran slow and thick in a sleeve of air with Ben inside it, and FAERIS leaned into the sleeve and amplified. Three feet became thirty. He rose past the rafters like a man on wires nobody had rigged and came down whooping on the high mats.

“That actually worked.”

“You create the time bubble,” Ryu said, already making notes. “FAERIS amplifies within it. Symbiotic.”

“This is much better than what I thought I’d have to do.”

“Which was?”

“Much sweatier.”

Nights later the payoff arrived at the community center. Ben came through a second-story window into a room of drawn weapons, landed in the middle of the cops, and scattered them like pins, then went up into rafters no flashlight ever thought to check.

In the bunker the pull arrived in her chest, low and slow. Her fingers gripped the armrest until it creaked. The armrest held, and so did she.

* * *

Leah tried comics logic first. She stood very still on the feeds and concentrated at a foam block, Jean Grey style, then tried running starts and cape physics and dramatic fists. The universe politely took a pass on all of it.

Then a sparring drill caught her wrong, an elbow found her ear, and the sound she made was older than any comic. It was a battle cry, rage under it and forward momentum behind it. Ahdia answered before she had properly decided to. The bubble took Leah mid-stride and velocity multiplied inside it, and the training dummy left its chain and met a wall. The gym went reverently quiet.

Ryu typed it into the log: “Vocalization plus forward momentum.”

At the raid, a cop swung his barrel toward the corner where the kids were. The cry reached him out of the dark first, and then Leah did, at freeway speed, shoulder first, so that the rifle went one way and the cop went the other.

A vein rose at Ahdia’s temple and kept its own time.

* * *

Victor took a full evening in the weight room, stacking plates, lifting what a strong man lifts and nothing more. Then he quit adding weight and stood a while working one hand, and the gesture he settled on came out of memory: fingers curled, wrist cocked, a grip shaped for rebar. He closed it on the loaded machine.

“That works,” Ryu said.

He typed: “Specific hand position plus grasping motion.”

The next grip tore the machine off its bolts, all six hundred pounds relocated like patio furniture. Victor stared respectfully at his own hand.

At the raid, that hand closed around a rifle barrel. The barrel folded like foil. The cop who owned it got lifted, carried, and set down gently on the gym mats, and behind the whole transaction an organizer sprinted a clear lane to the exit.

Sweat came up on her everywhere at once. She gritted her teeth and held. The bubbles held too.

* * *

Tess stayed unsolved until Ruth asked the right question. Everyone else had asked what she’d tried; Ruth asked what she had been doing the one time it worked.

Tess remembered the bridge, went still on the feed, and then, solemnly, raised her middle finger to the sky.

Ryu turned from the console and gave Ahdia the look he did with both eyebrows. She shrugged and reached for the cold, because the gesture was already the truest sentence Tess owned.

The mechanism was almost respectable. Inside the bubble, FAERIS read her iris and her focal depth, took the exact place she was looking as a destination, and folded the space between. Tess vanished off the mats and reappeared at the top of the climbing wall, screaming happily.

Ryu typed: “Gesture plus eye-tracking.”

At the community center the lead cop had the worst night of his career. Tess, unbound, appeared at his shoulder and was gone before he turned, arrived at his left elbow and left it, the finger raised first every time, a targeting ritual he could not have invented. By the time he understood anything he was zip-tied to a bench and she was three rooftops away.

The ladder topped out there. Warmth slid over Ahdia’s lip. Her fingers came away red.

* * *

Ryu was holding out a box of tissues, and he had also been holding her biometrics on his center screen for days without mentioning it.

“Your hemoglobin is dropping,” he said. “Temporal manipulation is causing microbleeds. Capillaries can’t handle the stress.”

“I’m fine.”

“You’re not.”

He put a graph up. The line went down and did not come back. “Each use accelerates breakdown. Your body is aging microseconds faster than it should. Compounds over time.”

She looked at the line instead of at him.

“How much time do I have?”

Ryu’s fingers stopped. He pulled the ledger up beside the biometrics, and for once he didn’t soften it with a reference. “You bought yourself a year in the training room. This week you spent it on them.”

“At this rate? Eighteen months baseline. Maybe two years if you’re conservative with usage. But . . .”

He let the rest of it stand there.

“Quality of life degrades faster than lifespan. You’ll feel it before you die from it.”

The tissue in her hand had stiffened. She folded it smaller.

“Can you fix it?”

“I’m not a doctor. I can monitor, warn you when you’re approaching critical thresholds. But stop it?” He shook his head. “Only you can do that. By not using the powers.”

“That’s not an option.”

“I know.” He watched the graph a moment longer. “I’ll keep monitoring. Tell you when to stop.”

“And if I don’t stop?”

His fingers went back to drumming the console edge. “Then I’ll document what happens. For science.”

* * *

Ruth got no trigger, because Ruth had no power. Everyone agreed on that, Ruth included: whatever the rest of them had caught, hers hadn’t manifested. The feeds kept disagreeing: on her callouts the team moved half a beat early, tighter than the drill, correct before the correction.

Ryu watched four sessions of it, then typed: “Leadership vocalizations plus team proximity.” He didn’t type a question mark, but she could hear it anyway.

Maybe FAERIS was treating Ruth’s commands as targeting data. Maybe Ruth was that good and always had been. Ahdia ran it both ways, got two clean answers, and left them both standing.

Firas was on the feeds too, every session, at the edge of the mats where the light thinned, present for all of it and part of none. He wore an expression she recognized from mirrors: somebody being left behind by the people he loved. She knew it intimately.

* * *

Assembled, the raid ran thirty seconds end to end.

Five cops came through the front doors at 2 AM with weapons drawn, on a room that still held kids and organizers from a program that should have ended hours before. Ruth stood a rooftop two blocks out and calmly called the play, FAERIS threading her voice into every earpiece half a breath ahead of need. Ben came through the window and the cry came out of the dark. The rifle folded. Tess was everywhere and nowhere, finger first. Ahdia held bubbles layered across the whole team at once, the expensive mode, fields stacked like panes of slow glass, and the cold poured out of her for the entire thirty seconds.

It played like a Hong Kong action movie somebody had shot in one long take. Nobody died. The five cops ended the night zip-tied in a neat row on the gym mats, breathing and humiliated. The civilians saw only blur and salvation. The squad was gone before the radios finished asking their questions.

In the bunker her nose had opened again. This time it did not close. Her hands shook against the console, and Ryu handed her tissues without a word and kept handing them.

He typed the mission log one-handed: “Full combat application successful. Team synchronization optimal. Power reliability: 100%.”

Then he opened the assessment file, and the screen sat angled so that she could read every line from her chair: “Subject demonstrates increasing physical deterioration. Continues operation despite clear signs of life force depletion. Pattern consistent with vindication-seeking behavior superseding self-preservation.”

He didn’t tell her to stop. He only documented. She filed that under kindness and left the rest of it alone.

* * *

Tess cut the footage that night in her apartment, hood up, lit by the laptop, a FAERIS feed watching her watch herself, and the post went up while Ahdia watched it go: “They said we couldn’t make a difference. They said Caledonia was lost. They were wrong. #GoSquad #CaledoniaHope #WhenNobodyElseWill”

The comments came in hundreds inside the hour. Then they came in thousands. Somewhere in the scroll a stranger asked why she kept risking it, and Tess typed back instantly: “People need to see this. They need to know someone’s fighting for them.”

#GoSquad trended locally by morning and regionally by the next night. And in other buildings, on other screens, people with titles ran the same videos frame by frame, closely, and took notes of their own.

* * *

By the end of the week, three beliefs were running at once. The squad believed in its powers. The city believed in its heroes. Her brother believed he wasn’t good enough to stand with either one.

She had manufactured all three, and none of the customers knew the factory existed.

Then Ryu pulled up a new file, and it held mission parameters, a target, and a risk column long enough to need scrolling. Something big was coming, bigger than a community center, bigger than anything the squad had trained for. The Seed sat colder and heavier under the old wound, and the blood kept up its thin patient trickle at her lip.

They were going to be fine, she told herself.

On the screens the team was laughing at something Ben had done, loose and in sync, easier together than they had ever been before her. She watched them in night-vision green. The dread kept its seat through the whole celebration.

Chapter 17

SETTING THE TRAP

The footage was on its fourteenth viewing, and Harding Kain read it like a quarterly report: from the back, hunting the one number that refused to reconcile. On the screen a figure went up the face of a parking structure and arrived at the roofline, thirty feet of sheer concrete in under two seconds. Halfway up, the image smeared, as if the camera itself had flinched. There. Every viewing, right there.

He cut into the lamb without looking down at it. The tray had come up at seven; the office smelled of rosemary and old leather. Forty floors below, the city glittered on services his companies billed it for monthly. His dinner rings clicked against the knife while he chewed, and the blur arrived again where it always arrived. “Run the scanning thing again,” he said.

Reed touched the console without comment, a young man who was expensive and precisely as useful as he cost, which in Kain’s experience made him rare. “Spectral analysis shows the same result, sir. Electromagnetic anomaly during the movement. Military-grade frequency signature.”

Military-grade. That phrase had a catalog price, and TRIOMF wrote the catalog. Kain set the knife down and gave the big signet a slow half turn on its finger.

The money under him ran three generations deep, and none of it had started in security. His grandfather pulled diamonds out of ground that fought him, and broke three strikes to keep pulling; the family albums called it grit. His father built the armored cars that moved the stones, and somewhere on those highway runs he noticed that the fear of losing a thing billed better, year over year, than the thing itself. Harding had taken that public—TRIOMF, the contracts, the candidacy. Monetize fear and call it safety. The stones were the blood, and the armor was only ever the arm. So the signature ruled out amateurs. That was the fourteenth viewing’s dividend: hobbyists did not smear on federal equipment. Somebody with resources had put capital into these people, and unaccounted capital was the only kind that had ever interested him.

The intercom announced Chief Whitford at half past eight, and Reed let himself out before being asked. Whitford came in with a folder held against his thigh. Kain appraised him across the desk: still a serviceable asset, but depreciating, the face above the uniform worn well past its book value. “You look troubled, John.”

“Read it.” The folder landed on the blotter, its CLASSIFIED faded from red to pink, which meant copies of copies and years of hands.

Kain did not touch it. He laced his fingers over his waistcoat and waited like a man at the top of a backswing. “Summarize.”

Whitford’s jaw tightened, and then he recited. “Tech signatures. Military-grade surveillance drones detected during seventeen separate Go Squad operations over the past six weeks.”

He turned a page he knew by heart. “My people were right. Someone’s watching them. Federal-level equipment.”

“FBI? CIA?”

“Neither.”

Kain looked up from the screen for the first time since the chief had come in. “Then who the hell are they?”

“CADENS.” The name landed on nothing. Kain had spent thirty years mapping federal money down to the last classified dollar, and this one had never crossed his desk. Either irrelevant or terrifying. He kept his face shut and waited for the rest.

“Cataclysm Activity Detection and Engagement Network Sentry.”

“Explain.” The rings resumed their slow turn while Whitford found the page.

“Shadow group funded through Special Access Programs. Black budget. Completely autonomous operational authority. Only the Secretary of Defense has direct contact with their leadership, and even he can’t give them orders.”

Every budget had an owner, and every chart had a top box. “Someone can.”

“One person. Director. Codename: Overseer.”

A person above the Secretary of Defense, with no name and no budget line. Kain reached for a price. Nothing attached. The list of things he could not price was a short list, and he disliked every item on it.

“And how,” Kain asked, the rings going still on the desk, “did you acquire classified intelligence on a shadow government program that doesn’t officially exist?”

“Golf.”

“Excuse me?”

Whitford shrugged like the answer embarrassed him. “The Secretary of Defense and I golf regularly. Montclair Country Club, every third Thursday when he’s in town.”

Whitford reported it in the tone of a business expense. “He was less than pleased about learning that CADENS tech was being used to help vigilantes beat up local precincts.”

The signet stopped again on its finger. “He told you this.”

“He implied it. Heavily. After his third whiskey.”

That part Kain believed, having bought better information for less in the same clubhouse weather. Or the Secretary had wanted it carried. That was likelier. Men that senior did not slip. They delivered.

Whitford turned the folder face down before he went on. “Apparently the Overseer doesn’t clear operational details with the Pentagon. Just does what they want. And what they want, currently, is to monitor enhanced individuals in urban environments. Go Squad qualifies.”

Whitford looked at the paused blur for a moment and seemed to dislike where his own sentence was going. “They’re using us as a test case.”

Kain considered the frozen figure on the screen and finished the thought for him. “We’re the rats in the maze. Go Squad are the subjects. CADENS gets to watch how enhanced individuals operate in real-world scenarios against organized opposition.”

“We’re opposition now? Not law enforcement?”

Kain let him keep the question, and the chief paced to the window and answered it himself. “My officers look like fools on every news cycle. ‘Vigilantes outsmart police again.’ ‘Community says Go Squad more effective than CCPD.’ ‘Where are our tax dollars going?’”

Kain watched the chief’s reflection in the dark glass and let him finish. “Your ego is showing, John.”

Whitford’s color was fully up now. “It’s not about ego. It’s about institutional credibility. Every time Go Squad makes us look incompetent, people ask why we can’t do what they do. Why we need military equipment and qualified immunity if a bunch of parkour enthusiasts can do it better.”

There it was, under the budget language. Obsolescence, not ego. A man afraid the market had found a way to route around him—and Kain recognized that fear from the inside and priced the recognition for later use.

“So the Secretary of Defense is angry, but powerless. And in his powerlessness, he shared information he shouldn’t have.”

“Can’t be helped,” Whitford allowed.

He came back from the window. “CADENS operates under Overseer’s complete control, not his. But he did slip some information that could be useful.”

From inside his jacket he drew a second document, thinner, unstamped, deniable: specifications, operating parameters, and a last page with a single heading. VULNERABILITIES. Kain slowly read that page twice. Nothing reached his face.

Kain closed the second document and squared it with the first. “This changes things.”

“That’s what I thought.”

* * *

That morning had belonged to a different file. Reed had delivered it at seven: three hundred pages on Ruth Carter, bound like a prospectus, and Kain had gone through every page over breakfast and finished both at the same time. “Their leader,” Kain said, squaring the pages on the blotter.

Reed answered without opening his copy of the file. “The medical one. She’s the tactical center. Every operation flows through her decisions.”

Kain found the tabbed sheet and read from it. “Johns Hopkins medical degree,” he read, and tapped the line below it with one heavy ring.

He read on down the page. “Top of her class. Published groundbreaking research on cellular regeneration therapy three years ago. Presented at international conferences. Should be running a research department or leading clinical trials.”

Kain set the page down on the squared stack. “Why is she in an ER?”

Reed had the answer ready, which was why Kain kept him. “Politics, looks like. She challenged the chief of surgery over patient care protocols. Got sidelined. Been stuck in emergency medicine ever since.”

Which was not, Kain noted, what the woman herself would say. Her published account blamed the science—the conference, the reception, the doors that stayed shut. She had been told the reason was her work. The file knew it was a man she had crossed.

Kain knew the mechanism. He had rented it more than once. A committee seat. A quiet lunch. And a career went into storage with no document worth a subpoena.

“She’s wasted where she is,” Kain concluded. An appraisal, not sympathy. Mispriced assets offended him on principle.

Reed took the sheet back and squared it with more care than it needed. “Yes sir. But she’s also the tactical center of Go Squad. She’s the weak point.”

Kain turned back to the research summary and ran the figures without a pen: cellular regeneration, published, shelved, unprotected, worth eight figures to the medical subsidiaries if the patents were drafted with any appetite at all. Conservatively eight.

“I want her research,” Kain told him, turning the folder back to its first page.

“Sir?”

Kain laid the file flat and spread one ringed hand on it. “The cellular regeneration protocols. The experimental treatments. All of it. Once we’ve eliminated Go Squad, we acquire the research. Patent it under TRIOMF subsidiaries. She won’t be in a position to object.”

Reed’s pen stopped, and he looked at the carpet and then at a spot in the middle distance, choosing his footing. “Sir . . . she’s Black. You really want to—”

“I want to win.” The room held still around it. His grandfather would have refused her work on principle and died owning less. His father would have stolen it and paid a lawyer to call the theft providence. Harding acquired.

The rings were motionless while he said it. “Personal feelings are expensive luxuries. Her research is valuable. The fact that she’s Black is irrelevant to its value.”

Reed wrote it down, the pen moving now. “Once the trap is set and Go Squad is neutralized, we move on her research. Have legal prepare acquisition documents. Medical board complaints. Patent filings. Make it look clean.”

He closed the folder on the badge photograph, a woman who looked into lenses, and slid it back across the desk. “She built something valuable while they kept her in an ER,” Kain went on.

He stood and buttoned his jacket over the waistcoat. “That’s the problem with institutional punishment. They suppress talent without capturing it. We’ll do better.”

* * *

By nine that evening Whitford had heard the shape of it. He stood at the glass with a scotch he had barely touched, watching the city light itself district by district below. Subtracting things.

“You want to pressure her.”

Kain laid it out in deliverables. “I want her to make a choice. Save herself or save her team. Make it public enough that CADENS can’t intervene without revealing themselves. Make it brutal enough that Go Squad questions whether they’re actually helping or just getting people killed.”

“Break the leadership, break the team.”

Kain turned his chair to face him fully. “Break the team, break the narrative. Break the narrative, remind people why they need order. Why they need someone strong enough to protect them from chaos.”

“You’re going to run on this.”

“I’m going to win on this.”

He said it in the tone he used for confirming wire transfers. Then he nodded at the screen, where the blur still hung mid-climb. “Set the trap. I want them confident. I want them thinking they’re protected. I want them walking into it believing they’re invincible.”

“I’ll coordinate with tactical.” The chief nodded slowly at the carpet.

“You’ll have what you need.” The screen light sat on his rings.

Whitford collected his folders and got as far as the door before he stopped. “There’s one more thing.”

“What?”

Whitford did not turn around when he said it. “The anomalies. The impossible movements. Even with CADENS watching them, they’re too good. Something else is happening.”

Kain waited, because the discomfort on the chief was worth watching; it meant the thought had been carried around for days. “Maybe they are enhanced,” Whitford offered.

He said it like a man testing ice. “Maybe CADENS gave them more than surveillance.”

“Or maybe someone else did.”

Kain heard his own sentence land and disliked it. Two unknowns were operating in his city now, a federal program with no address and whatever lived inside that blur, and he had built his fortune on being the man who knew. He preferred markets with fewer entrants. He preferred names.

Kain rose and came around the desk at his own pace. “If they’re enhanced, we’ll need more than conventional force to stop them.”

“What did you have in mind?”

Kain pressed the intercom with one heavy knuckle. “Get Dr. Jericho from holding. It’s time we had another conversation about his collection.”

* * *

The vault sat four levels under the tower, behind a door labeled CLIMATE ARCHIVE. Sixty-two degrees, forty percent humidity—Jericho’s own specifications, written years ago for the museum, and there was a certain economy in letting the man’s rigor furnish the man’s cage. Kain’s grandfather’s union men had taught the family that you did not break a strike, you broke the man the other men watched, and that isolation did the work of violence at a fraction of the unit cost. Six weeks of clean quiet had been doing that work here. Two guards brought Jericho in and sat him at the steel table. Six weeks ago the man had curated the sub-basement of the Natural History Museum. He had lost weight since, and his collar stood away from his neck. His hands shook. He

flattened them on the table and kept them there while he spoke.

"Walk me through them again," Kain said. The vault door had closed behind the guards on its slow hinge. The cases stood in two rows, twenty-three of them, lit from below. Some of the objects inside sat at angles that did not properly resolve. Kain had stopped trying to make them resolve.

Jericho kept his eyes on the table. "Most of them are inert. Or appear to be. We documented electromagnetic anomalies. Temperature fluctuations. But no active properties we could test safely."

"And the others?"

Jericho looked at the corner case before he answered, then looked away from it, and Kain walked to the corner case and stood beside it. "The Heart of Tamois," Jericho answered.

"Tell me."

Jericho recited it like catalog copy. "Recovered from a dig site in the Maghreb. Private expedition funded by collectors who wanted answers the academic establishment wouldn't provide. Carbon dated at 4.7 billion years."

"Older than Earth."

"Older than the solar system. The object shouldn't exist."

The thing in the case was the size of a fist, and crystalline. It pulsed. Red, then amber, then red again, like a slow heartbeat.

"What does it do?"

The shaking had reached his shoulders. "We don't know. Not exactly. The electromagnetic readings were off the scale. Temperature fluctuations. Temporal distortions in its immediate vicinity."

"Temporal," Kain repeated.

"Time moves differently near it. Milliseconds. Nothing significant. But measurable." Thirty feet of concrete in under two seconds. A camera flinching at nothing. He did not need it explained twice.

"Figure it out," Kain told him.

"What?"

"What it does. How it works. Whether it's useful."

He set one ringed knuckle on the glass, above the pulse. "You have everything you need here. Equipment. Monitoring systems. Time."

"I can't just—we documented these artifacts for years without understanding them. You're asking for answers we don't have." The flat hands had come up off the table.

"Then find them. You're an anthropologist. You study dead civilizations, decode their technology. Do that."

Jericho's glasses had slid down; he did not fix them. "In how long?"

"Forty-eight hours."

"That's impossible."

"Then you'd better work quickly."

He was at the vault door when he stopped and turned around. Jericho had not moved. The red light crossed the man's glasses and left them, crossed them and left them. "Dr. Jericho? You've spent your career studying dead civilizations. Objects from species that no longer exist. Now you get to discover if their solutions still work."

The door sealed on the collection. In the corridor the air ran warmer, and Whitford stood waiting with the guards, out of earshot of the cases. "He'll do it?" Whitford asked.

"He'll do it." Kain moved toward the elevator without waiting.

"And after?"

Kain did not slow down for the answer. "After, we test the Heart. See if the transformation can be controlled. See if we can create something strong enough to stop enhanced individuals."

"You're talking about human experimentation."

"I'm talking about leveling the playing field. Go Squad has powers they shouldn't have. We're going to match them."

"With artifacts from civilizations that died billions of years ago."

"With tools that work. The source doesn't matter. Results do."

"When do we deploy?"

"Once we have the Heart. Once we've confirmed it functions. Then we set the trap."

"And Carter?"

"Carter gets to watch her team fall apart. Gets to choose between saving them and saving herself. Gets to learn that powers and federal protection don't mean invincibility." The elevator carried them up in silence, and Whitford watched the floor numbers the whole way. Kain watched nothing at all.

* * *

The office was empty when he came back to it. He poured nothing and ate nothing. He sat with the skyline until the phone on the credenza rang at eleven, the one with no line into the building. His engineers had opened that wall twice and found no wire behind it, and it rang anyway when it chose to. This was the third call in six months. The first two had each carried one piece of information. Both pieces had been perfect.

He picked it up on the second ring and waited. "Mr. Kain." A woman's voice, precise and clinical, statements where questions should be, like someone who had learned English as a technical specification.

"I'm listening," he said.

"The Heart of Tamois. You have acquired it."

The vault was four levels down, sealed, on no network he had ever ordered built. "I have."

"And Dr. Jericho is attempting to unlock its properties."

That decision was an hour old, made behind a steel door in a room that recorded nothing. "He is."

"He will fail," she said. He turned the signet once and did not answer.

“The Heart requires specific activation protocols. Protocols his civilization does not possess.”

His civilization. He let the phrasing go past.

“You’re offering to help.”

“I am offering partnership. You require tools to neutralize enhanced individuals. I require the artifacts gathered and their properties tested. Our interests align.”

“What do you want in return?”

“The subjects eliminated. Permanently. No capture. No interrogation. Complete removal from the board.”

She kept calling the Go Squad “subjects.” He filed the word where she had set it, flat.

“Why?”

“That is not your concern. You wish to win your campaign. I wish to see these individuals removed. The Heart provides both outcomes.”

He weighed it like any position: cost, return, counterparty. No other bidders. The cost would be carried by other people, the return was everything he wanted, and the counterparty had been right twice already without once explaining herself, and that was itself a data point.

“What are the activation protocols?”

“I will provide them when Dr. Jericho has completed his preliminary analysis. Forty-eight hours, as you specified. After that, you will have what you need.”

As you specified. He had specified it an hour ago, underground, to a man and two guards.

“And you’ll have what you need.”

“Correct.” A pause opened. He waited it out.

“The subjects display capabilities beyond conventional enhancement. This complicates elimination.”

“CADENS?”

“No. CADENS observes. They do not enhance.” He had known that name for three hours. She used it without any weight at all.

“The source of their abilities is irrelevant to your objectives. Focus on elimination, Mr. Kain. Not comprehension.” He had not asked the question she was answering.

“You know something about them.”

“I know they must be removed. That is sufficient.” The rings lay still against the blotter.

“I’ll have Jericho proceed as planned,” he said.

“Excellent. I will contact you in forty-eight hours. The Heart will be functional. Your trap will be ready. The subjects will be eliminated.”

The call ended without a click. The line stopped carrying her. He set the receiver down and filed her where he filed all capital with unclear terms: usable, until the terms arrived. Then he restarted the footage. Fifteenth viewing. The figure went up the face of the concrete, and the image smeared where it always smeared, and the roofline arrived too early.

Problematic, she had called them on the first call, months ago. He was coming to think that was an understatement.

Chapter 18

The staging roof was four stories of cold tar paper with a clean line on the warehouse, and they had reached it on foot, over rooflines, in the dark. Ruth knelt at the parapet with the schematics folded on her thigh. Wind came off the water and went through the armor like it wasn't there. She had pulled enough winter shifts in her life to know the trick: quit negotiating with cold and itemize it. Ben crouched beside her and delivered the tip from memory, flat as a chart note.

"Weapons cache in warehouse district. District 7, near the docks. Kain's people moving product tonight, 2100 hours. Minimal security. Window's tight."

"Thoughts?" Ruth kept her eyes on the warehouse while she asked it.

"Fits the pattern. Kain's been moving operations since the warehouse raid. Makes sense he'd use the docks." Ben laid it out as settled fact, which was how his precinct contact always sold things, and the man had been right about enough of them that nobody in the room asked twice.

Leah lay stretched along the parapet with the binoculars. "Three heat signatures inside. No vehicles in the lot yet. If they're moving product, we're early."

"Good," Victor agreed, cracking each knuckle in turn. "Hit them during setup. Before they're organized."

"I like it when they're not organized." That was Tess, hood up against the wind.

Ruth ran the assignments worst first and nearest second. Victor and Ben would take the loading dock. Tess and Leah would hold the roof. She would keep the perimeter and call it from comms, because somebody had to see the whole patient. Twenty minutes of planning and it sat right. She checked her watch against the window and found nineteen to spare.

"Oh. Oh no." Tess had her phone out, the screen lighting her chin blue.

"What?" Victor leaned in from her other side.

"Wait," Ben said, looking over her shoulder. "How do they know our codenames?"

"There's like . . . hundreds of posts using them. Battlea this, Night Knight that." Leah had her own phone out now, thumb moving quickly.

"Did you—" Victor let the accusation finish itself.

"What? No!"

"Gloom Girl." Leah turned her screen around as evidence.

"I didn't leak anything," Tess insisted, and then honesty caught up with her, a block behind. "I just . . . may have used them. In a few posts. Months ago. Hypothetically."

"Firas is going to love this," Ruth said.

"Or kill me," Tess muttered, pocketing the phone.

Ruth let them keep the laugh, because a laugh before an op was cheap sedation and she genuinely believed in sedation. What was underneath it she kept for herself. Strangers had names for them now, and a named thing draws eyes, and eyes make every mistake bigger. She noted it and filed it and went back to the window they were burning.

At forty minutes to the hour she brought them onto the net.

“Everyone check in,” Ruth said. “Comms clear?”

They came back crisply and one at a time, and under the check-ins ran the feeling she had privately quit questioning: the team was right tonight. Everyone half a step early, tight on her callouts, like a good trauma bay gets ten minutes before a bad arrival, when the room already knows its shape. Whatever her own part in that was, she had stopped asking. It worked, and tonight working was the whole chart.

“No better place than here,” Ruth said, because Firas had built the call four years ago and traditions were load-bearing.

“No better time than now.” It came back from all of them at once and in step.

“Moving in,” Victor reported, and the entry was clean: two shadows crossed the lot, took the loading dock door, and were gone inside it while the night stayed quiet enough that she could hear her own pulse under the earpiece.

“Clear inside,” Victor said. “Setting up position.”

Eight minutes to the window. The lot stayed empty, and empty had stopped feeling early.

“Something’s wrong,” Tess reported from the roof. “There’s nobody here. Warehouse is empty.”

Three heat signatures, and nobody home. Ruth trusted the patient over the chart, every time, in every building.

“Abort. Everyone out. Now.”

“Too late,” Ben answered from the dark.

The floodlights arrived all at once, three sides of the lot going white as an operating room. Fifteen units at minimum, SWAT vans seeded among the cruisers, deployment already out and moving, every exit her plan had liked already spoken for. Nobody stages that in eight minutes. That force had been parked in the dark since before her team crossed its first rooftop, which meant the tip had never been intelligence. It had been an invitation, and she had RSVP’d for five.

“This is CCPD. You are surrounded. Exit the building with your hands visible.” The megaphone managed to sound bored.

“Shit,” Leah breathed.

“Smoke and scatter,” Ruth snapped. “Formation Delta. IR goggles. Move.”

The canisters went down and the lot became weather. She held her position and called the lanes, and the team threaded them as drilled, four shadows moving through white on choreography they owned, crossing gaps the flashlights kept guessing at and kept getting wrong. All four out of the cordon clean, on training. She allowed herself one full second of professional pride, because that was a thousand hours of dark gym and the pride was earned.

Then her goggles died. Full charge, mid-sweep, dead glass. She toggled the power twice, as you re-check a flat line before you believe it, and got nothing back. The GPS unit followed it down. The radio lived, barely, gone thin and scratchy.

“Anyone else losing equipment?” Tess sounded more puzzled than scared. That would not last.

“IR’s down,” Victor confirmed. “GPS too.”

“What the hell—” Victor again, and the rest of it went wherever it went.

“Powers are down,” Leah said, and the static could not hide what rode in on it. “I can’t—they’re just gone.”

Gone was nearly the wrong word for what Ruth heard after that; it was more like altitude, four strong people still moving and still trained but suddenly breathing thinner air, heavier inside their own bodies than they had been thirty seconds before. She caught it in the footfalls and in the half beat everything now landed behind. In herself she felt no change at all, and she had no idea what that meant, and no time to spend on it.

“You don’t need them. You’re trained. Stay focused.”

“Fall back to secondary positions,” Ruth ordered. “Stay in smoke. Use training. You’ve got this.”

They steadied, and she could actually hear it happen, which mattered more than whatever had been subtracted, because panic killed faster than anything else the night had shown her yet.

“Contact. North side. What the hell is that?” Ben called, and the smoke gave her nothing to confirm it with.

Through a seam in the smoke she found it. Seven feet of armored figure walked out of the floodlight wash at a stroll, wrong in scale against the cruisers. An officer broke cover to run, and the figure caught him one-handed and threw him, and the man crossed fifteen feet of air and folded a patrol car door around himself. Her eye read the landing automatically: scapula, ribs, spleen if he was unlucky. He stayed down, and nobody went to him.

“New player,” Ruth warned. “Enhanced. Real enhanced. Everyone stay clear.”

“It’s a goddamn tank!” Victor yelled, already flanking left with his staff up, because staying clear had never once been Victor’s discipline.

The Tank let him commit, took the staff on a forearm, and closed one hand over Victor’s wrist. The turn he made was small and terrible. Ruth read the arm as she would a film in a lightbox, elbow driven past its stop, shoulder rolling out of station, and then Victor was on the concrete and not using that arm to get up.

“Victor!” Tess screamed it from the roofline.

Leah was already in. Two textbook strikes with full hips behind both, and then she was through a stacked pallet and down among the broken boards, and the whole sequence had used less time than the naming of it.

Ben went low and never finished. The Tank lifted him by the throat one-handed, boots clear of the ground, and held him there like a man holding a clipboard he meant to read later.

“Put him down!” Ruth shouted, and she was off her perch and dropping through the fire escape before the sentence ended.

The Tank turned toward her and opened his hand. Ben hit the ground breathing. That was the trade on offer, and she took it.

The board sorted itself in one pass, the last clear thinking the night allowed her. Victor down, arm gone. Leah down, status unknown. Ben down, airway bruised at minimum. Police tightening from three sides, and one enhanced problem standing in the middle of her wounded. The math had only the one answer.

“Everyone fall back. Get clear. I’ll draw him off.”

“Ruth, no—” Tess again.

“That’s an order.”

She ran east and the docks took a quarter mile and she gave it everything, lungs tighter every block, cold air coming down her throat like blades. Behind her he followed at his own pace, and the sound of him never fell away. The container yard let her into its steel canyons, right and left and right on memory and guess. Then the canyon quit, and there was no more east. Black water at the toe of her boots, breathing against the pilings. It would be forty degrees this month. Ten minutes to hypothermia for a strong swimmer, less in armor, and she knew it before she finished stopping.

“Team, sound off. Everyone clear?”

Static.

“Anyone copy?”

The channel hissed, empty. Alone then at the edge of the water, with the sound of him coming through the containers, unhurried as a man walking his own property.

He came around the last stack at a walk, and under the yard lights he undid the helmet and lifted it off, and the face underneath was the worst thing the night had produced. Thirty or so, and clean-shaven. A face assembled from features nobody would swear to, offering nothing to remember. She would have lost it in a waiting room inside a week.

“Dr. Carter,” the Tank said.

Her name. She held her feet still and her face closed while it landed, because armor that knew her name changed the size of everything behind it.

“You should have stayed in the ER.”

“How do you know my name?” Ruth asked, and hated needing to.

“Everyone knows your name now.”

Which answered nothing. The city knew the codenames—Tess had seen to that months ago, and none of them were hers. Somebody had put a file together, and this man had read it.

He set the helmet on a bollard, taking his time, a man on shift with the job well in hand.

“Mr. Kain sends his regards. Says your research will be very valuable. Once you’re out of the way.”

Her research. Three years on a shelf, and it surfaced here at the edge of black water, in a hired mouth. She put it away with everything else she could not use yet.

“You’re enhanced,” Ruth said. “Real enhanced. Not like us.”

“Finally figured that out?” He sounded mildly interested. “Your tricks stopped working the moment the EMP hit. Ours didn’t.”

An EMP, then. She set it beside the dead goggles and the thin radio and left it there, because it bought her nothing at this range.

“What did they give you?” Ruth asked, stalling with the only thing she had left. “What kind of enhancement?”

“The kind that matters.” He rolled his shoulders once, loosening them. “The kind that can’t be turned off with a magnet.”

“You know what happens next,” the Tank said, and he said it without any weight at all. “Make it easy. Don’t run.”

She looked at the water and then at the man. The water was forty degrees, ten minutes, and a current she did not know, and the man was certain. She went for the gap between the containers, low and fast, and she was fast.

His hand closed on her arm before her third step landed. He turned her effortlessly, walked her backward, and set her at the dock edge with her heels on the last inch of it.

“Brave,” the Tank said. “Stupid, but brave.”

The fist came back. The water waited.

Chapter 19

Ruth closed her eyes. Nothing in front of her was worth watching, and some old animal part of her preferred the dark for this. The fist came. She heard the wind of it arrive at her ear as a low whistle, the sound heavy things make once they have finished deciding.

Then the whistle stopped in the middle of itself.

The water quit slapping the pilings behind her heels. The yard lights held their hum on one flat note and stayed there. She waited three seconds for the pain, strictly out of habit, and the pain declined to arrive. So she opened her eyes.

The fist hung four inches from her jaw. Above it the snarl had locked into place, upper lip drawn off the teeth, and the eyes behind it stayed open and dry and still. Her own breath left her and hung in the cold air in a shape that would not drift. Twenty feet off, at the mouth of the container canyon, a small figure stood with one hand out.

Ruth knew that posture. Shoulders squared against something, chin up, one arm extended as though holding a door for somebody slower.

“Ahdia?”

The figure took a step, stopped, and took another, and the walk was wrong in a way Ruth catalogued before she could stop herself: weight loaded onto the right leg, the left arm swinging dead. “Don’t move,” Ahdia said, and the words crossed the yard flat and certain.

* * *

Ruth turned her head slowly, because slowly seemed to be the only speed the world would still accept. Six meters out from the small figure the air changed. She could see the seam. Inside it everything held; past it the night went on being a night, a light bar sweeping red across the far container tops, a gull tilting and staying tilted only until it crossed the line. Standing at the boundary was the difference between being underwater and surfacing, and she was standing at it. Her heels were on the last inch of the dock. Her shoulders, by perhaps four inches, were inside the seam.

“You’re at the edge of the . . . the freeze. If you step outside, you’ll unfreeze too. Just . . . stay still.”

Ahdia crossed to her, and the crossing cost. Blood from the left nostril, tracked to the jaw and dried once already. Tremor in the extended hand, fine and fast. Tactical gear, matte black and torn open at the shoulder, and a black domino mask hanging off one corner of her face. Six meters of field traveled with her, and the seam slid forward over Ruth like a tide coming in, and the dock edge stopped being a border.

She made herself look at the fist again. It had moved. A hair, perhaps less, in the time she had spent looking away and back. The world was not stopped at all. The world had been slowed to a

rate at which a man's whole punch would take a week, and her mind refused the number and accepted the fist.

Ahdia walked around him. She set two fingertips against the outside of his right knee, held them there, and lifted them away. She did it again under his left shoulder blade. She did it a third time at the solar plexus, and a fourth at the other knee, and by the second one Ruth had it, because she had done it herself a hundred times with a violet pen on a shaved abdomen. The girl was marking incision points.

Then the yard came back on.

For half a second the whistle resumed and the water slapped and the lights buzzed, and the fist crossed an inch of the four it had left. Then it locked again. Ahdia had a hand flat on a container and her head down.

"Sorry. Can't hold it as steady as I used to."

Nothing in Ruth's training covered a reply to that. She kept her heels where they were.

"This is going to be weird," the girl said.

"When I unfreeze him, he's going to keep punching. But you won't be there anymore. I'll move you. Just . . . don't freak out, okay?"

"Okay," Ruth said.

"On three," Ahdia said.

Ahdia stepped in and laid her palm against the man's sternum and leaned on it, the exact pressure you use on a door you know is unlocked. "One . . . two . . ."

There were hands on Ruth's shoulders. Then there was nothing, an interval with no content whatsoever, and then she was ten feet to the left with her back against cold steel, and her body reported no memory of having traveled. The gap frightened her more than the fist had.

The world let go.

The punch finished into empty air and carried him a stumbling half step, and in that instant the four touches landed together. His right knee folded sideways. Something across his back gave with a sound Ruth felt in her own teeth. He came off his feet, and the gentle hand that had leaned on his sternum arrived as a truck, and he went backward through the wall of a container and did not come out of it.

Then Ahdia dropped.

Ruth got to her before her knees landed, which was reflex. She went to the ground with her and turned her and the doctor took over, because the doctor always did. Pulse thready and far too fast. Skin burning through the torn suit. Pupils blown wide and slow to answer the light. Respirations shallow, fast, and getting worse while she watched.

"Ahdia. Look at me. Focus."

"Saved you . . . like I saved all of them . . ."

Ruth's mind did what it did with any presentation that made no sense, which was to quit arguing with the symptoms and go hunting the one disease underneath them.

Tess off the bridge rail into open air and delivered unhurt onto a rooftop four blocks inland. Somebody carried her. Victor's hand closing on a rifle barrel and folding it like foil, in a man who could not deadlift what that takes. Somebody amplified him. Ben leaving a roof at three feet and arriving at thirty, always on the same crouch. Somebody put him there. Leah at freeway speed, shoulder first, in a woman Ruth had treated for a hamstring.

Her own callouts, the team a half beat early on every one of them. She reached that item, turned it twice, and set it down unsolved, because the rest of the list was answering.

Tonight an EMP had gone off in that lot and taken four powers off the board inside one second, and left her precisely as she had always been. She had wondered what that meant about her, and the answer was that it meant nothing about her. It meant the other four had been running on something outside their own bodies.

That something was lying in her lap, bleeding from the nose, twenty-seven years old, and supposed to be dead since August.

"The powers," Ruth said.

Her hand had gone still on the girl's wrist. "Their powers. That was you."

"They needed . . . to believe . . ."

"You've been dying to give us powers we never had," Ruth said.

Ahdia's eyes closed. "Worth it."

Ruth put the back of her hand against the girl's forehead, a mother's gesture and not a physician's, and did it anyway. "You're burning up."

"How long have you been doing this?"

"Since the warehouse. Since the explosion. Since you all . . ."

The sentence quit and restarted somewhere else, as sentences do when the blood pressure has opinions. "Needed to matter. Needed to help. He said I was already dead inside, so . . . might as well be useful while . . ."

Ruth had been standing in that room. She had watched Firas say it and had taken him apart for saying it, and the whole time there had been nobody behind the blue foam vault, and the air in that corner had stayed empty.

Ahdia stopped breathing.

"Ahdia!"

"Stay with me. Come on."

Her kit held a tourniquet, gauze, shears, and one ampule of epinephrine, and she had never been so out of ideas. There was no wound. There was no bleed she could compress and no airway she could open. This wasn't an injury. This was collapse, a whole system shutting down, and the only intervention that mattered had already been used on a woman kneeling at the edge of the water.

The radio at her collar came up out of its static. "Dr. Carter."

"Who is this?"

"My name is Ryu. I'm here to extract the asset."

“The ‘asset’ is a person,” Ruth said. She had two fingers under the jaw, hunting a pulse that kept declining to be found. “And she’s dying.”

“I’m aware.”

“CADENS can help her. But we need to move. CCPD three minutes out.”

“What the hell is CADENS?”

“Come with her and find out. Or stay and watch her die. Your choice. Clock’s ticking.” Something came down the canyon at shoulder height with running lights on it, unhurried and openly visible, towing a stretcher that carried itself. Behind it a man in a windbreaker jogged into the light, badge on a lanyard, a scientist doing fieldwork badly.

She made the drone show her the feeds first. Four green shapes north of the cordon, upright, moving together, away. Victor’s shoulder would want setting. Ben would breathe wrong for a week. All four had airways. The woman on the dock did not.

“I’m not leaving her side,” Ruth said.

“Then you’re coming with us. Hold on.”

Ruth got both hands under the girl and did not let go, and then the light climbed past white and the docks folded inward like origami, and every cell she owned received the correction on a slightly different schedule. She arrived on her hands and knees on polished concrete and threw up twice, while above her a man said something calm about protocols.

The room was a medical bay built by people with no budget ceiling. Articulated arms lifted Ahdia off the floor and laid her on a table without a human hand touching her, and screens came down on their own, and Ruth got herself upright by the wall and made her hands stop. “Tell me what’s wrong with her.”

“She’s dying. But you already knew that.” The woman had come in behind her without noise. Silver-gray, past fifty-five, dressed for a boardroom at an hour when boardrooms are dark.

“Who are you?”

“Director Overseer Bourn. CADENS. And you’re Dr. Ruth Carter—emergency medicine, Johns Hopkins, cellular regeneration research that conventional medicine laughed out of conferences.”

Ruth had spent three years learning to hear that sentence without flinching, and mostly she had succeeded.

“We need to talk. But first, let’s stabilize your friend.” The nearest screen wrote itself in white while the arms worked.

“Cellular Degradation Rate: Accelerating”

“Temporal Phase Variance: 47%”

“Telomere Integrity: 18% (CRITICAL)”

“Projected Viable Function: 18 months ± 6 months”

Telomere analysis took a lab three weeks and a grant application. This machine had done it in under a minute, and Ruth registered the professional awe, filed it for a night she could afford, and went straight at the number instead. “Eighteen months,” she said. “Best case scenario.”

“That’s if she stops using her powers completely,” Bourn said. “Every use accelerates breakdown. Tonight’s intervention alone depleted another 4%.”

Four percent. A fist, a wall, ten feet of a woman moved sideways out of its way. She made herself hold the number where she could see it. “At her current rate . . .”

“Weeks. Maybe less.”

“Can you stop it?”

“Can you un-shoot someone? Put aged cells back together?”

“No.”

“Neither can we. We can only slow it. Make the time she has left . . . matter.”

Bourn indicated a chair against the wall with two fingers, like a surgeon indicates an instrument. “Sit,” she said. “I’ll explain everything. And then you can decide if you want to help her, or watch her burn herself out trying to save people who don’t even know she exists.”

* * *

An hour later Ruth stood at an observation window above a lit table with a small figure on it, and the broad strokes had come in the same flat register. An artifact in a warehouse. Drones that amplified whatever she gave them. Six weeks of monitoring, timestamped, unbroken, beginning the night Ruth herself had been dragged out of a burning building believing she had lost her.

“You saw what she can do,” Bourn said. “Imagine that scaled up. Imagine using it against actual threats. Cosmic-level incidents. Things that would make Kain look like a playground bully.”

“You want to use her,” Ruth said.

“We want to keep her alive long enough to transition the team to truth. FAERIS drones are learning. Evolving. Eventually they’ll be able to provide real enhancements without her temporal manipulation. But we need time.”

“How much time?”

“Months. Maybe a year. If we’re lucky.”

Bourn stood at the glass beside her and did not look through it. “Your research,” she said. “Cellular regeneration protocols. Could they work on temporal degradation?”

Ruth ran it before she answered, honestly, as she would for a resident. “Possibly,” she said. “The principle is similar. Accelerate cellular repair. Reduce breakdown rate. I’d need to adapt the protocols. Test dosages. Monitor effects.”

“You’d have access to our resources. Full lab. Synthesis equipment. Isotopes you can’t get anywhere else.”

Three years of grant applications for isotopes, offered at two in the morning like a mint on a pillow. “You’ve been watching my research.”

“For two years. Since your first paper. We knew you’d intersect with our work eventually.”

“You knew I’d be useful.”

“We knew you were brilliant. And that brilliance would be needed.”

The word went in somewhere old and sat there. A room of men had decided years ago what her work was worth, and this organization had disagreed and never said so.

“We just didn’t know how.”

“What’s the offer?”

“Keep her alive as long as possible. Help transition Go Squad to truth when FAERIS achieves independence. Be our liaison—they trust you.”

“You want me to manage the lie.”

“Manage the transition. There’s a difference.”

Ruth let that sit, because there was a difference, and it was smaller than either of them was pretending. “I need to see your lab first,” she said. She put her back to the glass and negotiated as an equal or not at all. “And I need full disclosure on what you know about her condition. Everything. No secrets.”

“Deal. Dr. Ryu will give you the tour. Then we’ll discuss terms.”

“One more thing,” Ruth said. She sorted it worst first, and the worst was on the table behind the glass. “I tell my team I got separated during the fight. I tell them I’m clear. They can’t know about this. Not yet.”

“Agreed. We’ll translocate you back near the Academy. Make it look like you escaped on your own.”

Her phone had survived the night. Her goggles had not. She typed it with her thumb.

“Had to split off. I’m clear. Meet at Academy.”

Then she looked once more through the glass, at the girl the whole city had already buried, and got nothing back from her own face in the reflection.

Chapter 20

The corridor ran a hundred yards without a window. Ruth walked it close to one wall, a habit from buildings she had not chosen to enter. An hour ago a woman in a boardroom suit had used the words “shadow government facility” in the tone other people save for parking garage. Then, in the same flat delivery, “cosmic threats.”

Ryu walked ahead of her at a pace that kept turning into a jog. He talked over his shoulder for most of it.

“—so the cellular regeneration protocols you published three years ago were genuinely groundbreaking,” he said. “The way you approached accelerated healing through localized metabolic manipulation—that’s exactly the kind of thinking we need. Most researchers get stuck on macro-level solutions but you went micro, which is brilliant, and I know I’m talking too much but I get excited about this stuff and—”

He stopped walking suddenly enough that she nearly took his heels off.

“Sorry.”

He pushed his glasses up and squared the badge on his shirt pocket with both hands, tidying whatever happened to be nearest.

“I do that. The talking thing. My brain moves faster than my mouth and then my mouth tries to catch up and it just . . .”

“It’s fine,” Ruth said. It was mostly true. She had been running three words behind him since the elevator, still turning over “shadow government facility.”

He badged them through a door that took two full seconds to decide about him. “This is the main research lab.”

The room went sixty feet back, and it was the quiet that costs money: four synthesis benches down the left wall, pharmaceutical grade, the good ones. Behind leaded glass stood the isotope libraries, labeled in a hand nobody had rushed, and over the center table a molecular model turned slowly, amber and white, unbuilding and rebuilding itself like weather. Ruth had written grant applications for one item on that wall. Three years of them. She never got it.

A desk stood in the corner with its surface cleared and its chair squared to it, and there was no nameplate on it, no dust, nothing on the blotter at all. Somebody had been keeping it ready.

“This is where you’d work,” Ryu said. He took his hands out of his pockets and put them back. “If you agree. Full access to everything. Synthesis capabilities, isotope libraries, computational modeling. Whatever you need.”

“The temporal degradation data,” Ruth said, already crossing to the display. “Can I see the full workup?”

He brought it up without sitting down, and Ahdia assembled herself in gray above the center table, life-size and slowly turning. Fine threads ran through the gray, gathered thick at the center of the chest, then went outward along the vessels, root-like, into both shoulders and down the long

bones. Ruth walked around it once. She stopped at the hands, where the threads thinned and stopped short of the fingertips.

“The Hyper Seed integration,” she said.

“It’s converting her. Slowly. Every time she uses her powers, it spreads a little more. Replaces biological tissue with something else. Something that can channel temporal energy.”

She asked for the panels, and he stacked every one they had beside the body while she read down the columns. Apoptosis rates, telomere lengths, mitochondrial output falling off a shelf. She had read these exact columns, in this order, in men who had been on fire.

“The mechanism,” Ruth said. The certainty arrived a full second before the reasoning that properly justified it. “It’s cellular stress. Just like gunshot trauma or burns. The stressor is different—temporal manipulation instead of physical damage—but the cellular response is identical. Accelerated apoptosis. Telomere degradation. Metabolic collapse.”

Ryu’s fingers went still on the console edge. “Exactly.” He came quickly around to her side of it. “We’ve tried conventional interventions. Nothing works. The temporal nature of the stress makes it impossible to treat with standard medicine.”

They had gone at it as a temporal problem, which was the honest mistake of people who owned the only instruments capable of measuring one. Ruth looked at the threads and saw a burn.

“My CR-7 protocol,” she said. “The cellular regeneration treatment I’ve been developing. It’s designed for trauma patients. Gunshot wounds. Burns. Severe tissue damage.”

“I’ve read your papers. It’s revolutionary.”

“It never got institutional approval. Too experimental. Too risky.” The sentence had a groove worn into it by now, and it came out smooth. “I’ve been working on it in stolen hours between ER shifts. Testing on small samples. Never had the resources for proper trials.”

“You have them now.”

He said it, a man reporting a temperature, and then he stood there and waited while she took in the row of benches, one at a time.

“The principle is the same,” Ruth said. “Accelerate cellular repair. Provide metabolic support. Reduce the degradation rate. I’d need to modify the isotope ratios—temporal stress probably affects different cellular pathways than physical trauma. And the dosage would need careful calibration. Too little won’t help. Too much could accelerate the transformation.”

“I can synthesize whatever formulation you need. We have isotopes you can’t get anywhere else. Computational models to predict cellular response. We can have a test batch ready in hours.”

“Hours?”

“This is CADENS. We don’t wait for grant approval.”

She had spent her professional life waiting on committees that met quarterly, and this man had just quoted her a turnaround in hours. “It won’t be a cure,” she said. “Best case, it buys time. Extends the timeline from weeks to months. Maybe a year or two if we’re lucky.”

“That’s more than she has now.”

“I’ll need Ahdia’s full cellular workup. Blood samples. Tissue samples if you have them. Baseline metabolic data. I need to understand exactly how the Seed is affecting her before I can counter it.”

“Already compiled.” He turned a second display toward her, and the index on it ran past the bottom of the frame and kept going. “Everything we’ve collected since the warehouse. It’s all here.”

Weeks of samples, drawn and logged and kept faithfully current by people who could not read them, waiting for somebody who could. The somebody had turned out to be her. “You said you’ve been monitoring my research for two years,” Ruth said.

“Since your first paper on metabolic acceleration. We knew it would be relevant eventually.”

“You knew I’d be useful.”

“We knew you were brilliant. The world just hadn’t figured that out yet.”

She set the panel down and squared it to the bench edge, and she left the compliment lying where he had put it. There was work. “Okay,” she said. “Show me the synthesis lab. We’re going to need to move fast.”

* * *

Four hours later the vial stood upright in a rack under the bench light, four milliliters of it, pale blue and faintly cloudy at the bottom until you turned it. Ruth had built it in a room where nothing had to be begged for, and the whole of it had taken less time than a single shift.

“This is it,” Ruth said.

“You’re sure?”

“No.” She did not dress the word up. “But it’s the best shot we have. Weeks to eighteen months, if it works. Two years if we’re lucky.”

“And if it doesn’t?”

“Then she dies faster.”

Ruth looked at the vial and not at him. “I’ll need to be present for every dose. Real-time adjustments. Clinical judgment.”

“How often?”

“Every three weeks to start. Monthly once she stabilizes.” She capped the rack and stripped her gloves. “This only works if she stops using her powers every night.”

“Good luck with that.”

“Yeah.”

He wheeled his stool back from the bench and sat on it wrong, one leg up, the tablet forgotten against his knee. “Why couldn’t we figure this out? We tried everything. Standard protocols, gene therapy, metabolic support. Nothing worked.”

“You tried what’s in the literature,” Ruth said. “I’ve been working an ER for three years while I built this. You learn things about bodies that never make it into papers. The papers I published were incomplete.”

“On purpose?”

“Hospital administrators don’t approve experiments. So I didn’t tell them everything.” She nodded at the synthesis rig behind him, four hundred pounds of machinery that had done in four hours what she herself could not have done in four years of trying. “You can synthesize anything. But you don’t know which patients need which dosages. When to push. When to pull back. That’s not science. That’s art.”

“That’s why we needed you.”

She washed her hands at the sink and dried them, and she did not turn around immediately. “Before we do this,” Ruth said. “Tell me the truth. Why does CADENS really need her alive?”

“Cosmic threats,” Ryu said. “Dimensional breaches. Things we can’t stop. Ahdia might be the only Temporalist who can.”

“And if she dies?”

“We hope FAERIS learns fast enough.”

Ruth lifted the vial out of the rack. She closed her hand around it. “I’m not doing this for CADENS,” she said. “I’m doing this because she’s my friend.”

“I know.” He got off the stool. “That’s why you’ll succeed where we failed.”

* * *

“There’s something you should see,” Ryu said at the door. “It’s relevant to the long-term plan.”

Two levels down, a window looked into a test chamber with a padded floor and a training dummy on a weighted stand, and one FAERIS unit hung at head height in the middle of it, doing nothing. Ryu called what the drones did to her team “enhancements”, and Ruth had watched that word fold a rifle barrel like foil.

“Watch,” he said, and then, to the console: “Execute enhancement protocol.”

The unit dropped four feet and held. Nothing in the chamber changed color or made a sound. The dummy’s arm came around on its stand at an ordinary speed. Then the air in a two-meter sleeve went thick and slow and slightly wrong to look at, and the arm inside the sleeve traveled four times as far as its own hinge permitted. The stand rocked and settled, and Ruth read the numbers along the bottom of the glass twice.

“No temporal field,” Ryu said. “No Ahdia. The drone did that by itself.”

“It’s replicating her powers?”

“At about 10% effectiveness. But yes. The drones have been learning. Observing how Ahdia manipulates time, how she creates the enhancement effect. They’re developing the capability independently.”

“How long have they been doing this?”

“Three days. Started small—minor accelerations, barely measurable. But the effect is strengthening.” He put a curve up on the glass, and the line left the flat, climbed, and then kept on climbing. “At current progression, they’ll reach 50% effectiveness in six months. Full capability in a year, maybe eighteen months.”

Ruth arrived at the end of it before he did. “When Ahdia dies, the team won’t lose their powers.”

“Eventually. If FAERIS evolution continues at this rate. If we can keep Ahdia alive long enough for the transition.”

“They’re becoming sentient,” Ruth said.

“We don’t use that word. Not yet. But . . . maybe.”

“What happens when they don’t need her anymore?”

“I don’t know. The drones are learning from her technique, but they’re also developing beyond it. Adapting. Finding more efficient methods.” He watched the unit hold its station in the empty chamber. “In theory, they could eventually provide enhancements that are safer, more sustainable than what Ahdia does through sheer force of will.”

“In theory.”

“In theory.”

The curve stayed up on the glass, climbing over its own numbers. “Does Ahdia know?”

“Bourn told her. Part of the original recruitment pitch. ‘Help us long enough for FAERIS to learn, then you can step back.’” He shrugged with one shoulder only. “But Ahdia can’t step back. Every time someone’s in danger, she intervenes. Burns through her life force like it’s infinite. The treatment you just developed? It buys her time. But only if she stops trying to save everyone every night.”

“And she won’t.”

“Would you?”

Ruth thought about twelve-hour shifts. She thought about the nights she had stayed past them, and about the four people searching the docks for her body. “No,” she said. “I wouldn’t.”

Below them the FAERIS unit came about on its axis, unhurried, and stopped facing the observation window. It stayed that way. “That’s new,” Ryu said.

“What?”

“That level of environmental awareness. The drones weren’t doing that yesterday.”

He watched it a while. His fingers took up their drumming on the rail, faster than before. He collected his tablet off the sill.

“Come on,” he said. “Let’s get you to medical. Ahdia should be awake by now.”

* * *

The ceiling was white. It had no water stain on it, which was how she knew she was not home.

Ahdia lay still and did the rest of it in order. The light came from a strip along the wall, and there was no window anywhere. Underground, then, or close to it. The equipment beside the bed belonged in a hospital. It made no sound. It had no wheels. It carried no brand name on any surface that she could see. A line ran into the back of her hand, taped down twice.

Then the pieces came back. Containers, black water, a fist stopped four inches off Ruth’s jaw, four points on a man who never once felt them being marked. After that, concrete, and Ruth’s

hands, and nothing else.

Her mouth tasted like metal. She turned her head. Ruth stood in the doorway with a hard case under one arm.

"Hey," Ruth said.

"Hey."

The word came out thin and used. She tried again on something longer.

"I'm alive?"

"For now." Ruth set the case on the tray table and unlatched it. "How do you feel?"

"Like I died and came back wrong."

"Close." Ruth took out a vial of something pale blue. She stood it upright in the tray. "You almost did die. On the docks. In the translocation. Twice in medical before we stabilized you."

Ahdia looked at the ceiling for a while.

"Why didn't you let me?"

"What?"

"I was done. I saved you. That's all I needed to do. Why bring me back?"

Ruth stopped what her hands were doing. She left them stopped. "Because you're my friend."

"You barely know me."

"I know enough." She pulled the chair over and sat down. "I know you've been dying to give my team powers they never had. I know you've been burning through your life force every night because you can't stand watching people get hurt. I know you think that makes you useful instead of worthy."

"It's the same thing."

"It's not."

Ahdia turned her hand over on the blanket and looked at the tape.

"If I'm not useful, what am I?"

She waited for Ruth to answer that. Ruth did not. The rest of it came out on its own.

"I'm not . . . I don't have anything else. No job. No life. I watch TV twelve hours a day and order gas station food and hide in my apartment because going outside means I might have to be a person and I don't know how to do that anymore. The only thing I'm good at is stopping time. Take that away and I'm just . . ."

"Just what?"

"Nothing."

Ruth did not move in the chair. "You saved my life tonight. You've saved Victor. Ben. Tess. Leah. Firas. Every person we've helped for months. You've been dying by inches to give them hope. How is that nothing?"

"Because they don't know." Ahdia kept her eyes on the ceiling. "They think they're heroes. They think they have powers. They don't know it's me. Invisible. In the background. Fixing everything while they get to be . . . people."

"You're a person too."

“I don’t feel like one.” The next part came out level, because it was only a description. “I feel like a tool that wears skin. Something that gets used until it breaks. And then what? Then I’m just taking up space.”

The room stayed quiet. Somewhere behind the bed a machine changed its note and changed back.

“I used to think that too,” Ruth said. She sat back. “Hopkins wanted me for research. Brilliant work. Groundbreaking. Then I challenged the chief of surgery and suddenly I’m in the ER. Twelve-hour shifts. Gunshot wounds. Overdoses. Watching people die because the system’s too slow or too cheap or too corrupt to save them. I thought—if I’m not doing the research, if I’m not changing medicine, what’s the point? I’m just another body in scrubs.”

“What changed?”

“I realized the ER was where I could actually help people. Not publish papers. Not collect accolades. Just keep someone alive who shouldn’t make it through the night.” She leaned forward with her forearms on her knees. “You think you’re nothing without your powers. I think you’re someone who’s been dying to save people who don’t even know your name. That’s not nothing. That’s everything.”

Ahdia looked at the vial in the tray instead of at her.

“What’s in the vial?”

“Hope.” Ruth picked it up. “I developed a treatment. CR-7 Temporal Variant. It should slow your degradation. Buy you time. Eighteen months, maybe two years.”

“Should?”

“I’ve never treated temporal stress before. But I’ve spent three years learning where this protocol bends. This is the same principle.” She drew the dose and held the syringe up to the light. “Different mechanism. Same art.”

“And if it doesn’t work?”

“Then you die faster.” Ruth found the port on the line and cleaned it. “But I’m not letting you die without trying. Someone should fight for you as hard as you fight for everyone else.”

“Why?”

“Because you’re worth saving.” She looked up from the port. “Not because you’re useful. Because you’re a person who deserves to live. Even if you don’t believe it yet.”

Ahdia had nothing to put against that. She tried for a while and found nothing.

“I don’t know how to be worth anything except this,” she said.

“Then I’ll teach you.” Ruth seated the syringe. “But first, let’s keep you alive long enough to learn.”

“How long?”

“Until it works or doesn’t.” The plunger went down slowly, in stages. Ruth watched the line and not the syringe. “We’ll know in a few hours. If your cellular markers improve, we continue treatments every three weeks. If they don’t . . .”

“Then I had weeks anyway.”

“Yeah.”

It went in cold. It came up her arm as cold and stayed cold across her shoulder. She waited for it to cross over into the pain the Seed always charged, and it did not. Somewhere under the collarbone the cold turned over and came back warm, and the warmth went out along the same roads, slowed down, and settled. The cold under the old bullet wound sat where it always sat, and it was not fixed, not healed, just less wrong.

She breathed in. The breath went further down than it had gone in weeks. “Thank you,” she said.

“Get some rest. I’ll be back to check on you in an hour.” Ruth latched the case and stood up with it.

She was three steps toward the door when Ahdia spoke.

“Ruth?”

Ruth stopped and waited.

“Don’t tell him,” Ahdia said. “Please. Not yet.”

Ruth nodded once and did not ask who. The door sealed behind her, and the room was down to its machines. Ahdia lay with her hands flat on the blanket. Above her the monitors went on with their numbers, which she could not read and did not try to, tracking something in her that was either turning around by now or not. In a few hours somebody would come and tell her which. She looked at the white ceiling and waited to find out.

Chapter 21

The first rule of losing your superpowers was that nobody talked about losing their superpowers.

They had been not-talking about it downstairs since the docks, so Tess came up here. The room over the Academy office held a mattress, a duffel, and nine energy-drink cans. She left the cans in frame. She squared the phone in the tripod. “Hey guys, it’s your girl, Gloomy. If you’re watching this, I’m either dead or I finally got the guts to post it, and I genuinely don’t know which is more terrifying.”

She sat on the mattress. Nobody was coming up. “It’s been one day since the docks. Since the tank cop almost killed us. Since Gale disappeared and our powers just . . . stopped working.” She let it sit two seconds and then ruined it. “Well, most of them.”

She stood and raised her middle finger at the lens, slowly, like a magician showing both sides of a coin, and aimed her eyes at the door frame. Nothing happened. It used to be instant. Then the room moved a step to the left and she was at the door with the tripod six feet away, her stomach arriving late. She held the jamb until the floor agreed to be a floor. Outside the window a drone hung at roof height with its lights off, as always, and it stayed there a while after she had stopped moving. “See? Mine still works. Knight thinks it’s because mine was always tech-based—FAERIS drones doing the actual teleporting. Which means maybe all of it was tech. Maybe we were never actually super. Just regular people with really expensive invisible support.”

She sat back down. “That’s what’s breaking everyone. Not that we lost our powers. That we maybe never had them to begin with.”

Watching people was the one skill she owned that predated the mask, and she turned it on her own team now, quickly and mercilessly. “Sable’s strength? Gone. He’s dealing with it by being pissed at literally everything. Battlea’s speed? Gone. She’s gone quiet, which is way worse than when she’s yelling. Knight’s jumps? Gone. He’s over-planning every detail because if he stops thinking he’ll have to start feeling and I think that might actually kill him.”

Then the one she had been circling. “And Gale . . . Gale sent one text saying she was clear and then went dark. Nothing since the docks. She won’t answer and we don’t know if she’s hurt or hiding or—” Her thumb found the stop button and did not press it. “Can’t think about that. Focus on what we can control.”

The list of things they could control had gotten very short. Firas had made one anyway. “Firas suggested we rescue Dr. Jericho. The artifact expert who got kidnapped from the museum. The guy who was researching the same artifacts that gave Kain his powers. The Tamois Heart. Turned him into whatever that thing at the docks was.” She pulled her knees up. “If anyone knows what’s happening to us, it’s Jericho. Problem is, Firas is downstairs right now bleeding through his bandages because he won’t admit his chest wound isn’t healed. He suggested the plan, worked out half of it, but he can barely walk. So it’s just us. Four people. Three without powers. Going after a billionaire with private security and whatever cosmic bullshit Kain’s got now.”

“Great plan, right? Super tactical. I’m sure nothing will go wrong.” The laugh she hung on the end of it did not survive the trip out. “If I don’t make it back . . . tell my dad I tried. Tell him I was doing something good even if I sucked at it. And tell him there’s a photo folded inside that picture frame on his desk. Maybe he should actually look at it sometime.”

She stopped. She wiped her face with the heel of her hand, once, hard. She did not say his name. She never did. Folded behind her school photo in that frame was another one, both her parents in it and a cake. She had put it there years ago. He had never mentioned it. “Team’s meeting downstairs in five. Time to find out if we’re brave or just idiots.” She reached for the phone. “Probably both.”

* * *

The camera came downstairs with her, because holding it gave her hands a job. Documentary mode. Nobody objected, which told her more than anything anybody said.

Firas had the laptop and a chair he was obviously pretending not to need. Victor sat on a plyo box, taking each item out of the bag and putting it back. Leah had the couch and her arms crossed. She had not spoken since breakfast, and Tess had read enough rooms to know precisely what that meant on Leah. It was not attitude. It was terror with absolutely nowhere to go.

“Okay,” Ben said, and turned the laptop around. A house assembled itself in gray, drone-mapped. “Kain’s hosting a gala event at his mansion tomorrow night. Wealthy donors, politicians, the usual corrupt assholes. Heavy security on the perimeter, but inside? Just catering staff and house staff.” He set three fingers on the schematic and moved them one by one. “Three entry points. Front door—obviously not happening. Service entrance here, kitchen access. And loading dock basement entrance here.”

Firas leaned in, and the lean cost him something across the ribs, and Tess watched him spend it silently. “We need someone inside distracting Kain,” he said, and he was already looking at the couch. “Someone who can pass as a wealthy donor. Someone who can keep him occupied while the rest of us search for Jericho.”

“No.”

“Leah—” Ben tried.

“I said no.”

“You’re the only one who can pull it off.” Victor delivered that to the gear bag, which was cowardice, and Tess filmed it anyway.

“Pull off what, exactly? Playing dress-up for a billionaire creep while you guys search his mansion? Hard pass.”

“We need you,” Firas said.

“You need me to put on a tight dress and smile while Kain ogles me for an hour. That’s what you need.”

Nobody rushed to fill that. It was accurate and everybody heard how accurate it was, and Firas took the weight of it and declined to set it down anywhere clever. “Yeah. That’s what we need.

And I hate asking. But Jericho might be our only shot at understanding what's happening to us. What happened to Gale. Why our powers are gone."

Leah studied the ceiling. "Fine," she said, and uncrossed her arms. "But I'm picking the dress. And if he touches me, I'm breaking his hand."

"Deal," Firas said.

* * *

She picked red.

"are you kidding me"

Tess had the phone up before Leah cleared the doorway. Floor-length, cut with a slit that was clearly a tactical decision, and Leah walked the mats in it like a fighter.

"I look like I'm auditioning for a spy movie."

"You look hot," Tess said.

"I look like bait."

"You look like hot bait."

"You know you can't post this if you shoot my face."

"That's what face blurring is for, duh."

Leah stopped at the mirrors and studied herself like a stranger's ID. "I hate this. I hate that this is the plan. Distract the creepy billionaire with my tits while you guys do the actual work."

"Hey." Tess lowered the phone, which she hardly ever did. "You're not just bait. You're getting us in. You're the reason we have access. That's not nothing."

"It's also not punching cops in the face, which is what I'd rather be doing."

"We can punch cops after we rescue Jericho."

Victor had come in with the zip ties and had forgotten what they were for. "Wow."

"Don't," Leah said, to the mirror.

"I'm just saying—"

"I know what you're saying. Don't."

"You look good. That's all I'm saying."

"I look like I'm about to seduce a Bond villain."

Victor considered it honestly. "Well," he said. "Technically you are."

Ben came through with a comms case, mouth already open. "We need to go over the comms plan—" He stopped. "Oh."

"Yeah," Victor agreed.

Leah turned from the mirror with her weight on one hip, and Tess got all of it, and would eventually cut two frames after the eyebrow. "Oh. Everyone get a good look? We done objectifying me?"

Firas was in the doorway by then, one shoulder on the frame, standing at a cost nobody would itemize. "You're not being objectified," he said. "You're being weaponized. There's a difference."

Leah breathed out slowly through her nose. "I hate that that makes me feel better."

“We work with what we have,” Firas said. “Right now what we have is Knight’s planning, Sable’s muscle, Gloom Girl’s teleportation, and your ability to make Kain forget we exist. That’s the play.”

“If this goes wrong and I die in this dress, I’m haunting all of you.”

“Noted,” Ben said.

“I may be fine with that,” Victor said, and took a shoe for it.

“Okay,” Firas said. He pushed off the frame and stood unsupported, because some sentences could not be delivered leaning. “Let’s rob a billionaire.” He gave them the call, as he had for four years. “No better place than here,” he said.

“No better time than now.”

It came back from all of them at once. Then Leah turned to the mirror and said the whole thing herself, both halves, to her own face.

“No better place than here. No better time than now.”

Tess kept filming after the rest of them turned away.

* * *

The parking structure east of the mansion was empty after nine. Tess had its northwest corner: three laptops on a milk crate, and a sightline to the mansion’s front elevation. Four feeds: Ben’s apron cam and Victor’s, both dark and jouncing; the house system, ninety dollars and one of Ben’s favors; and Leah’s clutch, a pinhole behind the clasp, showing a car ceiling.

Twenty minutes to showtime, and Tess did what she always did with them. The bodega clip was still running: a ceiling camera at Rodriguez’s Bodega on Morrison Street, a blur in the doorway, a man with a bat sitting down abruptly beside the chip rack. She read the comments like other people take vitamins. “These are the real police.” Under that, “Squad saved my cousin last week. We owe them.” Under that, “Why aren’t we funding these people?”

Somebody had cut a compilation, scored to strings. “Go Squad Saves Caledonia - 47 Confirmed Interventions This Month.”

@CaledoniaNights had the one that got her: Mr. Rodriguez holding out a paper cup, Battlea half turned away, caught taking it. “Stopped a robbery. Wouldn’t take payment. I gave her coffee anyway. #GoSquad #CaledoniaHeroes”

None of it was true this morning. Some of it, apparently, had never been true. The city loved them honestly for a power they could not use anymore and possibly had never owned. She was the one who would have to write that post.

The last was from @WestSideWatch. “Go Squad spotted entering vehicle near Academy. Think something’s happening tonight. Stay safe, Squad. We got your backs.”

The reply count under it read 47 and climbed like a fare meter. She screenshotted it to show Leah after, because Leah would need it after. On the clutch feed the hired car swung through the gates and stopped.

“You’re on,” Tess said. “Looking good, by the way.”

“Feeling like bait,” Leah said, barely moving her mouth.

“Hot bait.”

“Not helping.”

* * *

Two nights back Ben had laid it out on a table with a marker. “Battlea enters through the front as Sophie Clement, wealthy French donor. Sable and I go in through the service entrance as catering staff. Gloom Girl stays on the parking structure two blocks out, monitors comms and security feeds.” He tapped the basement. “We’re looking for Dr. Jericho. Artifact expert. Last seen at the museum before Kain’s people grabbed him.” Sophie Clement’s name on that list had cost a donation to Kain’s PAC, and Firas had signed it out of his sister’s estate.

“If he’s anywhere, he’s in the basement research level. That’s where Kain keeps his collection.” That was Firas, from the chair.

“What if he’s not there?” Tess had asked.

“Then we get whatever intel we can and extract. Hard drives, documents, anything that tells us what Kain’s doing with those artifacts.”

Now Victor’s apron cam swung through a service door held open by a man with a clipboard who never looked up, and two caterers walked into a billionaire’s house on two rented aprons and a stack of warming trays. “We’re in. That was . . . easier than expected.”

“Don’t say that,” Ben said. “You’ll jinx it.”

Tess had filmed the loadout while Ben walked the table. “Thermal goggles under the tablecloth. Smoke grenades in the champagne ice bucket. Data drives in the bread basket. Zip ties in the napkin dispenser. Everything hidden in plain sight.”

“We’ve done the catering staff thing before. Guards never look twice at waiters.” Victor had said that cracking knuckles, taking comfort where comfort was cheap.

The kitchen was four cooks and a sous chef screaming at a salamander, and nobody had time to be curious. On Ben’s feed the service stair went down past the wine room, and the light went industrial. The corridor was concrete and cold, with a door at the end of it like the front of a bank. “Vault should be at the end of this corridor,” Ben said.

Firas had put the cloner in his hand the night before, holding it like anything he built. “RFID cloner. Get close enough to any guard’s security badge, this’ll clone the signal. Should open most of the electronic locks including the basement vault.”

“Should?” Victor had asked.

“Ninety percent chance. If there’s biometric locks too, you’ll need to improvise.”

On the feed the cloner’s light went green, and the panel with it. The door did not move. “Shit,” Victor said. “It’s not working.”

“Biometric?” Ben was already on one knee at the panel.

Victor had the thermal goggles up. His feed washed out and came back in false color, and Tess leaned over the crate to see it: heat where heat had no business being, a long cold room, a shape in

the middle of it putting out warmth on a slow regular pulse. Nothing about the shape was a person. “Something’s in there,” Victor said. “Artifacts, maybe. But we can’t get in without an actual guard’s fingerprint or retinal scan or whatever.”

“So we improvise,” Ben said.

Victor held up both hands and looked at them. There was a whole day in it. “My powers are more, like, momentum based . . . ?”

Nobody laughed. Ben put his palm flat on the vault door, like you check a hood for heat. Whatever sat behind it was warm and there was a lot of it, spread out in rows, a collection on shelves, and none of it was moving. Cases, then. The intel had promised a research level and given them a warehouse instead, which meant the work had gone somewhere else and taken the man with it. “Yeah, this isn’t happening. We need to find another way. Let’s search the rest of the basement.”

They took eleven minutes on the rest. Storage, a wine cellar, empty offices with the chairs still wrapped. No cell. No cot. No Jericho. “He’s not down here,” Victor said.

“Then we go upstairs. Get what intel we can from his office.”

* * *

The clutch feed had been climbing the steps. Kain came down his own staircase in shirtsleeves, doing her the favor of being early. “Ms. Clement,” he said, and took her hand and kept it past any schedule Tess recognized. “Welcome. I’m sorry the place is in such a state. We weren’t expecting you for a few more hours.”

“I should have called ahead. But I was in the area and thought, why not?”

“Not at all, not at all.” He held on a beat longer than politely necessary. “It’s a pleasure anytime.”

Leah got her fingers back and turned toward the clasp. “He’s so gross.”

She had asked the practical question the night before. “So I just . . . keep him occupied? Talk about rich people stuff?”

“Art,” Firas had said. “He collects it. Especially ancient artifacts. Egyptian, Greek, Amazigh. If you mention you’re interested in antiquities, he’ll talk your ear off. Guy loves showing off his collection.”

“Great. I know nothing about art.”

“You know it when you see it, right?” Tess had offered, which felt helpful for a second.

“That’s porn.”

The clutch came out onto the west lawn, past caterers laying a hundred and forty covers, and stopped at nine feet of bronze Harding Kain gazing nobly at nothing. “It’s . . . magnificent,” Leah said, in an accent that was holding.

“I know,” Kain said, as other men say the time. “It’s nothing, really. You should see my place in the south of Marseille. Ever been?”

Ben's whisper came flat and fast from a linen closet downstairs. "He's fishing. That's in Sophie Clement's cover story. He might've read up on her."

"Often," Leah said. "But I prefer to stay in Paris, where I can keep a close eye on my business."

"A woman who understands priorities. I like that." He put a hand on the small of her back, and the frame jumped where her arm went tight and then loose. "Come. Let me show you my office. I have something that might interest a woman of your . . . refined tastes."

"Wait, that worked? He's taking you to the office?"

"Lead the way," Leah said.

"Second floor office," Tess relayed, hands flat on the crate.

The office ran the whole west end of the house, and the window ran the office. On the far wall hung a painting of a monument Tess did not recognize, with a long bright tear opened in the sky above it. "What a view you must have."

"To see the sunset," Kain said. "Very nice choice, isn't it?"

Ben came onto the net. "We're coming up. Stall him."

A man sat at a workstation in the corner with three monitors and a cold coffee, older, thin, wearing a cardigan in a house kept at seventy-two degrees. "Dr. Jericho, take a break. We have a guest."

"But the resonance calibration—"

"Can wait," Kain said, and nothing in his delivery moved, and that was how you knew. "Give us the room."

"The temporal stability is still fluctuating. If I leave now—"

"Ten minutes," Kain said. He gave the second half to Leah, smiling, sharing it like a joke about staff. "Then you can get back to making me a god."

Jericho went. The door closed. Nine seconds later Tess heard a soft double thud in her right ear, hardly louder than a book landing, then Ben breathing hard, and she let out air she had been holding since the gates.

"So," Kain said, crossing to a glass chamber alone on a plinth. "You mentioned an interest in antiquities?"

"I did," Leah said. The chamber lit as he neared it, and Tess's screen bloomed white and then found its level, and even through a pinhole two blocks out it was hard to look at. Red, then gold, then red, on a rhythm slower than a heartbeat and considerably more patient. "This . . . what is that?"

"The Tamois Heart," Kain said. He set one ringed knuckle on the glass above it, fondly, like a man tapping a fish tank. "The Amazigh worshipped it as divine. A gift from gods. But it's technology. Dr. Jericho has been researching its properties. Learning how to replicate it. Scale it. Imagine—power like this, mass-produced. Distributed to whoever I choose."

Tess wrote the word on her hand. Replicate. He did not want to be the one who had it. He wanted to be the supplier, and he said so out loud to a woman he had known eleven minutes.

Leah moved. “Sorry about this.”

“What—”

The clutch went sideways and showed carpet, then wall, then Kain’s face at an angle no photographer had been allowed. She had his wrist behind his shoulder blade and her knee in his back. She got him down unhurriedly. She broke nothing, and Tess watched her decide not to.

The door opened on Ben and Victor in catering whites, and Ben went past Kain to the workstation. “Holy shit. This is it. The artifact from the museum. And all his research.” Drives came out of the bread basket, three of them, and the monitors filled with directory trees. “Resonance patterns, cellular integration protocols, temporal manipulation theories . . .”

Victor had stopped a yard short of the plinth, hand half raised. “That thing’s . . . it’s doing something. I can feel it.”

“Don’t touch it,” Ben said, without turning around.

Kain worked his cheek off the carpet. “Who are you people?”

“Concerned citizens,” Victor told him, kneeling to run the zip ties. “And we’re taking Jericho and all this research.”

“You have no idea who you’re robbing—”

“TRIOMF executive, presidential candidate, corrupt billionaire experimenting with cosmic artifacts,” Leah said, from above him.

Victor pulled the last tie tight. “Yeah, we know.”

Ben read the summary with his thumb on the eject. “Got it. Research files, ledgers, everything. Including proof the police chief is on your payroll.”

Tess had already switched screens. The house system carried twelve cameras and eight went busy at once. Stairwells. The service corridor. Two men crossing the lawn past the bronze at a jog, four more moving steadily behind them.

“We need to get Jericho and go,” Victor said.

“Wait—I’m seeing security mobilizing. Multiple guards heading to the second floor. Did someone—”

On the clutch feed Kain’s shoe lay flat against the leg of the plinth, on a plate the size of a light switch. His heel was still on it. “Shit,” Ben said.

Leah saw it too. “He called security.”

“How many?” Victor asked.

Tess did not believe the shapes on her feed. She looked again. They were still there. “All of them,” she said. “You need to get out NOW.”

Both office doors opened at once. Ben’s camera swung and filled with men. Twelve weapons at minimum, more along the corridor behind them, one at a balcony window the office was not supposed to have. Nobody in that room had powers. Tess sat on the parking structure two blocks away with four feeds and no way in, and watched every screen stop moving.

Chapter 22

The order reached her twice, thin on Ben’s apron cam and a half second late on the house system, and Tess heard both from two blocks east.

“Open fire!”

Twelve weapons at the near door, more in the corridor behind it, one man at the balcony window the office was not supposed to have. The west wall was mostly glass, and past it lay thirty feet of nothing, then gravel, then the fountain at the bottom of the drive. Between the bookcases on the long wall stood the plinth, and the thing from the vault sat lit inside its case on top of it, doing what it had done all night.

Leah reached the same conclusion first and solved it sideways. She got behind the wheeled chair and ran it out into the middle of the floor, and Harding Kain went with it, wrists zip-tied and turning slowly under his own chandelier, a nine-figure obstruction nobody had authorization to shoot through. The first volley went high, and the ceiling came down across the feed like snow.

Whoever hung the cameras in that office had hung them for a man who enjoyed being looked at. Twelve angles and every one of them pointed inward. He sat at the center of all of them now, revolving at whatever speed the casters gave him, and the room would come past him a piece at a time whether he wanted it or not.

“Gloom Girl,” Ben said from behind the desk, which was oak and the only honest cover in the room. “We’re pinned. Need an exit.”

She had one and it was bad. Four trips minimum, one body each, every arrival slower than the last, and the room still full of men when she came back for the last. Jericho lay out cold on a linen shelf. On her third laptop the copy bar sat at thirty seconds and declined to hurry.

“Copy’s not done,” she said, and her thumb pressed into the corner of the crate hard enough to leave a mark. “Hold them off.”

Victor tipped the champagne bucket. Goggles came out from under the catering linen. A dozen men lost the room in one breath, and only three did not.

Leah’s heels came off first, and they came off as ordnance. She got a hand down and took one by the strap on the way, put it through the eyebrow of the man nearest the door, and sent the second after him into the smoke without waiting to watch it land. She fought the rest of the night barefoot in the gown. She had told them the slit was a tactical decision and nobody at the table had believed her, and Tess was going to owe her about that for a long time.

Battlea took the chair apart and kept two armrests. The second one went back over her shoulder without a glance, into a hand that was already open for it. That was the part Tess would think about afterward. The hand had been open before the armrest got there.

After that the smoke gave Tess nothing to see by, and she read the fight like you read a storm from indoors: a rifle going up and away, a shoulder finding a sternum, men walking into furniture they could not see and into people they could see considerably less.

The audio carried better than the picture. She put the house feed in her good ear and listened to a dozen professionals lose an argument with a room. Chairs went over. Somebody called a corner and somebody on the far side of it called the same corner back. A man walked into a bookcase and said sorry to it. Under all of that the team made no sound whatsoever, and that was the trick, and it had cost four years of somebody standing at the mats saying do it again, softer. In a room full of smoke the guards were the only thing generating noise, and the noise told Ben and Victor where each of them was standing.

Ben came out from behind the desk and set his feet, and put his left forearm out flat at hip height, and held it there like a rail he expected somebody to use. Leah used it. She came at him out of the gray with her hand already reaching, took the forearm at a dead run, and he turned his hips into her and let go. She crossed that office in one continuous piece of movement, at a speed her own legs could not have produced. Tess had watched her do it on a flat track with a helmet on and a whistle going. She had never once seen it done in a gown.

The man at the far end took a bare heel in the sternum and the wall behind him did the rest.

Ben worked the room from the door end and Victor from the window end, and they met in the middle and stayed there, back to back, turning like one slow animal. There was nothing improvised about it. They had a name for that shape and had walked it on tape and drilled it in a gym with no smoke in it, and in the smoke it looked no different.

She should have felt better than she did. They were holding. They were holding without her and without Gale and without whatever it was that had been doing this for them since the docks, and they were good, and it turned out that had its own cold under it. On the third laptop the bar moved a little and remained in no hurry.

She kept the center camera up the whole time, because he was the center of it. He was not frightened. He sat in his chair inside his own smoke with his chin up, following the noise around the room, and his face did what her father’s face did at a car dealership. He thought he was watching equipment. Somebody had sold these people something, and he would find out who, and then he would buy two.

Smoke buys a minute. It had never bought more than that, and every person in that office who had planned anything had planned for the end of it.

The man at the balcony window had spent that minute finding a firing position and had found one. Ben ran three steps up the paneling and came off it sideways, and a guard went through the west glass and stayed audible longer than she wanted.

The hole he left was four feet wide. Smoke poured out of the office and up the face of the house, and on her screens the room resolved into furniture and a dozen men getting their eyes back. Their advantage had been the weather. They had just broken the window it lived behind.

And they kept winning.

That was the thing Tess could not find a shelf for. They were in the clear now, in a lit room, against men who could see them and had rifles and expensive training. Three people with two chair arms between them went on taking the office apart at the same rate.

Victor made a step out of his hands and Leah went up it to the top of the bookcase. She came off the bookcase into two men who were still looking at the floor where she had been. Ben threw a guard, and the throw was not an attack, it was delivery; Victor caught him at the far end and set him down. Leah got a knee onto Ben's shoulder and Ben stood up under her. She went over the desk from six feet in the air with the second armrest already swinging.

The room worked with them. Leah pulled a drape down over a man's head and left him wearing his own window. Victor took an armrest to a knee, then to a wrist, then laid the man out on the carpet with something close to courtesy. Ben got a shoulder into a bookcase and let it settle the argument for the two men sheltering behind it. Somebody went hard into the plinth. The case on top jumped on its base and came down starred across one corner. The plinth stayed upright, and Tess clocked it and lost it inside a second.

None of it ran in a straight line. Ben's shoulder opened a lane and Leah was inside the lane before it finished existing. Leah crossing pulled two men off Victor. He spent the seconds that bought him stripping a rifle off a third and putting it out through the hole in the west wall. Every weapon that came loose went the same way. Nobody on any of her screens held one longer than it took to throw it.

By then the men still standing had stopped closing. They had drifted to the walls with their backs against the paneling, and a couple of them were not aiming at anything any more.

Firas built this. He built it in a gym with sour mats and a whiteboard nobody could read, and tonight the whole of it was working at full size, on the one night he could not get up the stairs. Tess sat on a crate two blocks east with her hands shaking and was proud of them in a way that was difficult to hold.

On the center camera, Harding Kain stopped moving his head.

He had tracked all of it until then, chin swinging with the noise, a man at a demonstration keeping up. Now he sat still while the room went past him, and he was looking at one place, and the place was not the fight. It was the plinth between the bookcases with the light going in its case.

He looked at it for a long while. Tess read that as a rich man taking inventory in the middle of a burglary, and went back to the copy bar, which said eleven seconds.

"Battlea! Incoming!" Victor called it from the far end, and the fresh ones came through both doors clear-eyed, taking their time about the angles.

A guard put his forehead into Victor's face. Victor went down on one knee in the open. Leah got an arm around the nearest man's throat and his rifle neatly into her free hand, and walked him to the wall, which bought ten seconds and cost her both hands.

"Gale?"

Nothing came back. Gale had been dark since the docks and everyone in that office knew it, and Leah asked anyway, because four years of asking does not switch off in a day.

Ben swept the roofline through the broken glass and found gutter and chimney and cold slate. Then he remembered. Nobody had known where she was since the water.

“Little help?” Leah’s hostage was working his chin down toward her forearm and getting somewhere with it.

Ben went under a man with a knife. The knife came up. Victor stood cornered against the plinth with a dozen barrels finding him, and there was nothing left to try. He put his hands out where they could be seen and came off the plinth into the open, three steps, because that was the only thing left that the barrels wanted.

Out on the carpet one of the new men got around at last to the obvious service. He got a knife under the ties at the back of the chair and sawed, with his eyes on the fight the whole time. It took him a moment. He went back to the line without once having looked at the man’s face. Kain did not get up. He put his freed hands flat on his knees and went on looking at the plinth.

Then the lights died.

All of them at once, the house and the lawn and the floods around the fountain, and the moon over the roofline seemed to dim with them out of politeness. One second of total dark.

She had left the crate two minutes before that. The first jump was the long one, structure roof to the boxwood on the west lawn, and it went as everything had gone since the docks: the finger up, the eyes set, a pause where no pause used to live, then the world stepping a foot to the left without her. She came down badly in the hedge with her stomach still two blocks east. The kitchen door took the second and the service stair took the third. The fourth put her at the wire-glass window of the electrical room, the fifth put her inside it, and she pulled every breaker in the box by feel.

The sixth took her to the linen shelf. The seventh took her and Jericho three blocks east to a loading dock. She left him on his side with his glasses folded into his shirt, and came off that dock tasting pennies. The eighth put her in the office, eight feet up, on the crown molding.

She crouched there with the goggles on while the second ran out. Below her the room lay open in green and gray, and she read it like a wall: the knife nine feet down and two feet left, the desk, the chandelier chain, the whole room a route instead of a fight. She had spent four years going around things, and from up here going around was the answer.

There were two things down there and one second to spend on them. The knife was the near one. The other was past the desk, where a man who had sat in a chair all night was on his hands and knees at the plinth with his face turned up into the light.

She picked Ben.

She came off the molding onto the man with the knife and put him into the carpet with her whole weight, and the ninth had Ben out from under him and across the room before his hands understood they were empty. The chandelier she did not strictly need, and took anyway. It hung there and swung where she wanted, and the tenth dropped her off it onto the two men under the doorway, who went down without ever seeing what arrived. Then Battlea, off the wall and onto the desk, her hostage left blinking. Eleven.

The emergency circuit came up yellow and half-hearted. The chair by the desk lay on its side and empty, the ties cut through, and on the plinth the light had changed color while she was not

watching it.

"Jericho?" Ben asked, on his feet with his back to the window.

"Got him," Tess said. "Data drive?"

"Downloaded." He had it closed in his fist.

"Then we're leaving."

"Hands up!" The near door had re-formed into a dozen men with weapons leveled.

There were two ways out of that office. One of them ran through those guns. The other was a four-foot hole in the west glass with thirty feet of cold night under it and a fountain still running this late in the year. She took Ben's collar in one hand and Leah's in the other.

"Now!"

They went through together and the night took them. Fifteen feet down she left them and came back up through the glass for Victor, who had stopped at the frame with the drop in front of him, doing the honest math of a man with nothing left in his hands.

"Trust me," she said, and took his sleeve, and jumped them both off the sill.

After that it was only parkour, which is the art of refusing the straight line down. She did not stop the fall, because nobody stops a fall. She bent it. Two jumps put the four of them sideways across the drive, the next took the worst of the speed off the angle, the last dropped them into three feet of green water at a slant, and the fountain did what water does with anything handed to it at a slant.

She surfaced last, ears ringing, mouth full of pennies, hands not willing. Victor got her over the rim.

* * *

The alley ran three blocks east, and they reached it at a limp, soaking, in the first cold snap of the year. It had arrived that week and meant it.

"What the hell just happened?" Victor asked the alley generally.

"Gloom Girl happened," Ben said.

"That was insane," Victor said, and sat down heavily on somebody's milk crate.

"That was fun," Tess said.

Leah wrung a pint of fountain out of the ruined red dress and laughed.

Firas came into the alley mouth on foot, slower than she had ever seen him move, like a man carrying something breakable. One flat hand stayed pressed over his ribs the whole way. He had walked it. Walking was the only way any of them ever went.

"Everyone alive?"

"Mostly," Ben said.

"Jericho?"

"At the extraction point," Tess said. She got the words out in the right order, privately proud of it. "Unconscious but breathing. Got all his research too."

The back door of the row house opened, and a woman in her sixties came out into the wet in a bathrobe and slippers, arms folded tightly.

“Go Squad?”

Nobody answered her. In four years nobody had ever had to.

“I knew it. I told my daughter you operated in this neighborhood.” She got a phone out of the bathrobe pocket. “Can I get a picture? She won’t believe me otherwise.”

“Ma’am, we really need to—”

“Please? Just one? You saved my nephew last month. The thing with the guys and the—” Her hand made a small circle in the air that finished the sentence for her. “You know.”

Leah crossed the alley in the wrecked dress, stood next to the woman, and put her head close while the phone came up unsteadily and did what phones do.

“Thank you,” she said, and gave the rest of it to all five of them. “For everything you do. We see you. All of us. We see you.”

Then she went back in. The screen door shut, and the latch eventually caught on the second try.

“That was weird,” Victor said.

“That was nice,” Tess said.

“Then let’s get out of here before—”

The light came up behind them, red and gold, across the whole east face of the house. Tess felt it in her back teeth and in the marrow of both shins, and she knew it, because it was hers. Space folding, run backward: an arrival with no leaving in front of it.

“What—”

Harding Kain came out through the front wall of his own house at a walk. The stone stayed stone and he came through it regardless, without a door and without a hole. Tess knew what she was looking at. That was space folded and let go, the same trick her own body did, done to a building by a thing sold to her as a clock. The Heart sat sunk in the middle of his chest, red, then gold, then red, patient about it. His eyes flickered rapidly between one state and another. He looked up at the sky for a while, unhurried, a man checking the weather before a drive. Then he turned his head three blocks east and found them in the dark, and smiled, and walked off through the side of an apartment building.

“We need to call someone,” Ben said.

“Who?” Leah asked.

“The cops? The cops who work for him?” Tess had her phone out already, holding it in both wet hands with absolutely nowhere to send it.

It rang. Unknown number.

“Hello?”

“No better place than here,” Ruth said in her ear.

Four years she had answered that call in a gym and on a rooftop and once with her mouth full, and it had never made her want to sit on the ground. Gloom Girl was a name she had picked at

nineteen to be funny about the worst thing in her life. Standing in an alley in wet armor with her hands shaking, she decided she wanted a different one.

Ruth did not wait for the response.

“I saw what just happened. Get somewhere safe. I’m sending help.”

The line went. Then the air developed an edge it had not had, and something the size of a bus stopped being invisible forty feet up, and the engine pitch her ribs had been reading arrived at her ears. A ramp came down. Ruth stood at the top of it in full tactical gear, matte black and armored, none of which anybody had seen her wear.

“Need a ride?”

Chapter 23

The ramp came up and took the alley. Firas did not board. He had walked three blocks on a shotgunned torso and would be useless in the air, so he took the drives from Ben's fist and turned east toward the dock. He looked up once while the ramp closed and she made herself hold it. He asked nothing, which was worse than the four questions coming up the aisle behind her. The hold smelled of ozone and webbing. They came up dripping, Leah barefoot in the wreck of the red dress, Tess tasting pennies and not saying so, Victor holding his ribs like Firas held his. Four years of running on her callouts, and now they waited in a transport to be told what she was. "Sit," she said. "We need to move fast."

They sat. Victor took the bench nearest the door, the seat you choose when you think you may need it. "Okay," he said. "What the hell is happening?"

"Long version or short version?"

"Medium version," Ben said. "With explanations."

"You know how your powers stopped working after the docks?"

"Yeah," Leah said.

"They were never yours to begin with." Nobody moved for a second and a half.

"Explain," Victor said.

"You've been enhanced. Temporal manipulation distributed through drone networks. Someone with actual powers was amplifying you. Making you faster, stronger, more accurate. You thought it was you. It wasn't."

Ben's color went. She had watched that drain a hundred times in an ER, where it meant blood leaving the face for somewhere it was needed more. He was recalculating four years of tactics built on a lie, every plan in which a man could clear thirty feet. "The whole time?" he said.

"Every fight. Every mission. You were being helped."

"By who?" Tess said.

The sentence had no pronoun in it. She had built it that way, out loud, alone, twice. "By someone dying to keep you safe," she said. "Someone who thought giving you powers was worth their life."

"That's not an answer," Victor said.

"It's the answer you're getting." She did not soften it. "What matters is the enhancement stopped because the person providing it nearly died. They're in treatment now. Recovering. And once they're stable, the drones will resume operations."

Tess's head came up on the last word. "Drones," she said.

"FAERIS." The question reached Tess's face and stopped. "Yes."

"I thought those were just surveillance."

"They were that too."

"Who are you people?" Ben asked.

“CADENS. Cataclysm Activity Detection and Engagement Network Sentry. Shadow government organization. International black budget funding. We monitor and respond to cosmic-level threats that normal governments can’t handle.”

“Like Kain,” Victor said.

“Like Kain. Like the artifacts. Like the things that left them here.” She put the mansion feed up on the bulkhead. “He used the Tamois Heart. Integrated it. He’s transforming into something else. Getting bigger. Stronger. If we don’t stop him in the next few hours, he’ll either die or become something worse.”

“What’s worse?” Leah asked.

“Fully transformed. Unstoppable. The kind of thing that takes armies to bring down.” She heard Tess laugh, badly. “A monster with a grudge.”

The comms panel opened and a woman read coordinates through it. “HAZARD to command. Target is mobile. Heading northeast through the city. Moving fast. Smashing through buildings, vehicles, everything. Trail of destruction.”

The map replaced the feed. Caledonia in gray, the twin rivers paler, a red thread stitching itself northeast a block at a time and slowing nowhere. “Where’s he going?” Ben asked.

“Nowhere. Everywhere.” She let them look. “He’s razing Caledonia. Block by block.”

“So we slow him down,” Victor said.

“If we can.” Ben pushed. “Who?”

The honest answer was a name and she did not give it, and the withholding cost what she expected. “First, we need intel. Jericho knows how the Heart works. How Kain’s abilities function. What his limitations are.” She turned toward the cockpit. “Set down at the extraction point. We’re picking up our prisoner.”

* * *

Firas had gotten him upright and put a jacket on him, because Firas is constitutionally unable to leave anybody on cold concrete. Ruth came down the ramp in gear he had never seen her own, did not look at him longer than she could afford, and that was the second thing she spent that hour. Jericho sat against the wall zip-tied, awake now, glasses on, terrified. She crouched to his level automatically, as she had ten thousand times. In the ER that was a kindness. In armor it read as something else, and she let it. “Dr. Jericho,” she said. “We need to talk.”

“I don’t know who you are,” he said. “But I’m not—I didn’t—Kain made me—”

“Save it.” His file had taken her four minutes at eleven thousand feet, and that was generous. “Resonance calibration. Cellular integration protocols. Temporal manipulation theories. You’ve been helping him weaponize the Heart for six weeks.”

“He kidnapped me from the museum!”

“And then you kept working. Enthusiastically.” His mouth opened and produced nothing. “You wanted to understand it. Crack the code. Publish the breakthrough of the century.” She had been awake past thirty hours. Under a government office building a person lay in a bed with a

needle taped into their arm, and that had burned off what she kept in reserve for frightened men. “Here’s what’s going to happen,” she said. “You’re going to tell us everything. How the Heart works. How to stop the integration. How to prevent this from happening again. And then you’re going into protective custody until we clean up this mess.”

“And if I don’t?”

“Then Kain wakes up. And the first person he’s going to blame for his transformation is the scientist who told him it would make him a god.”

He took less time over it than she had allowed. “Protective custody sounds great,” he said. She stood, and her knees reported in. She was not proud of how efficiently that had worked, and she noticed she was not, and put the noticing away with everything else.

* * *

They flew north with him strapped in across from her team, and he was better at this than she wanted. “The Heart isn’t technology,” he said. “It’s organic. A seed from something vast. It integrates with biological systems, enhances them. Kain thought he was gaining power. Really he was being consumed.”

“Can it be reversed?” Ruth asked.

“No. Once integration begins, it’s irreversible. The Heart is rewriting his biology.” He turned the tablet around. “Massive muscle growth. Bone density increasing exponentially. He’s becoming huge. Strong. Durable.”

“So he’s just . . . big and strong?” Leah said.

“Exactly. Like the enhanced officers you’ve fought before, but scaled up. Fifteen feet tall, maybe more. Strong enough to tear through concrete. Durable enough that conventional weapons barely scratch him.” He scrolled, and the next frame was worse. “But there’s a problem. The integration is accelerating. His body is rejecting the transformation even as it’s completing. He’s dying. Fast.”

“How fast?” Ruth asked.

“Hours. Maybe twelve at most. The cellular stress is catastrophic. Eventually his biological mass will fail and the Heart will consume what’s left.” She knew the shape of that disease. She had lab notes on it and a pale blue vial four hundred feet underground, and kept that off her face.

“So he dies anyway,” Victor said.

“Or completes the transformation first.” Jericho pushed his glasses up with a bound wrist. “Becomes fully integrated. Permanently enhanced. A twenty-foot monster that won’t stop.”

“What are the odds he completes before he dies?” Ben asked.

“Based on his current acceleration? Sixty percent. Maybe higher if he continues using his abilities.”

“So we have to stop him before he completes,” Ben said. “How?”

“You can’t,” Jericho said. “He’s fifteen feet tall and growing. Stronger than anything you’ve faced. More durable. There’s no conventional weapon that works on something that size.”

“Then what do we use?” Victor asked.

“Another Temporalist. Someone who can manipulate time. Slow him down. Freeze him. Create windows where he’s vulnerable.”

Ben got there in one step and did not need the pause the others took.

“The person who’s been enhancing us.”

“They’re recovering,” Ruth said. “Not cleared for field operations.”

“But they could do it?” Ben said. “Stop Kain?”

“Theoretically.” The word tasted like a coin. “At significant cost.”

Victor stood up in a moving aircraft, which nobody is supposed to do. “The person enhancing you,” he said. “They’re at your facility. Recovering. And now you’re asking them to fight a temporal god.” Every one of those sentences was correct. That was the trouble with Victor. “Who are they?”

“Someone who’s been protecting you since the beginning. Someone who thinks you’re worth dying for. That’s all you need to know.”

“That’s not enough,” Victor said.

“It’s going to have to be.”

“This is insane. This whole time, someone’s been watching us. Helping us. Like a ghost.” Tess had both hands flat on her knees. “And we don’t even get to know their name?” Ruth let the engine noise stand in for an answer, a thing she had learned to do lately.

“That doesn’t help,” Victor said. He came up the aisle and stopped nearer than she would have permitted anyone else. “You know them.”

“Yes.”

“And you’re not telling us because they asked you not to.”

“Yes.”

“Even though we have a right to know.”

She said nothing at all. It was the worst answer available and the only honest one, and she let it sit in front of four people who had gone into gunfire on her word for four years while she sat dark in a bunker and watched.

Leah had been silent a long time, still barefoot. “How long?”

“How long what?”

“How long do they have? If they fight Kain.” Ruth looked at the deck plates, and Leah did not let her have it. “How long, Ruth?”

“Weeks. Maybe less.” The hold went completely quiet under the engine note, and the red thread added another block.

“Then we need another option,” Ben said. “We can’t ask someone to die for us.”

“It’s not your choice,” Ruth said. “It’s theirs.”

The panel opened again before anybody could take it apart. “Command, target is downtown. Main Street. He’s destroying everything.”

“Then what do we do?” Tess asked.

The deck tilted and settled, the landing lights came up green, and Ruth was already unbuckling. “Wait here.”

* * *

Bourn was on the pad, hands behind her back, her suit unwrinkled at an hour when nobody’s should be. “Ryu says she’s awake,” she said. “Asking what happened. Saw the feeds from the mansion.”

“Does she know about Kain?”

“She knows.” Bourn’s delivery did not change. “And she’s already asking when she can deploy.”

Both sentences had come off a status line hours old. Ruth heard the timestamp under it. Awake was an event and not a condition; the girl had surfaced, asked for the one thing that would kill her, and gone back down without keeping any of it. “How long does she have if she fights?”

“Ryu estimates days. Maybe a week if we’re lucky. The temporal strain of freezing something that size, that strong . . .” Bourn let that hang. “It’ll accelerate everything.”

Ruth looked back at the ramp, where four wet people sat in the dark. “Bring them to the briefing room,” she said. “They deserve better than sitting in a transport.”

“And you?”

“Give me ten minutes,” Ruth said. “Then I’ll join you.” Bourn let it go. Ruth took the left-hand corridor, and the ten minutes went where they went.

* * *

The briefing room ran two floors and a wall of live feeds, thirty-one crises on four continents, and a gallery of consoles staffed by people who hardly looked up. Tess turned slowly in place with her arms out from her sides. Ben found the meta-human tracking board and read it standing. “This is insane,” Tess said. “They’ve been monitoring meta-humans worldwide. Hundreds of them.”

Victor had found the personnel wall, and on it a file with his own face and legal name. Leah sat in a chair that adjusted itself under her. “They know everything about us.” She made a small approving noise and adjusted it slightly further. “I could get used to this.”

Four cases came in on a cart and opened flat. Matte black armor cut to measurements nobody had ever given anybody; a collapsible staff; a grapple spool; a belt of smoke and flash; a pair of boots with the derby laces already run through them by somebody who had noticed. Bourn let them look. “You’ve seen what we do. You know what’s at stake.”

“And you want us to join,” Ben said.

“I’m offering.” She did not oversell it. “You’re free to walk away.”

“Just like that?”

“Just like that. What you’ve seen here stays here.”

“Can we think about it?” Ben asked.

“Of course.”

Victor closed the lid of his case with one finger. “Hell of a sales pitch,” he said. “What—”

The room’s light went amber. The gallery came alive, twenty voices layering into one, and a technician spoke evenly over them. “Director Bourn, we have a situation. Downtown Caledonia. Multiple cosmic-level threat signatures.”

The main wall took the feed. Kain stood twenty feet in the middle of Main Street, still growing while they watched, skin gone translucent, the Heart burning red and gold under it like a coal in a paper bag. Behind him came four men in torn CCPD uniforms, seven feet each, unhurried. A bus lay on its side across two lanes. The camera was mounted high on a bank and did not look away, and Ruth watched three of them not make it. “Jesus Christ,” Ben said.

“Response authorization required,” the technician said. “Waiting on clearance from—”

“Override that,” Mack said. “Deploy all available units. NOW.”

“Sir, protocol requires—”

“I said NOW!”

Seven minutes to muster. Eleven to the site. Ruth did that math, and so did the four people beside her, who had spent four years arriving in ninety seconds because nobody ever asked them for clearance. They looked at each other. Ben to Victor, Victor to Leah, Leah to Tess, Tess back to Ben, and no one said one word about it. Ben picked his case up off the cart without hurrying about it. “We’re not waiting.”

“The suits aren’t calibrated—” a technician said.

Tess already had her belt in one hand and was not looking at anybody about it. “Don’t care.”

“You can’t,” Bourn said. “Without powers, you’re—”

“We’ve been without powers before,” Ben said. He had the armor out of the case already. “We’ll manage.”

“This isn’t street gangs,” Bourn said. “This is—”

“Our city,” Victor said. “Our people. Our fight.”

“You’re making a mistake. You’ll die out there.”

“Probably,” Tess said. “But at least we’ll die doing something. Not waiting for authorization.” They took the cases and went, and their footfalls got smaller very quickly down the corridor.

“Dr. Carter—”

“I’m going with them.”

Bourn’s chin came up. She looked at the corridor, then at Ruth, and said the name low, sure it would work. “Ahdia—”

“Ryu can handle it.”

Then Ruth was gone too, and Director Harriet Bourn stood alone in her briefing room, thirty-one crises on the wall behind her and one in front, watching five people with no powers between them run at a twenty-foot god because nobody else would go without a signature.

Chapter 24

The rain was going up.

She stood on a street she half knew, and the rain rose off the pavement in long silver threads and climbed back into the sky. A pigeon crossed the intersection tail-first, wings folding neatly where they should have spread. On the corner a man's coffee jumped out of the air and poured itself back into his paper cup, and he lowered it unsipped and walked briskly away in reverse.

She reached for the Seed and nothing answered, the reach coming back empty, like knocking at a house you had already moved out of. Then the cold in her chest moved. It was not a voice and it did not use words, but it had a direction and it leaned.

The feeling said: Wrong direction.

The whole street ran backward, a tape rewound by somebody with nowhere to be, and under her hoodie the blue light pulsed in time with her heart, and every pulse took the world back another second. The pulse was hers, her light and her heartbeat, running without permission asked.

You only ever pull. Slow. Stop. Backward. What if you pushed?

She tried to stop the street instead. She grabbed for the rain and the pigeon and the man with his coffee, held the whole rewinding block the only way she knew how, and for a moment everything hung obediently still. Then the moment ended because moments do, and the street went on running backward through her hands. The feeling: You can't freeze moments. Only delay them.

The pavement quit pretending to hold her, and she fell. She fell through stacked moments, frozen flat like photographs in a box: the warehouse caught mid-blast with its fire solid and orange, Gloom Girl hung above the bridge with her arms wide, the ambush with its bullets parked in the air, patient as pins. Every one of them was hers, and every one of them had waited, and none had ever stopped waiting.

She landed in a hallway. Blue doors ran down the left wall, red doors down the right, and the hallway went out of sight both ways. She understood, as you understand rules in dreams, that she had only ever opened blue.

One blue door stood open on Montana. Pine, woodsmoke, the campground, herself at eight years old on a log with a stick she was too proud of. The girl looked up without surprise.

"You've been stuck here. We all have."

The fire popped and its sparks went up slowly and stayed up.

"You keep looking back. What if you looked forward instead?"

"I'm scared," Ahdia said.

"Good. That means you're moving."

Behind her, on the right-hand wall, a red door had swung open. Warm air came through it, and light, and a low sound that could have been traffic or blood or applause. Everything she had spent years arranging her life to avoid was on the other side of that door, and all of it was alive and none of it was safe.

Something came down the hallway then. It was too big for the hallway, and the hallway held it anyway. It moved slowly and it was old and it was curious. It was not hostile and it was not kind. It looked at her like she had looked at the photographs, and then it passed and every door shivered in its frame.

She put her hand out for the red door and everything cracked: red light poured through the seams, hot and forward and fast, and she was spread across every possible moment at once, and all of them were moving, every one, forward.

Another voice answered from nowhere near the warmth, cold and final, and it did not belong to the Seed.

“Wake up.”

* * *

She came off the bed gasping. White ceiling, monitors, a room loudly disagreeing with itself. The IV was out of her arm and she had no memory of tearing it.

“Hey, hey—” Ryu was there, glasses crooked, wearing a week without sleep. “You’re okay. You’re—”

She swung her legs off the bed anyway.

“Whoa, easy.” His hands hovered uselessly and landed nowhere. “You’ve been out for twenty-six hours.”

“What happened?”

“You passed out. Ruth said—” He caught himself on the name. “You were in pretty bad shape when they brought you in.”

“Where’s Ruth?”

He looked at the door before he looked at her. The look took too long and he knew it, and knowing it made it longer.

“Where’s Ruth?”

“She left. With the others.”

“Left where?”

He did not answer. The wall monitor behind him had been answering the whole time, and she saw it now. Downtown, from a rooftop feed: smoke, sirens crawling faintly between the buildings, and in the middle of Main Street a shape that read as a man until the scale resolved. Twenty feet of him and more, still person-shaped and wrong everywhere, translucent at the edges, too many joints working, and in his chest the Heart pulsing like a second sun.

“What the hell is that?”

“Kain.” Ryu said it flatly, a diagnosis with a name. “He used the Heart. The Tamois Heart. He’s been growing for the past hour.”

On the feed, the shape put a fist through the corner of a building without slowing down.

“Ruth and the team went after him,” Ryu said. “About thirty minutes ago.”

“They don’t have powers,” she said.

“I know.”

“They’re going to die.”

He did not argue. In a room full of bad information, that was the worst piece.

Her bare feet found the floor. The cold of it climbed her ankles and she stood up into the sway and let it pass through her.

“Ahdia—”

“I need the treatment.” She was already moving. “Now.”

Ryu got to the door ahead of her and put his back against it. “You can’t. The treatment isn’t stable yet.”

“Using your powers will—”

“Give me the treatment.”

The door opened behind him. Bourn came in wearing the suit she had stood in while five people ran at Kain without her, and she read the room in one pass.

“You don’t understand,” Bourn said. “You need eight more doses. Three weeks between each one. That’s six months.”

On the monitor, Kain took a sedan off the street by its roof and threw it through the front of a bank.

“I don’t have six months,” Ahdia said.

“You collapsed at the docks. Cellular degradation. You’ve been unconscious for twenty-six hours.” Ryu dealt the facts out with open hands, a man laying down cards he hated. “Ruth developed a treatment. We administered the first dose. You’re stabilized, but still severely damaged. Your cells need time to integrate each dose. If you take them too soon—”

“We’re out of time,” Bourn said.

She had come in to say no. The whole shape of her had come in to say no, and everyone in the room heard the sentence change sides. The cabinet stood against the far wall, and nobody stopped Ahdia from opening it. Eight autoinjectors sat in their foam like rounds in a magazine. She carried them to the bed and lined them up in a row and looked at them until they were only a procedure.

Then she closed her eyes and found the Seed and pushed. The light through the hospital gown went red. It had never been red. Blue was the whole history of it, blue at the warehouse, blue over the bridge, blue in her sleep. The cold stayed the same cold. Only the direction was new.

The first dose went into her thigh. The room dropped into slow motion around her, the alarms stretching into long low notes, and the cold poured outward from the Seed into every corridor of her.

“She’s accelerating!” The shout arrived pulled out of shape, low and long.

“She’s giving herself the three weeks!”

The second dose, the third. Her cells took the payment as fast as she could offer it, and the red haze came up at the edges of the room like weather.

Ryu had the tablet up against the glass of her speed, writing in block capitals:

RATIO = 1:2000

His fingers counted along with it, too slow and hopelessly behind her, and his pen tapped a metronome she heard as if from underwater. The fourth dose went in, and the alarms stretched past hearing.

TOO FAST = CELLS BURN

Somewhere beyond the red, Ryu went clinical. “Energy expenditure is exceeding regeneration. It’s a net loss.”

The fifth. The taps were fading steadily now, wall by wall, a man knocking from farther and farther away.

“It’s not like there’s a dial I can turn!” The shout went out of her into air gone thick. “Or a needle gauge to monitor!”

TRY 1:1500

The sixth dose, the seventh. The haze stopped being haze and became the color of the room, and somewhere out past it the tapping no longer mattered.

“Even at perfect ratio, she’s only getting fifty percent max,” Ryu said. He was talking to Bourn now. “It’s a zero-sum problem.”

SLOW DOWN

She never read it. The eighth went to her thigh, same press, same sound, and nothing went in. Her fist took it under the gown. The world came back at full speed, sound first, then the shaking in her hands. Fifteen seconds had passed on the wall clock.

“Did it work?” Ahdia said.

Ryu was already at the screen. “First few integrated. Last ones barely worked. Maybe thirty percent total regeneration.”

“Is that enough?” Bourn asked.

“I don’t know.”

Ahdia stood up in the hospital gown. Her legs held, barely, and she let nobody see what that cost.

“It has to be.”

She reached for the Seed and was gone.

The monitors flatlined over an empty bed. The cabinet hung open, its foam stripped bare. Ryu looked at Bourn, and Bourn looked at the place where a patient had been, and then they both turned to the feeds, because the feeds were where she would land, and waiting was the only procedure left.

* * *

The FAERIS drone’s light came first, dropping down through the smoke over the intersection, white and steady. Then space folded. It creased at the middle of Main Street, held for a breath and opened. Ahdia stood in the intersection. Hospital gown, bare feet on broken glass, hair loose, hands spread from her sides, and through the thin fabric the light of the Seed was blue again.

Kain froze mid-step at twenty-three feet, fist raised. His other hand stopped closed around the teenagers it had caught, and they hung inside the cage of his fingers, alive. The four giants in torn CCPD uniforms froze with him. Edgar with Victor in his grip. Ogden, his fist an inch from Leah. Philips and Orlansky mid-charge, boot soles off the ground.

Everything else kept moving. The smoke moved, the sirens moved, loose paper moved along the street, and the civilians ran the moment they understood that running worked again, pouring away down the side streets without looking back. The Go Squad did not run. Ben pulled Leah up off the asphalt without taking his eyes from the intersection. Victor stayed against a wall, an arm across his ribs. Tess stayed on her knees where Ogden's shadow had been. Ruth stood beside them, the bruise across her throat gone darker.

"Is that—" Ben said.

"Ahdia," Ruth whispered.

The name barely crossed the ruin of her throat, and it landed in front of four people who had grieved that name for somebody else's sake. Nobody asked her to repeat it. What they saw, and could not stop seeing, was this: the girl who should be dead, small at the center of a wrecked street, holding five giants still. Her arms shook. A thread of blood ran from one nostril, and she did not wipe it. The blue light beat through the gown with her heart, and every line of her body reported what the stillness was costing, and she paid it standing, and nothing she held moved.

Chapter 25

The drone came down through the smoke to her shoulder. “Go,” she said, and bumped it off with her hip. “Go on to your mama.”

It crossed the intersection and did not leave. It settled over Tess’s shoulder, close enough to touch. Tess went rigid.

Nobody spoke. Four people who had buried this woman stood in the wreck of Main Street and looked at her. Nobody looked away. She broke first. Ruth watched it happen: shoulders up, chin sideways, a hand rising in a wave.

“Uh . . . hi, guys, first-time caller, long-time fan, I’m Ahdia, Firas’s big sister.”

Firas was east of here with a bandage under his shirt and no idea, and Ruth had chosen that too.

Leah’s fist tightened in Ben’s sleeve. Ruth read the panic. “What the hell is going on? Are we dead? We’re dead, right?”

“Definitely not,” Victor said.

“Oh yeah? How do you know?”

“Because if we were dead, this would be a tropical beach and you’d be wearing . . .” He let his hand finish it slowly, a pass at the armor. “. . . not that.”

Ruth crossed to her, and every step gave less of the girl and more of the patient: bare feet on broken glass, sweat through the gown, the blue light beating faster than a heart. Blood ran freely from one nostril. Both hands shook badly. She should not have been vertical.

“We’re not dead,” Ruth said. Three words out of a bruised throat, and they cost more than three should. “How are you feeling? You took the rest of the treatment, didn’t you?”

“Yeah, what gave it away?”

“Well, you’re here at all for one.” Ruth watched the blood and not the face. “But couple that with this demonstration of this whole new ability . . .”

“Oh, about that, yeah, turns out I could do it all along.” She tipped her head at the giants without looking. “Fun fact, I’m not actually freezing Marky Mark and the Funky Bunch over there. I’m doing the other thing. Who knew?”

Ruth had let the jokes past and kept reading the patient. Now she understood what she had been standing inside. Kain was not stopped, and Edgar and Ogden and Philips and Orlansky were not stopped, and nothing over there was touched, and the difference was here, in her own arms and the four beside her.

“You’re speeding us up?” Tess said.

“Oh, yeah, look at you, Gloom Girl, penny for the pretty lady,” Ahdia said.

“So why haven’t you?”

“To be fair, I just figured out that I could about fifteen minutes ago.” She rocked back on her heels and made it look deliberate. “Would have gotten here sooner but I had to find one of those

guys to hitch a ride. They do a really good job of cleaning up their toys when they're not using them, over there at CADENS HQ."

The word landed in a street where nobody had heard it, and Tess picked it out of the air like a stone and came off her knees, and did not stop.

"You knew about her?"

"This whole time?"

"You've been working with CADENS."

"You knew. You've been lying."

"I—"

"How long?" Victor said. His hand slid down the rebar until it found balance. The knuckles went pale. "How long have you been lying to us?"

"Okay, whoa, hold on." Ahdia put both palms up, and the shake was visible. "This is not on Ruth. She didn't know about me until, like, two weeks ago? Maybe three? Time's been weird."

One day. The docks last night, the labs this morning. She let the wrong number lie where it fell. Correcting it would buy nobody anything. The honest answer was worse, because one day had been enough.

"And she's been trying to help me not die, so maybe we could table the whole trust-issues intervention until after we deal with Godzilla over there?"

"This isn't—"

"It's not her fault," Ahdia said. Blood had reached her lip. She wiped it with the back of her hand and looked at the hand. "CADENS approached her. She didn't ask for this. I'm the one who's been—"

She stopped. Then she picked it up again, evenly, and gave it to all four.

"Look, I know what you're thinking. Why didn't she tell you? Why all the secrets? And the answer is . . . me. I asked her not to. Because I'm Firas's sister, the one who couldn't even leave her apartment for dinner, and you guys—you're out here actually doing things. Saving people. Being, like, actual heroes."

The sway went through her and out again and she rode it standing, barely.

"And I didn't want you to know that someone like me had powers when you didn't. That felt . . . wrong. Like the universe screwed up the distribution or something. Like I didn't deserve it."

The nosebleed had found her chin, and nothing in the street moved but her mouth.

"But you guys? You've been doing this with no powers at all. Just . . . guts and gear and giving a damn. So yeah, I kept it secret. And yeah, Ruth helped me do that. At first it was about being painfully, audaciously, anti-social and my anger towards Firas but then it became—"

The sentence went out from under her. Her hand stayed up where the rest of it went.

"I started wanting you guys to look all enhanced and amazing because . . . because even without me, you guys are, well . . . super."

"We trusted you." Ben said it.

Four years of tactics rested on that sentence, and Ruth felt the floor tilt. "You still can—"

“Can we?” Leah was upright now, holding her ribs, and the second one came sharper. “Because it seems like you’ve been keeping a lot of secrets.”

Nobody was asking Ahdia anything. Ruth had been the voice these people went through doors on, and she felt them stop hearing it that way.

“We don’t have time for this!” Victor said. He was pointing at Ahdia, not at Ruth. Her knees were traveling, the blood came steadily onto the gown, and the light in her chest pulsed out of sequence and skipped. She smiled at them with red teeth.

“I can hold this,” she said. “But not forever. So if someone wants to, I don’t know, make a plan? That would be great.”

All four of them turned to Ruth. Nobody offered her anything. They looked at her because she built the plans, because nobody else was standing, and because a liar with a plan beat four honest people without one.

“Wait.” They had been treating the stillness as a wall. It was not a wall. Kain stood inside his own second like a photograph of a man, fist up, and they stood outside it for as long as she could give them. “So you’re saying we’re all moving at unimaginable speed while they stand still in normal time?”

Ahdia nodded, and the nod nearly took her down. Ben went to the giants and read the gaps quickly. Leah let go of her ribs slowly. Victor’s grip shifted until the weight sat right. Tess came last, because Tess had to carry her fury the whole distance to the same place, and it cost her.

“Then let’s run.”

Chapter 26

The asphalt gave her feet everything it had been saving up all night: cold, wet, and studded with small sharp things. She was barefoot in an intersection on Main Street, in a gown the color of a hospital's idea of calm. Blood came down her arm and onto the pale blue and spread there freely.

She watched it happen to the girl in the gown. That was the trick and it had never once failed her. You stand slightly to the left of yourself and you do the voiceover. The girl in the gown was in serious trouble, and somebody really ought to help her.

Kain stood twenty-three feet up and was not done. His skin had gone translucent, so the light of the thing sunk into his sternum came out through the whole torso, red sliding to amber and sliding back, a coal in a paper lantern. His bones moved while he stood still. They made the sound a house makes settling, sped up and turned up, and every so often the street got a little smaller around him. He had left "human" behind somewhere around the fifteen-foot mark.

Four of them waited at his heels in the ruins of CCPD uniforms. Ogden, with the scar running cleanly through his left eyebrow. Philips, thick through the neck, whose hands she had watched close on Ruth's throat on a monitor four hundred feet underground. Edgar, bald, knuckles already wet. Orlansky, the young one, eyes too wide for the work. Ryu had put their faces on a tablet and talked through them rapidly, and now here they all were, off the screen and out in the weather.

"Well," Kain said. The word arrived slowly, with a delay in it, like thunder that had to travel. "This is unexpected."

"Yeah," she said. "I've been getting that a lot tonight."

The two kids were out of the intersection. Somebody in black had carried them off during the run and she never saw who. Her hands shook badly enough to be interesting. She let them.

"You look like you escaped from psychiatric." His head tipped, and the movement traveled unhurriedly out to the far end of him. "Or possibly intensive care. Hard to tell with that fashion choice."

She plucked the gown out at the hip and gave it a small model's turn, badly.

"It's called 'hospital chic.'" The turn nearly put her on the ground. "Very in right now."

"She's delirious," Philips said. His hand had drifted casually to rest near his holster. "Blood loss. Look at her."

"I'm looking," Kain said. "I'm looking at the girl who should be dead. The one who took a bullet to the chest. Who fell three stories into an explosion. Who by all rights should be a smear on warehouse concrete."

"I got better," she said.

"Clearly." He let the word sit and then leaned heavily on the rest of it. "But not much better. You're barely standing."

While he was enjoying himself she read the roofs. Gloom Girl lay flat along the bank cornice with her chin on the stone. Battlea crouched behind the overturned bus, weight forward on her toes.

Night Knight had the fire escape above the pharmacy and a canister in each hand. Crimson Sable held a length of rebar low and easily in the alley mouth. Ruth stood at the corner in gear nobody in this city had ever seen, talking steadily into her collar, and all four of them moved when she spoke, and not one of them looked at her while they did it. Ahdia found that with her attention like a tongue finds a chipped tooth. She had absolutely no idea what she was looking at.

"I've had worse Tuesdays," she said. "There was this one time I tried to make pad thai from scratch and ended up setting off the smoke alarm for like, six hours straight. My neighbor called the fire department. Twice. This is maybe top five bad Tuesdays. Top three if you count that thing you're doing with your face."

"You're stalling," Kain said.

"Am I?" She rocked back onto her heels and stayed up, mostly. "I thought I was making conversation. You know, pre-fight banter. It's traditional. I've seen it in like, every action movie. The hero and the villain exchange quips. Usually the hero has better one-liners but I'm working with limited material here. Blood loss and exhaustion aren't great for comedic timing."

"You're no hero," Kain said.

"No," she said. "I'm really, really not."

It went by him like a breeze. He had come here to insult her and she had handed him the sentence cheerfully, and there was nothing in it for him at all. It was the truest thing she had said out loud in weeks.

The Seed was cold in her chest, as always. The other thing that arrived was warm, and it hurt worse.

Because he had stood in a room and told everybody in it that she had not made it, and then said the other part, the part about her being already dead inside, and she had heard all of it from behind a foam vault with her hand over her mouth. She had filed it away under closed, permanently. And here came the dent in the front quarter panel, faster than the street deserved, aimed at a thing the size of a church.

She kept her eyes where they were and did not let them travel.

"What are you?" Kain said. She gave him nothing, so he supplied it himself, generously. "A girl in a hospital gown who should be dead?"

"Something like that," she said. "I've definitely had better days. My feet are cold. This gown doesn't cover nearly enough. And I'm pretty sure I'm concussed. Or possibly having a stroke. Hard to tell the difference at this point."

She smiled up at him with red teeth.

"But you're about to have a really bad fifteen seconds."

Kain moved two fingers, and the four of them came.

Getting angry on purpose used to be work. Now the anger lay right there on the top of everything, and she picked it up like a dropped set of keys, and the street stopped.

Sound went first. Then the cold came up her forearms and set its teeth in her elbows, and it cost her more than the last one had, because it always did now.

She walked. She went in among them, past Edgar's shoulder, under Ogden's arm, into a forest of enormous men leaning into a charge and going nowhere at all. She moved Ogden's forearm gently, a few degrees left. She turned Edgar's hip fractionally, until his weight sat wrong. Orlansky she left alone, because the kid was already going to miss. Philips she barely touched, since Philips was carrying the most speed and the rest of it would take care of itself.

Getting back out of the way took longer than everything else put together. Then she let go.

Saturday morning, a bowl of cereal going soft: the anvil, the tunnel painted onto a rock face, the coyote arriving at a wall with a fresh idea. Four very large men ran into each other in the middle of Main Street and made a sound like a filing cabinet coming off a truck. Ogden went down under Edgar. Philips took Orlansky off his feet, and the two of them slid into the base of a mailbox and stopped there.

The cold left her elbows and went off to do damage somewhere less convenient. Her nose was running. She did not look at her hand afterward.

Kain came around slowly, a foreboding weather system coming around, and the fist that had been full of teenagers a few minutes ago came down at her out of the dark.

She stopped the street.

Then she walked out of the strike path, ten feet, fifteen, in no particular hurry, around a hydrant and past the bus, and stood there with her arms folded to keep her hands from being visible. Everything had gotten remarkably heavy. Her legs had opinions. She let go anyway.

The fist finished its trip and took a bite out of the pavement where she had been standing, and Kain's arm went in past the wrist. He stumbled forward onto a knee, and the whole block rang like a struck pipe.

Philips came up off the mailbox with his sidearm out.

"Stop—" Kain said, because nothing that size wants lead flying around the thing it is about to pick up.

She took the word out of the air along with everything else.

Getting the pistol away from a frozen man is mostly a problem of levers. She worked his fingers open one at a time, dropped the magazine into her palm and set it on the sidewalk, racked the slide, and let the round that came out of it hang there in the air like a wasp in amber. Then she put the empty weapon back into his hand, closed his fingers around it, and squared his grip up neatly like she was fixing a kid's hold on a bat. She stepped clear. She let go.

Click. Click.

Philips looked at the gun with the honest bewilderment of a man whose entire personality had failed him.

Then her body quit arguing.

The gray came in from the edges of everything, and the intersection went narrow and soft, and she was suddenly down on her knees with her hands sliding off them. Air everywhere. None of it useful. She was drowning standing up in a street that was full of the stuff.

Kain did not swing. That was the genuinely frightening part, that he had learned something. He came in close, folded down, and closed a hand around her middle and lifted her off the ground, and then he squeezed. Her ribs creaked and complained and something in there let go with a noise she felt more than heard. She reached for the cold and the cold was a long way off with the lights out.

“Not so clever now,” Kain said.

Something moved at the far end of Main Street, past the barricade of dead traffic. Headlights, low and quick, coming the wrong way up a street the whole city had agreed to leave alone. A gray sedan, civilian, with a front-quarter dent nobody had ever gotten around to fixing.

The headlights kept coming.

“You . . .” she said.

Kain leaned down to hear it, delighted.

“you . . . had . . . enough?”

The sedan jumped a ramp from broken asphalt and crushed into him.

She pushed. She knew this one now, like a stove you have already put your hand on: red, going forward, expensive past discussing. She had done it in a hospital bed and she had done it standing in this street, and never for longer than it took, and never inside a fist with her ribs coming apart, and never with somebody else to drag along with her, and never on this little. It went anyway. It took her and the car and the idiot driver and shoved all three of them out ahead of the world.

Everything held. Steam stood up off the crumpled hood in a shape that had no business staying put. Glass hung in the air in a spray, each piece with its own little light in it. Kain’s face was caught partway through working something out, mouth open, eyebrows on their way up. The Tanks lay scattered wherever they had put themselves. The hood was folded against his shin, and the whole tableau sat there being nothing but a photograph of the loudest moment of her life.

The impact had done one useful thing before the world quit. It had taken Kain forward off his heels, and the hand around her had gone loose in the same instant everything stopped, so the fingers stood there in stone, not quite closed. She worked an arm out, and then a shoulder. She braced both feet against the thumb and shoved, and the rib that had let go earlier told her about it in a voice she could not turn down, and then she was out of the hand and falling. The pavement came up and took her hands and knees. Glass stood around her in the air, unbothered, and cut nothing on the way down.

The job wasn’t done. The driver, whoever they were, she needed to get them before the impact force arrived. She got up slowly and climbed to the driver door and did a double take.

It was her brother. It was Firas.

Of course it was him. He wouldn’t miss a kaiju even if he were dying in a hospital bed.

She got a fist into her brother’s jacket through the open window and brought him with her. He came out of the car sideways and landed hard on pavement that had stopped caring about time, rolled once, and came up on his hands with a dead earbud swinging at his collar, looking at a world

where nothing dripped. He looked at the glass. He looked at the steam. Then he stopped looking at any of it, because she was standing there in a paper-thin gown, bleeding heavily.

And the voiceover cut out. She was not standing to the left of anybody now. She was in her own feet, on her own street, being looked at by her brother.

“Hey, Ahdia.”

“Hey, little bro.”

His mouth worked. There was a bandage showing at his collar and he was breathing wrong, and he was doing the thing Ruth does, running his eyes methodically over her ribs, her arm, her bare feet, filing injuries.

“You look—”

“Gonna stop you right there.” She held up a finger. “I just have a pet peeve when family you haven’t seen in a while immediately start with how fat or skinny you’ve gotten.”

“That’s not what I—” He stopped. He put a hand over his face and left it there, and when he took it down he had gone somewhere much worse. “I’m sorry. This . . . this is all because of me. I shouldn’t have come to your place, I should have just gone to the hospital.”

“I know,” she said.

She did not tell him it was okay, because it was not okay. What he had said in that room went through her like rounds through drywall and confirmed the whole case she had been building against herself since she was a kid. And he had driven his car at a kaiju anyway.

“We need to talk about it,” she said. She looked at the hanging glass rather than at him. “Later. When we’re with more polite company.”

“Later.” He nodded once, slowly.

“Later,” she said.

He was already pulling his jacket off, and then his shirt, and under the shirt was black armor, plates and matte panels and a harness gone shiny at the buckles from years of use.

“Why are you—”

“Habit.” He got the shoulder strap open with his teeth on one glove. “Wore it under my clothes. Just in case. Stupid, probably. But—”

“But you’re the guy who packs a go-bag,” she said. “Even when you’re benched.”

“Yeah.”

He got the last of it off and stood there in a t-shirt, thin, bandaged, a little ridiculous, holding out the only thing he owned that anybody had ever taken seriously.

“You can’t fight in a hospital gown.”

“Firas, you need—”

“I’m benched. You’re not.” He pushed it at her, and then he heard how that sounded and reached for something better, and what he came back with was a shrug and a small awful grin. “It’ll be loose. You’re smaller. But it’s better than nothing.”

She took it. It weighed more than she expected and smelled like her brother, sweat and cheap detergent and the inside of a gym bag. Lifting it hurt on the left side, low down, in a way that

arrived late and then stayed. She held it up at arm's length between them, considered it, considered him, and swung it down hard to slam it onto the frozen street.

She was already wearing it.

It sat too big in the shoulders, and the harness hung low on her hips, and there was a hard plate lying over the thing in her side that had let go, so that every breath now had to come in through it, and her feet were still bare on the cold pavement, and Firas made a sound like the beginning of a question and then did not ask it. Nobody explained anything. The street stayed stopped around the two of them, glass hanging, steam standing, everything patient.

"The team?"

"Positioned. Rooftops. Fire escapes. Ruth's coordinating." He was backing away toward the sidewalk with his eyes still on her, unarmored, wearing a t-shirt in a street with a monster in it, wholly untroubled by the arrangement. "Waiting for your signal."

"Okay," she said.

"Okay?"

"Yeah."

She took her air in small careful helpings while he crossed. He went into the doorway of the sandwich place across the street and put his back against it, and there was nothing between him and the rest of the night but a door frame and his opinion of her.

She walked out to the middle of the intersection, into the space between the man on his knees and the four on the ground, in armor built for somebody else, breathing shallowly around the left side of herself, and let the whole street go.

Sound came back in a wave. Steam broke, glass fell, and Kain finished the thought his face had been halfway through.

"Let's give them an opening."

She pulled a breath that hurt everywhere it went and put everything she had left into her lungs instead of her legs.

"No better place than here!"

And it came back off the roofs, the other half of it, screamed down at her from the cornice and the fire escape and the alley and the wreck of the bus, and the Go Squad came down off the buildings, all of them, yelling.

Chapter 27

They came off the buildings at him, four of them dropping out of four directions at once. One off the bank cornice, one off the fire escape above the pharmacy, one out of the alley mouth, one up over the roof of the dead bus. The fifth did not drop. She came in low across the pavement from the corner, at a dead run. The answer came down ahead of them, screamed raggedly and out of time with itself, the other half of whatever the girl had put into the air.

“No better time than now!”

Kain did not adjust his stance. Five people throwing themselves at something twenty-three feet tall priced out as suicide, and he had watched men buy it before, generally at the end and generally cheap.

The girl stood under it in black armor he had not seen her put on. It sat badly on her. Too wide at the shoulders, the sleeves eating her hands, the harness slung low, the collar gone black where the blood had run down into it. Her feet were still bare. Somewhere in the noise she had acquired a costume. He set it down without turning it over.

Then the drop stopped behaving like a drop. Between the second-floor windows and the pavement the four of them gathered speed the fall had never given them. The fifth ate ground at a rate no stride buys. And this time he could see where it was coming from. The girl swayed. Her hands shook inside the long sleeves, her jaw worked, and her breathing had gone shallow and quick and visible from forty feet away. Whatever this cost her, she was paying it openly. Then the Go Squad hit the street as blurs.

Battlea took Ogden at the hip like a car coming through an intersection, and Ogden left the ground. Crimson Sable landed on Philips with the rebar coming down two-handed, and the asphalt broke cleanly in a ring around them both. Edgar read Night Knight’s line and moved off it correctly, and Night Knight corrected mid-strike at an angle no shoulder should offer and caught him center mass. Orlansky got a guard up. Nightingale went through it as though it were a door somebody had left unlatched.

Gloom Girl hit nobody. She went out of the air halfway down, arrived neatly on the sidewalk beside a man in a t-shirt who had no business standing there, raised her middle finger at the whole intersection, and took them both out of it.

Four down. Five standing in a ring around the girl in the middle, and the girl had not thrown a punch.

“What are you?”

She gave him nothing. He watched her fail to answer and understood that she had nothing left to answer with.

Ogden came up out of his crater and Crimson Sable’s rebar found his temple on the way. Philips crawled toward the nearest pair of legs and went down under a low sweep, and Gloom Girl arrived on top of him out of clear air. Edgar surged at Nightingale and did not make three steps;

they closed on him before he had chosen his stride, Night Knight into a restraint hold, Crimson Sable following it in, the medic left standing behind them. Orlansky was last. The young one had watched all of it happen and swung wild anyway, and all five converged on him, each of them opening the next one's line. It was competent work. They were taking people down rather than killing them, and he found the care faintly sentimental.

Then it was over, and they were standing there breathing hard and bleeding in several places and alive. Ozone. Copper. Something burnt. Pavement dust hung over the intersection and would not settle.

The light came up out of Ogden first. Sickly green, the shade of the thing sunk in Kain's chest, and it left the body like marrow leaves a bone. Ogden's back arched off the asphalt, held, then went slack, and what lay there afterward was smaller than the man had been. The light crossed the pavement like iron filings crossing to a magnet. It hit Kain wet. It was organic, and it went in.

Philips, then Edgar, then Orlansky. Four streams converging on one body, and the air chilled as each of them passed.

He had cut the Heart and distributed the fragments himself. He had made four weapons out of four men and put them in the street to be broken open by whoever proved strong enough, and the Go Squad had done it beautifully. There was no pleasure in it worth the name. There was the flat satisfaction of delivery on a thing already paid for. The Heart came back together behind his sternum, whole.

Nightingale saw it before the others did.

"NO! STOP!"

Her arm was out toward Crimson Sable, who still stood over Philips with the rebar raised. There was nothing to stop. The light was already moving and it would move whether anybody swung again or not.

"You're feeding him!"

Somebody in the ring said the other thing, low, without lifting their head.

"We killed them."

He could not tell which of them it was. He did not much care to work it out.

The husks lay where they had been dropped, four sets of torn uniform with the men no longer in them. Before he had opened those men up they had been officers, with names and mortgages and wives who packed lunches. The Go Squad were looking at that now, and coming apart over it, and he watched a team lose the fight they had won three seconds earlier. It was inefficient of them. Grief is a luxury good, and they were buying it in the worst hour of their lives.

"Thank you," he said.

The words went out slowly over the intersection with weather in them. He meant them, and he was polite about it, because courtesy is the cheapest instrument in the case and he had never understood why a man would leave it shut.

"I was wondering how to reclaim those fragments."

He came up past twenty-five feet while they stood there. Twenty-eight. Thirty-one. The pharmacy sign went under his elbow and the second floor of the bank went under his ribs, thirty-five, thirty-eight, forty, and the growth ran on past the point where more of him did him any good. His skin had gone clear enough to read by. The bones stood in it, dark and shifting, and the Heart pulled at him harder than it had an hour ago, taking its fee out of the muscle nearest it. He had priced that before he ever put it in his chest. He had decided it was worth the fee.

Below him, in the middle of her people, the girl swayed. She was drowning in armor built for a bigger body, the sleeves over her knuckles, the collar dark and shining wetly, her bare feet planted apart on broken glass. She had made five ordinary people into weapons and thrown them at him, and every one of them was still alive down there. Nobody said the rest of it out loud. She had saved all of them, and she had fed him doing it.

Chapter 28

Her legs went out from under her without any negotiation. One knee hit the pavement, then one hand, and the cold came up through her palm and stayed. The suit hung off her in every direction, the sleeves over her knuckles. Her lungs burned, and the edges of the intersection had gone soft and gray, and she let them go.

The four of them lay where they had dropped. Ogden. Philips. Edgar. Orlansky. Torn uniform with nobody inside it, flatter than men are, the shapes all wrong. Somebody in the ring had said we killed them, and Ahdia had been standing in the middle of that ring, close enough to know. It was Gloom Girl. Gloom Girl had translocated out with Firas before any of this, and the sentence was still lying in the street without her.

Kain stood over all of it at forty feet and had not stopped growing. His bones cracked like gunshots as they went, one and then another, a sound with no give in it. Under the clear skin the Heart pulsed in his chest like a dying star, red into gold and back, unhurried. Battlea and Crimson Sable had backed off the husks and were looking up at him.

“We have to move.”

Ruth had her by the arm and was already lifting.

“Now. Before he—”

Kain moved first: the arm came up, the whole intersection went dark under it, and the fist came down like a building falling.

Ahdia reached for the Seed.

She went down into the cold place behind her sternum and asked it for the thing it had always given her, and nothing came back. She had spent it getting them here, on surviving the impact, on changing her clothes in a blink.

Something took her in the hip and the pavement she was kneeling on stopped existing.

The fist landed where she had been. It took the asphalt out in a dish, the cracks ran twenty feet, and shrapnel came off the rim in a flat sheet. A chunk of road the size of a basketball went past her head close enough to move her hair. Leah was half on top of her, elbow in her ribs, already pushing off, already gone.

“Scatter!”

“Don’t let him track patterns!”

Leah went left because she was fastest and drawing him was the job. Crimson Sable broke right. Night Knight was up the face of the pharmacy toward something with an angle.

Ruth got a fist in her harness and hauled her up.

“Can you run?”

Ahdia nodded. It was a lie and Ruth took it, because there was nothing else on offer.

“Keep moving!”

“Don’t stop!”

The hand came down at Leah and closed on air. She had changed direction a half step before it committed, derby instinct, reading the momentum of something enormous and taking the angle off it.

Crimson Sable came in under the ankle with the rebar two-handed, a swing that should have taken bone out of a man. It bounced. The shock came back up the bar into his shoulders, and Ahdia watched his hands open and shut on the metal.

“It’s not working!”

There was grief in it, out where anybody could hear.

“He’s too—”

The backhand was almost courteous: Kain did not look down and did not wind up. The arm came across and Crimson Sable left the street in a flat low arc, went into the second floor of the pharmacy thirty feet away, and brick came down after him, and Victor did not move.

“Victor!”

Leah was already turning, and turning the wrong way: toward him, out into the open, straight across the front of the thing they had all been running from.

“Leah, NO!”

Ruth’s scream changed nothing. The hand came down and Leah went under it, took the landing on her shoulder, rolled out of it and came up running without losing a stride, and got to him. She had a fist in his collar and his ribs were moving.

“I’m okay,” Victor said, and it took most of what he had left.

“I’m—”

Night Knight came in from the blind side and did not go at Kain. He went at them, full body, both arms, and took all three of them out of the radius in a tangle of limbs and gear while the fingers shut on empty road.

“Futile.”

The word came down over the intersection and the glass left in the pharmacy front hummed with it.

“You’ve already lost. You fed me. Made me whole. Now watch what that bought you.”

Ahdia lay where Ruth had put her and listened to the sentence land on the people it was about. Night Knight had his head down over Victor. Leah had both hands full of his collar and had stopped moving. Nobody answered it, and there was nothing on the street that could.

She reached again.

The Seed answered her this time, cold and thin, a flicker, a fraction of what it had been an hour ago, and she held everything she had out to it, and the intersection did not slow. Ruth was running and was not going to get there. None of them were going to get anywhere, and the hands were coming down over them, and Ahdia knelt in the road with her whole self open and nothing coming through.

Then the sky screamed.

The air arrived before the sound, a shove of displaced pressure up through the pavement into her knees, and something crossed above the rooftops faster than the noise it was making. It went into Kain's chest.

White, blinding, total, a small sun standing over downtown, and then the wave came out through the buildings and every window for three blocks let go. Forty feet of him hit the street like a falling building, and the road came up in a swell and put her down on her side.

She heard the boots before the dust gave them up, and then they came through it in a formation nobody had to think about, twenty of them, black kit and long guns, spreading around the crater and taking angles on a dead thing.

The man in front stopped at the lip and put two fingers to his ear. Ahdia knew him: she had sat across a table from him under four hundred feet of dirt, and he had been dry then.

"Overseer," Mack said.

"Target is down. Repeat, target is down."

The earpiece came back loud enough for Ahdia to hear it, a woman's delivery with the affect sanded off.

"Confirmed kill?"

"Confirmed," Mack said. He was looking into the crater when he said the rest.

"Kain is dead."

Nobody had asked him for what came next. He gave it anyway, in the tone of a man reading a report he already knows the end of.

"Overseer wanted authorization before engaging," Mack said.

"Pentagon wanted assurances. SecDef wanted contingencies. We stopped waiting."

Then he turned his head an inch toward the comm.

"Some things are more important than careers, ma'am."

Ahdia sat down in the road, legs splayed, breath going in and out too fast to do her any good, and looked across at the body in the crater.

Dead. They'd won.

A medic came at Ruth with a bag already open.

"Ma'am, we're here to assist with—"

"I'm a doctor. ER. I've got this."

Ruth did not look up from Ahdia's arm.

"Where's Firas? Where's Gloom Girl? Did they—"

"Safe," the operative said, checking his forearm.

"Translocated out before engagement. We tracked them to—"

The ground moved.

It was smaller than the blast and it kept time, spaced out and even, like a heartbeat, coming up through her tailbone out of the crater. Down there the body had gone into motion with nothing alive in it, the chest folding inward first, everything traveling toward the Heart.

"What the—"

Mack was already moving.

"Fall back!"

The formation came apart and re-formed twenty yards out.

"Everyone back!"

Forty feet of him went to thirty. The arms folded into the torso and the torso went on folding. Twenty, and the temperature fell off a cliff, and Ahdia could see her own breath in the middle of the street. Fifteen. Ten. Five. Then there was no body at all, only a point turning two feet above the crater floor, no bigger than a basketball, so dense the air bent going past it.

"What's happening?"

Ruth had both hands on her again.

"I don't know."

She was looking at it and pulling at the same time.

"But we need to move. Now."

Then it pulled.

The debris went first: glass, brick dust, a torn length of uniform, the rebar lying where Victor had dropped it. It all came off the road and went in and was not anywhere any more, each piece faster than the last.

"Singularity!"

"It's forming a singularity! Everyone out! NOW!"

Ahdia felt it take hold of her body. The suit rippled around her in a wind that was not wind, every fold drawn one way, and her hair went forward across her face. Ruth had her under both arms and was hauling the other way and losing, an inch and then another inch, boots skidding through glass.

"We need immediate evac! The artifact is collapsing into—"

Ahdia was not looking at the point any more, but past it, at the bank.

It was leaning. It did it so slowly that for a moment she could tell herself she had invented it, and then she could not. The windows went out of the upper floors in order, one row and then the row under it. The frame let out a sound she felt in her teeth. Steel does not scream. What came out of it was lower than that and longer, and it did not stop.

It was going to come down. It was going to come down across the whole intersection, and everyone still standing in it was underneath.

Chapter 29

The bank leaned another degree and went on making its sound, low under everything else on the street, a note with no end built into it.

The pull found her hair first. It lifted the loose ends off her shoulders and carried them forward across her face, gentle about it, and then less gentle. Her suit went next, every fold of it pointed one direction, the sleeves emptying toward the crater like sails.

Then the pavement gave up what was lying on it. Glass came off the road in a sheet and crossed the intersection at waist height. A parking sign tore out of its footing. Brick and grit and a torn strip of black uniform crossed the road and went into the point where Kain had compressed, turning two feet above the crater floor, and nothing came out the other side of it.

Her body went third, tipped at the hip and the shoulder, her weight sliding off her heels and onto the balls of her feet without anybody asking her.

"Everyone back!"

"Fall back! NOW!"

Mack had his people moving before the second word finished. Twenty of them came off the crater rim in one piece, backward, weapons up, boots working against a floor that wanted them the other way. Nobody ran. They gave ground like men who had practiced giving ground, backward and in order, and not one of them turned around to look at it.

Ruth had her arm.

"We need to move. Can you—"

The rest of it went under the bank. The upper floors let their windows go in order, one row and then the row beneath it, and the glass did not fall. It flew, all of it, sideways, into the point. The steel behind the glass made a sound she felt in her teeth. Then the whole face of the building came off vertical and stayed there, leaning, working out how it wanted to do this.

Ten stories of it, and every person on the street standing underneath.

She could see all of them from where she was. Leah had Victor half off the pavement with his arm across her shoulders. Night Knight was coming down the front of the pharmacy with one elbow locked against his ribs. Gloom Girl held position by the overturned bus, arms out from her sides, leaning back against the drag like somebody on the deck of a boat.

"Go," she said, and got both hands into Ruth's harness.

"What?"

"No. We're not—"

"GO!"

She shoved, and there was nothing kind in it, no measure in it at all. Everything left in her shoulders went into Ruth, and Ruth went back three steps and sat down hard in the glass.

"Get them out! All of them!"

"No. Don't you—"

Ahdia turned around and walked at the crater.

“Stop her!”

Ruth came off the glass in a dead run and got four strides. Then her feet stopped being hers. The pull took her at the hip and turned her, and she went down and caught the base of a parking meter with both arms and stayed there. Leah made it as far as the light pole and stopped for the same reason. To cross the last of that ground either of them would have had to let go of what they were holding on to.

“AHDIA!”

“Don’t you DARE do this!”

The walking got harder, not easier, and that was the part she had not planned for. The current wanted all of her at once. She would not go all at once, so every foot of it was work, the soles of her bare feet dragging over grit and broken glass, the cold coming up through them, the suit hammering flat against her body.

At ten feet the ground under her opened in a spiderweb, and she planted herself in the middle of it and stopped.

Arms wide. Right hand out at the point, left hand back at the city behind her.

She went down into the cold place behind her sternum and asked for the red.

It came out of her right palm and into the core of the thing, and it was not a beam and it was not a wave, it was permission. Whatever the thing at the center of the crater was doing, it could do it now. Whatever it had left to burn, it could burn all of it in one breath and be finished with the street.

The point brightened, and the ground under her jumped hard enough to take her off her heels.

It was not enough. It was drinking the road and it would take the bank next, and the red on its own was going to need longer than the building had.

So she opened her left hand and gave the city the other direction.

The blue went out behind her and wrapped forward, and she felt it close over the crater like a palm coming down over a struck match. The pull she had used her whole life, running as a shell around the acceleration, holding the edge of the thing still while the inside of it raced.

Both directions at once, through one body, in opposite hands.

The Seed could do it. That was the thing nobody had tested. The Seed could do it, and she was only the wire it came through, and the wire was not rated for this.

Her skin opened. The fissures came up both forearms and across her chest under the suit, splits with edges to them, and what showed inside was not blood. It was white. It had structure in it, and it went down further than a body goes.

She heard herself screaming and could not feel it in her throat.

Her vision came apart into panes, and at the edge of every pane there was a corridor with doors in it. She shut her eyes and refused it. It stayed where it was, behind her eyes, waiting.

Then there were hands over her hands.

Warm ones, human ones, and she knew before she turned her head, because there was one person on this street who would cross the last ten feet of it to hold on to her instead of pull.

“I’m not losing you again!”

He had both palms over her knuckles, pushing her hands out further into the shapes she was holding them in, and he had nothing on him. No Seed. No field. Skin, and everything he had.

The cracks came up his forearms, the same splits, the same white underneath.

“No—”

“You can’t—no Seed—you’ll—”

He did not move, and nothing in his hands changed.

“Let go!”

“Firas, let GO!”

“No.”

“We do this together.”

He said it without strain, and that was how she knew the argument was already over, because he had decided it somewhere back before he ever touched her, and he had never once reopened a thing he had decided.

Her left hand knew what to do before the rest of her caught up. It went to her hip, to the thing that had been riding there since the medical bay, the one she had faked, the one that had gone into her palm instead of her leg. It came free into her fingers. It was for him. It had always been for him.

She could not turn her hand over.

The fingers were going. She could see the crater through them, and the injector sat in a hand that was in more places than one, falling and floating and lying still, all of it at the same time, and no version of her hand could close on every version of it.

“Firas—”

Then the street was gone.

The corridor was not bleeding in at the edges any more. It was all of it, floor and ceiling and both directions, and the doors ran away from her past where seeing stopped, and every one of them was lit a different color.

She looked for her hands and there were no hands. There was light in the shape of where she had been, and inside the light there was structure, depth going down through her that had nothing to do with meat, time laid open along it, older versions of her overlapping the present one like frames of film stacked out of order.

No mouth. No lungs. Nothing to scream with and nothing that needed to.

The doors were lives, and she knew it without being told. Behind one of them was an apartment she never left, a couch, a television, forty years of that and nobody hurt by it. Behind another was a warehouse floor and her own body cooling on it. Behind another, close, standing open a crack: Firas alive, and no Ahdia anywhere in it at all.

Something turned its attention on her.

It was at the far end of the corridor and it was directly in front of her, and both of those were true. It had never been human. It had never been anything that had to work its way up to being what it was.

It looked at her, and she looked back, and there was recognition in it going both directions, arriving with no words attached to it.

She had questions, all of them, everything she had wanted to ask since the warehouse.

It acknowledged her. Then it took its attention elsewhere, and whether that was dismissal or whether it was permission she could not tell, and nothing in the corridor was going to tell her.

Then something took hold of her and put her back.

It was violent, and it arrived all at once: she was torn open and reassembled inside the same instant, the corridor shattering, dimensions folding down and down, everything she had been able to see crammed back into three directions and one clock.

Back into a body. Back into flesh, which hurt, and weighed something, and had edges.

Air went into lungs she had forgotten she owned. Pavement came up under her knees, cold and solid and stupid with reality.

Firas was inches from her face.

There was a sharp pain low in her abdomen, bright and specific, and she looked down. The autoinjector stood against her with his thumb still on the plunger.

He looked up at her, still smiling, and there was nothing in his face that was fighting anything.

Ruth had both hands locked on the arm that had come back far enough to hold, her face pulled out of shape with it, screaming something the roar took before it got anywhere. Behind Ruth: Victor with both arms around Ruth's waist and all his weight back. Leah holding Victor. Ben anchoring Leah, boots braced, shoulders down. Tess at the end of it with her arms around Ben and her legs jammed against the overturned bus.

All of them hauling. All of them on the wrong side of the pull and refusing to be on any other side of it.

They had come for her, all of them, and nobody had asked her first.

"NO!"

She got a hand on his wrist and tried to tear it off the injector, and she tried to stand, and the chain let her do neither.

"Ahdia, we can't—the pull—"

He was still smiling.

His mouth moved, and she heard him. The roar stayed out at the edges somewhere, and the words came in under all of it, close and unhurried, arriving in her before they had any distance to cross.

"Oh hey," he said.

"I knew you were in there somewhere."

"Firas, please—"

The cracks went up his neck and across his jaw and the light came through them from inside, more of it every second and less of him.

Nothing dragged him. He moved, and the space he was standing in shifted over and took him along with it, and his feet never left the ground so much as the ground stopped being where he was.

He kept his eyes on her the whole way.

At the edge he looked back once.

Then he went in, and the light and the energy and all of it, everything that had ever been her brother, went down into a space smaller than a fist and was absorbed.

Gone.

The point pulsed once more, brighter than the street could stand, and then it was not there. The red had finished what it was doing. Whatever had been in the middle of it to burn was burned.

Air came in from every direction at once to fill the hole where the thing had been, and the pressure hit like a wall going past, and everything the intersection had put in the air came down and clattered and rolled and stopped.

The bank groaned. It held. Then there was no sound anywhere.

The chain came apart. The line of them went down at once, people who had been pulling against something that stopped existing, and they landed in a heap in the glass and lay there breathing.

Ruth had not let go of her arm. She had not let go of it once, and she used it now to drag Ahdia into the middle of the pile, into the elbows and the knees and the shaking, and somebody’s hand closed on the back of her neck and stayed.

Ahdia sat in the center of all of them and let them hold on.

Across the intersection, where the crater had been, there was nothing. No body. No mark on the ground except the scorch, and the scorch was going pale at the edges already.

She was alive because he decided she would be.

She never got to say goodbye.

Chapter 30

The command center glass ran floor to ceiling, and held the cold of four hundred feet of rock behind it. She put her forehead on it. The fog came up around the print of her skin, thinned, went, and she made another one and watched that go too.

He came up on her left and stopped a polite distance short of her shoulder.

“You holding up?” he said.

“I’m standing,” she said.

“That counts for something.”

“It does.”

His reflection stood in the glass beside hers with a tablet in it he was not reading. Twelve hours of debriefing had worn the Dr. off his name somewhere in the middle of the night, and neither of them had gone back for it.

“Overseer wants to see you. When you’re ready.”

“How’s the team?”

“Checked out clean. No temporal anomalies, no residual Seed energy, no cellular degradation.”

She kept her eyes on the glass and let that sit where it landed.

“Victor’s arm is in a sling but that’s from the pull, not the temporal forces. They got lucky.”

Luck. She turned that one over, found nothing in it she could use, and put it down.

“Let’s get this over with.”

Bourn had not moved a chair. Same desk, same wall of nothing behind it, same woman who had sent her downtown alone and then written it up as a result.

“Auerbach. Have a seat.”

She sat. The chair was still too low for the desk, and she was still not going to mention it.

“How are you recovering?”

“Fine, just dandy.”

“Good.”

Bourn squared a folder she did not open. “I’m very sorry for your loss. I wanted to make sure I told you that.”

“Sure,” she said.

“Thanks.”

It came out flat and she let it stay flat. Sympathy from this desk arrived stamped and dated, like a form with a box on it that had needed ticking.

“That was quick thinking yesterday,” Bourn said.

“Using opposing temporal forces to burn out the Tamois essence while containing the collapse. Impressively, you did it on your own.”

The cold went through her fast and went out again. “I had the Go Squad,” she said.

“They formed the chain. Pulled me back. They almost died doing it.”

“Of course,” Bourn said, and moved along the page.

“They held their ground against a Terminus-level gravitational anomaly. Unarmed. That takes remarkable courage.”

She saw where the road went and got out in front of it. “It probably shouldn’t give you ideas,” she said.

“It just happened to work out this time. They used timing and positioning. Next time, they die.”

“And yet, you let them help. That took guts. Leadership. How did you know the temporal acceleration wouldn’t tear them apart?”

There was a version of this in every workplace comedy she had ever watched, the little room with the chair and the camera and somebody explaining themselves to nobody at all. She kept her hands in her lap.

“Oh, you know. Most of what we do is guess and theorize because cataclysm science is still in its nascence.”

“Yes, it is.”

“I guessed,” she said.

“The Seed was channeling through me, not them. They were pulling on flesh and bone, not exotic energy. As long as they stayed outside the acceleration field’s direct path, physics would mostly apply.”

Bourn did not write any of it down, and that was worse than a pen moving. “That’s a hell of a shot in the dark. And your brother—”

“Don’t.”

She heard how it came out of her. She did not go back for it.

“Don’t analyze that.”

Bourn let the silence run its whole length. Then she opened the right-hand drawer, set something on the wood, and pushed it across.

It was a badge. Silver, a cracked shield, the agency’s letters around the rim, and under them the name they had issued her and she had never once answered to in her own head.

“It’s yours if you want it,” Bourn said.

“I can’t use my powers anymore. The Seed’s dormant. Maybe permanently.”

“We don’t value that nearly as much as we value what you bring to the table regardless. Your methods are not CADENS ways of doing things, but that’s where you’d be an asset.”

She picked it up. It had weight. More than the size of it promised. A whole life came attached: a desk, a clearance, a door with a number on it, a folder walked in every morning for the rest of it.

She set it back down on the wood. She took her hand away. “I’m flattered,” she said.

“But I’m ready to go back to my life. The couch has been booty calling me.”

“Let me know if you ever change your mind. Until then, I trust you can keep CADENS under your hat.”

“It’s not like you won’t have FAERIS tracking me anyway.”

“We have no reason to monitor you anymore, Ms. Bacchus.”

Filed and closed and shelved with the assets that had stopped producing. She stood and put her hand out. Bourn took it. The grip was dry and short and correct.

“It’s been a pleasure and a privilege,” she said.

“One last thing.”

Bourn had not let go yet. “How close did you come to draining all of your life force yesterday?”

Behind her eyes there was a corridor with doors down both sides of it, lit in colors she had no words for, and a thing at the far end that had turned its attention on her and then taken it somewhere else. She could put all of that on this desk. It would go into a folder with a review date and it would belong to them, and then she would sit here while a stranger explained it back to her.

She smiled instead, the one she used on cashiers, and got her hand back, and went out.

The intercom clicked behind her before the door swung shut. “Please send in Dr. Ryu,” Bourn said.

“Yes, ma’am,” the voice on the intercom said.

* * *

“Welcome to Carl Tucker Tonight,” the anchor said from the TV. Nobody had turned the television off in a day and a half. It ran on the far wall over the fireplace nobody used, throwing a man in a good suit across four exhausted people and a coffee table covered in gear they had not put away. “When the nation’s first response to prank calls from some yahoos with too much time on their hands is to scream like chicken little that the sky is falling, we have to wonder what kind of leadership we have currently steering the ship. Just because officials have a hint of something possibly happening, in this case a supposed critical gas leak in the city’s center, all of Caledonia gets completely evacuated? The National Guard gets called in? Where were they while crime has been running rampant and overwhelming our city’s noble police force . . . ?”

Ruth reached over and killed the sound. The man went on talking into the carpet.

The gear on the table was theirs again: ham radios with tape on the battery doors, a coil of line, black cloth washed so many times it had gone the color of weather. The armored cases had gone back down the elevator that morning with two men who signed for them.

“I wish they let us keep the suits,” Victor said.

“Lot of good it did you,” Leah said.

“My arm might have been taken clean off without it!”

“We don’t need them,” Ruth said.

“Right,” Tess said, and turned a radio over in her hands.

“We already have ‘uniforms.’ Still . . . being bulletproof . . .”

Ruth put her palms on the table’s edge. There was a way to walk them up to this, and she had no fuel for the walk.

“I mean we don’t need them because we’re done,” Ruth said. “The Go Squad. It’s all over.”

Tess stopped turning the radio. “What? Why?”

“Guys . . . come on. Do I have to spell out why?”

“We have the proof to expose the cops,” Ben said.

“And my consumer advocacy group has filed a lawsuit against the money we paid to the Kain PAC,” Victor said, and shifted the sling with his good hand.

“Ahdia may not get her money back but neither will Kain. That money will get frozen.”

“And?”

Nobody answered that, so she did. “You guys know Kain is no worse off than before, right? He’s already rebuilding his mansion. His campaign is just rolling right along. What we do . . . what we’re done with now is and has been insignificant.”

“When we expose the Police Chief, it’s gotta connect to him, though,” Ben said.

Victor shook his head. “Wrong,” he said. “Ruth’s right. It’ll connect to the PAC. His hands will be clean.” Victor said it to the table, because he had gotten there ahead of the rest of them and had been hoping to be wrong.

“And what about Ahdia?” Tess said.

“We haven’t seen her since yesterday. Since downtown. Where is she? She just sends me access to her penthouse and bank account and doesn’t make contact? No, there are too many reasons we need to keep laying low. The Go Squad is too dangerous. Anyway, we’re not the Go Squad without Firas. He started all this. It was always his.”

Leah had not moved through any of it. She sat forward now with her elbows on her knees.

“Ruth . . .”

“What?”

“You’ve been holding us together,” Leah said. “Since it happened. Since he—”

Leah stopped and took a different road at it. “You’re the one who made sure we all got out. You organized the chain. You’ve been carrying us.”

“Okay,” Ruth said.

“Then listen to me now . . . this world . . . doesn’t need us. We’re just a bunch of crazies running around, hopping around rooftops in our pajamas in the middle of the night. And we just lost—”

The name went out from under her. She stood in it. Hands still flat on the table, she made herself take the next breath through her nose.

“We just lost Firas. Yesterday. He’s gone and that’s—”

She got the rest out level, because there was a thing to say and saying it was work and work she could do.

“That’s as much of a price I’m willing to pay to keep doing this. I can’t lose any of you, too.”

“You won’t,” Ahdia said.

She was in the doorway with her hands in her coat pockets. There was a duffel bag on the floor at her feet, packed and zipped, sitting there like something that intended to stay.

* * *

He fixed his tie outside the door, which was a thing he did before every meeting on this floor and had never once helped.

“Dr. Ryu, come in,” Bourn said. “Have a seat.”

“Are you anxious, doctor?”

“No,” Ryu said. “Why? Do I seem anxious?”

“It’s why I asked,” Bourn said.

“Well . . . I thought maybe you were calling me in here to admonish me for letting Auerbach leave the facility early.”

“No, I understand why you did.”

Bourn turned her monitor so he could see the column of medical panels on it. He knew the shape of that column. He had signed the top half of it himself.

“But we need to discuss what happened with the treatment protocol.”

“Ma’am?”

“She lied to us.”

“The eighth treatment. The one she told you she’d completed before leaving the facility.”

He finished it for her. “She didn’t take it.”

The room stayed where it was. He put his hands on his knees.

“Medical analysis confirms she left at approximately one-third cellular recovery. Far below combat readiness, let alone channeling opposing temporal forces through her body.”

“She walked into a Terminus-level event critically compromised. It’s a miracle she’s alive.”

He put it against what she had told him in the corridor and it came out where it had to. She had said the eighth was in. She had said it with her sleeve already down, and then walked past him into the worst hour of the city’s life.

“That was . . . tactically unsound,” he said.

“It was reckless. And effective.”

Bourn let that stand a moment, then closed the panels. “Which brings me to the second issue. Kain.”

“I’m sorry, ma’am. I thought—downtown, the singularity—”

“You saw the press conference this morning?”

“I was dealing with equipment inventory,” Ryu said.

She turned the monitor the rest of the way around. A podium, flags behind it, a man with heavy rings on both hands looking gravely into the middle distance.

“—tragic incident involving what appeared to be an experimental weapon. We believe this was an attempt by criminal elements to impersonate me and destabilize my campaign. I was, thankfully, nowhere near downtown at the time. The authorities are investigating—”

“He’s spinning it. Claims the entity at the singularity was a lookalike. Some kind of bioweapon or cataclysm construct.”

“That’s . . .”

He got up out of the chair and sat back down in it. “That’s absurd. We have footage. Thermal signatures. Energy readings from the Tamois Heart in his chest.”

“And he has lawyers. And a story that doesn’t require the public to believe in cosmic artifacts and temporal singularities.”

“We can’t touch him. Not officially.”

She took a sheet off the folder and turned it face up between them, and he had seen that seal maybe twice in three years.

“The authorization,” Ryu said. “The authorization that never came.”

“I requested executive clearance to intervene six hours before Auerbach went downtown. Do you know when I received it?”

He did not. “Forty-seven minutes ago,” Bourn said. “Fourteen hours after the event concluded. With a note thanking us for our ‘patience and restraint during the review process.’”

Something in him went cold and stayed there. “They wanted us hamstrung.”

“They wanted plausible deniability. If Auerbach failed, no connection to CADENS. If she succeeded, no political fallout from officially acknowledging cataclysm threats.”

“Either way, Kain walks free. We’re left cleaning up gravitational anomalies and explaining to city officials why downtown looks like a meteor strike.”

“So what do we do, ma’am?”

“We document everything. We build the file. And we wait.”

“For what?”

“For Kain to make a mistake. For the authorization to mean something. For whoever’s pulling strings above us to realize that threats like this don’t go away just because we pretend they don’t exist.”

She squared the sheet with the edge of the desk and did not look up from it.

“In the meantime, we do our job. Monitor cataclysm activity. Track the Seed-bearers. And hope that next time, a depressed girl with time powers and a death wish isn’t our only line of defense.”

* * *

The duffel stayed by the door a long while as everyone talked at once. Victor wanted to know how she had got up here, and Tess wanted to know if she had eaten, and Ben stood up and then had nowhere to go with it. Ahdia let all of it run at her.

“Guys,” Ahdia said. The room came off the boil. “I just wanted to say . . . thank you.”

“You guys saved my life yesterday. Downtown. The singularity.”

“When I was channeling those opposing forces, when I went . . . somewhere else . . . you pulled me back. Formed that chain and hauled me out of a collapsing dimension.”

“Even without me helping you in the background, you guys are real, genuine heroes. You inspired me to get off the couch and do something worth a damn. At first, I thought it was just to prove to Firas that I wasn’t a screwup. I’ve learned so much about you guys and about myself since

then. And what I've learned . . . is that this city needs us. This world, this universe, this dimension and all others. Between the corrupt cops, to Kain and the people who support that madman, and things happening that people don't know about, cataclysms that either provide unthinkable advances for humanity or threatens it entirely. I know I can't go back to my life the way it was before you guys but you're the only family I have and my family is unbeatable."

Leah put both hands over her face and left them there a second. "How can we say no to that?"

"We don't," Ben said.

"We keep up the fight. We stay vigilant. We stay ready."

"And we help the people who need it the most," Victor said.

"Because there's no one but us," Tess said.

Then all four of them turned and looked at the woman with her palms still flat on the table, and Leah dropped her hands.

"This doesn't work without you, boss," Ahdia said.

Ruth looked at the muted television, and at the gear, and at the girl in the doorway who had gone somewhere yesterday and come back with a bag.

"If we do this," Ruth said, "we start over. Build it up from the bottom because we're not just beating up muggers and getting old ladies safely across the street anymore."

"We need to be ready for cataclysms, cops and Kain," Ruth said.

Victor got his good arm around Ahdia's neck and pulled her in and held on.

"Oh, my," Leah said. "So . . . ?"

Ruth put her teeth in her lower lip and kept them there, and the room let her have the whole length of it.

* * *

Sunset went across the city sideways and put five long shadows down the gravel of the highest roof in it.

All of them were in the matte black armor, cut to their measurements, the same suits that had come off them after downtown. Ben had his old vest on over his. Leah had the pads she skated in strapped over hers. Tess had her hood up. Victor had rebar taped at one end. Ruth had a harness she had rebuilt twice with her own hands. Thirty blocks south, forty feet of nothing hummed on a residential roof and threw no shadow at all.

"All clear," Ahdia said in their ears. "Happy hunting."

"Copy," Ruth said.

She went to the ledge, put a boot up on it, and turned around.

"This is it," Ruth said. "Yesterday, we lost someone. Today, we keep going. Because that's what Firas would've wanted. Because people still need help. Because we're the Go Squad, and we go when nobody else will."

Nobody made a sound. The wind came up the face of the building and moved the loose ends of everything they had on.

“It’s not just Caledonia anymore. Not just muggers and corrupt cops. It’s singularities and cosmic entities and things we don’t have names for yet. No better place.”

“No better time,” they said back to her.

“You got it, Ahdia?”

“Everyone’s in position,” Ahdia said. “Ready when you are.”

Ruth stepped up onto the ledge. Arms out. She went off it backward.

The others came after her in order, four seconds apart. They had drilled the spacing on a stairwell in a school with no roof access at all. The wings caught and hardened. The four of them fanned out over the grid, north and west and two south, and the city came up like a floor rising to meet them.

She flew her lane down the avenue, the streetlights coming on underneath her in a wave. She tucked at the last. She flared. Her boots came down on a gravel roof across from a corner store with its door standing open and a man inside it holding a bag.

Then the gravel let go of her. An inch, maybe. Her heels came up off it. They hung there. Then they settled back down. There was nothing in her hands, no cable, no wing out, no reason for it anywhere in the equipment she was wearing.

Thirty blocks south, a machine that belonged to nobody hummed on a roof.

“Thank you,” Ruth said into the radio, and went over the parapet.

“Go get ’em. I got your back.”

Ahdia sat in the middle of a horseshoe of monitors she had no clearance to touch, in a machine she had taken out of a hangar without filling in anything, wearing a coat and socks and holding a cigarette she had not lit.

Down there they had a whole building for nights like this one. They would log it, and file it, and wait for the right signature to come through the right channel, and there was a man on the third monitor backing out of a corner store with a bag in his hand.

Nobody down there was going to get to him tonight.

Epilogue

“—and I want to assure the good people of Caledonia that I was nowhere near downtown during this tragic incident.”

The lights were low and warm, and set where he had asked, no shadow under the eyes. Grief photographs badly. Steadiness photographs well, and steadiness in a man who has been attacked photographs better than anything money can otherwise buy.

“We believe this was an attempt by criminal elements to impersonate me and destabilize my campaign.”

He let a beat go, because the room wanted one. “The authorities are investigating. I have full confidence in our law enforcement and our intelligence agencies to get to the bottom of this terrorist attack.”

Thirty cameras. The polling would come in overnight and it would be good, and the good would be worth more than the mansion, which was insured.

“That’s all for tonight. Thank you.”

The aides took him off the riser and down a hall and into a service elevator, and the doors closed on the noise and cut it off like a switch. At the bottom of the building a man in a gray uniform looked at a screen and stepped aside.

“Clear,” one of the aides said into his earpiece.

Then a second elevator, which went down. Past the garage. Past the mechanical floors with their pipes and their painted numbers. Past four levels that appear on no drawing filed with any office in the city. Forty-seven seconds, lobby to bottom. He had counted it once, back when this part still made him nervous, and had not needed the number since.

The corridor at the bottom was seamless white, with no doors in it, and the sensors sat in the walls where the seams would have been. His shoes made no sound. He had priced this corridor. It came in over. Worth it.

The tank room hummed at a pitch you felt in your teeth. Rows of them, glass and fluid and a soft green light coming up from below, and in every one of them a body floating with its chin down and its hands open. A boy of nine. A young man with hair. Himself at forty, at fifty, at the weight he carried now and at a weight he had not been in twenty years. All of them asleep. All of them paid for.

Halfway down the second row a cylinder stood open and dry, the cradle empty, the number stenciled at eye height. Forty-seven. An acceptable loss. The accounting on it was clean.

“You look tired,” a woman’s voice said.

She was standing at the end of the row and she had not been there a moment ago. White coat, no badge on it, no age on her at all, and the proportions of her a degree off in a direction he had long ago stopped trying to put a word to.

“Forty-seven was our best integration,” he said.

“The Tamois Heart had fully bonded. Years of work. Gone.”

“And yet you’re here.”

“That’s the point of redundancy.”

“I know the point.”

He looked at the empty cylinder and not at her. “I’m living it.”

“Are you?”

She came down the row without hurrying. “Forty-seven thought he was special too. Thought the Heart made him more than a vessel. Look where that got him.”

“How long until we can reintegrate a Heart?”

“We have three more in storage. We can begin the bonding process within a week.”

“But that’s not what you should be worried about.”

“What should I be worried about?”

“Agent Auerbach saw Bellatrix.”

The hum went on around them. He took his hands out of his pockets and put them back.

“During the singularity?”

“According to the readings CADENS picked up, yes. She transcended. Briefly. Made contact with higher-dimensional space.”

“She saw the hallway.”

“That’s not possible. The Seed was dormant, we made sure—”

“Nothing is ever certain with the Seeds. That’s why they were scattered in the first place. To see what would happen. Who would find them. What they’d do with them.”

She stopped in front of the empty tank and looked into it as though something were still in there.

“Bellatrix doesn’t interfere. She observes. But she acknowledged Auerbach. That means something.”

“What does it mean?”

“It means the girl is more important than we thought. It means her death might have consequences we can’t predict.”

“It means we proceed carefully.”

He had a file on the girl. It was thin and it was cheap and it had a line through it as of yesterday afternoon.

“The plan was always to eliminate her once the Seed went dormant.”

“Plans change.”

She said it as an item already decided in a room he had not been invited into. “Focus on the election. Win the presidency. That’s your role. Let me worry about the girl.”

The door took her and closed, and the corridor beyond it made no sound.

He stood where he was, in the hum, among the rows of himself, every one of them asleep and waiting to be worn.